

NOT A POTATO

FROM THE AIR



ANDRIES J. GREYLING

Chapter 1 — Descent Over Gold

The Cessna came in low and the LENS had the door off, harness biting, the wind a solid hand on the side of the face. Below: nothing. Then everything.

The pampa unrolled the way a held breath releases. Dun and dun and dun, the colour of a thing left in a drawer for a thousand years, and then — there — a line. Arrow-straight, pale against the dark, running away from the aircraft toward a horizon it would not bother to reach because it simply went on. The LENS stopped breathing the way you stop breathing in front of a thing that does not need you. The hands knew what to do without consultation. Shutter. Shutter. Bracket the exposure, because at this hour the desert lies to the meter, all that reddish iron-oxide skin throwing back a light that read warmer than it was.

“Two thousand feet,” the pilot said into the headset. “You want lower, I go lower, but the figures, they like this height. From the ground —” he lifted a hand off the yoke, tipped it, *who knows*.

That was the thing nobody had told the LENS properly, though everyone had said it: from the ground you got a stripe in the dirt. From here you got a hummingbird the length of a soccer pitch, its beak a single unwavering stroke aimed at a point the eye wanted to follow and couldn't. The bird only existed up here. It had been made for an eye that was not yet supposed to have been able to climb this high.

The crew were arranged through the little cabin like luggage that argued. Behind the LENS, the hydrology-reader had a tablet open and a topographic overlay glowing on it, and was not looking at the

figures at all. Looking instead at the *between* — the dry channels, the ghost of old water, the faint creased darkening where the plain remembered being wet. A finger moved across the screen, slow, tracing something that wasn't on the map yet.

"There's a spiral," the hydrology-reader said, not to anyone. "Two o'clock. It sits in a low. You see how the ground darkens into it?"

"I see a spiral," said the LENS, because that was true and the rest wasn't, yet.

"It sits in a *low*."

"Noted." Shutter.

They banked. The horizon swung up and showed Cahuachi — adobe mounds, sun-coloured, the old cult centre brooding at the western edge like furniture under a sheet. Beyond it the long lines fanned out across the plain, dozens of them, hundreds, converging on points and ridges, and for a second the whole pampa looked less like a desert and more like the back of something enormous that had been *written on*. Trapezoids opened like throats. A figure with a tail. A pair of hands.

It was, the LENS would have admitted under oath, the most beautiful thing the camera had ever been pointed at, and the LENS had been pointed at a great deal that wanted to be called beautiful and was only loud.

Down on the ground, a woman in a dust-pale field jacket watched the plane and did not shade her eyes, because she had been watching planes come over this pampa her whole life and knew exactly where the sun would be.

She was Cahuachi-born. Her grandmother had been Cahuachi-born. She had spent eleven field seasons on her hands and knees out here with a soft brush and a string grid, and she could tell you the difference between a line laid by the Paracas and a line laid four centuries later by the Nazca by the *width of the cleared margin* and the way the displaced stones were stacked at the verge, and she had told that difference to perhaps nine people in her life because nine people had asked the right way.

Two outfits arriving in one week. She had watched the other one set up yesterday — the consortium, German-Peruvian-American, a logo on the side of the cases, drones in foam, a young man with very white shoes who had asked her, politely, where the *most undocumented sector* was, as though she would hand him the last unbrushed corner of her grandmother's house. She had pointed him toward a sector she had finished mapping in 2019 and watched him thank her.

This second outfit came in a rented van with a dented bumper and a photographer hanging out the side of a small plane. Different animal. She knew the photographer's name; everyone who had ever opened a magazine knew the photographer's name. She'd seen the famous picture — the one from above a flooded delta, the water making a hand. The man saw the world from up there and was very good at it. She wondered if he could read the ground at all, or only the *shape* the ground threw at the sky.

The plane straightened, found the strip, came down in a long flat skid of dust. She walked toward it without hurrying.

On the ground the heat was a different country. The LENS climbed down on legs that hadn't quite landed yet, ears still full of engine, and the silence after the propeller stopped was the loudest thing about the place. No wind. None. The pampa was one of the stillest surfaces on the planet — the guidebooks said twenty minutes of rain a year, and the LENS hadn't believed it until standing in it, in air that did not move, where a footprint would sit for a season because nothing came to erase it.

"You're the photographer." The woman had arrived without seeming to cross the distance. She put out a hand, dry and strong. "I'm your contact. I work the lines."

"We were told an archaeologist."

"That too." A small flat smile. She glanced at the crew unfolding from the van, at the hydrology-reader already kneeling, palm flat on the cleared surface of a line, reading it through the skin. "Your colleague's going to want to wash that hand before lunch. The crust is what keeps the line."

The hydrology-reader looked up. "The mist."

“The mist.” She nodded, surprised and not showing much of it. “It comes most mornings. Hardens the surface into a little armour. Two thousand years it’s been ironing these flat. You took your hand off?”

The hydrology-reader had already taken the hand off, was looking at it as though it had betrayed something. “I felt the low,” they said. “The line we passed coming in — it runs into a low spot. You can feel the ground change under the —”

“You can feel a lot of things out here.” She let it sit, neither agreeing nor closing it. Then, to the LENS: “You’ll want the morning light. Six, six-thirty. The lines come up out of the ground like they’re lit from inside. After ten the contrast dies and it’s all the same dirt.”

They walked a little way out, because she offered, and because the LENS could not have refused if a knife had been involved.

She told it the way you tell a thing you have told a hundred times and still believe. The lines were *removal*, she said — not built up but taken away. The whole pampa wore a skin of pebbles gone reddish-black with iron oxide and a thousand years of desert varnish, ten, fifteen centimetres of dark stone over pale subsoil. You cleared the dark, you exposed the pale, and the line was the *contrast* between them. No engineering. No lost technology. Stakes and cord. They’d radiocarbon-dated a wooden anchor stake left at the end of a line; the date came back exactly where it should, inside the window the pottery already gave them. Four hundred BC to five hundred AD. Paracas first, then Nazca.

“Stakes and cord,” the LENS repeated. “For *that*.” A hand at the hummingbird, somewhere out there, invisible from the ground.

“For *that*.” She crouched, drew a line in the surface with one finger — the dark skin parting under a fingernail, the pale showing through, instant, effortless. “Try it. It’s that easy. The ground’s soft. A boot marks it.”

The LENS pressed a heel down and the desert kept the print, clean as a stamp. Easy. The skin gave at the lightest insult. *That* was the thing that made the alien-runway business collapse on contact, she said without contempt — von Däniken, the spacecraft, *Chariots of the Gods*, the whole 1968 of it — because anything heavy enough to land

would have ploughed the pampa to gravel. The ground was too soft to hold a craft and too soft to need one. It held a footprint because a footprint was all anyone had ever asked of it.

“People wanted it to be hard,” she said, standing, brushing her hands though there was nothing on them. “Hard to make. Made by someone bigger than the people who made it. It’s not. It was made by the people who lived here, with their hands, in this dirt. That’s the harder thing to sit with, actually. That it was *them*.”

The LENS looked at the ruler-straight line running off into the heat-shimmer and thought about the word *easy* and did not yet say the thing that would become a problem.

They tried it, of course. The crew. Two afternoons later, off the protected sectors, on a scratch of ground she’d cleared them to use, with stakes and cord and a half-day of will. The official method, faithfully. Stake at one end, cord paid out, a sightline.

The line came out *wrong*.

Not catastrophically. But the LENS put the camera up on the survey pole and shot down at it, and the photograph was merciless. Their line wandered. It had a belly in the middle where the cord had sagged and nobody had caught it. Where they’d cleared the dark stones the margin was ragged, stones knocked half-aside, the cleared band fat here and starved there, a thing that had been *attempted*. Beside it — fifteen metres beside it — ran one of the real ones, two thousand years old, and from the pole the real line was *true*. Crisp. A single unbroken intention. The verge stones stacked neat the whole length. It did not waver across what must have been a kilometre of plain it could not, from the ground, have seen the end of.

The crew stood over their lumpy effort and laughed, the good kind.

“It’s a potato,” the hydrology-reader said.

“It’s a potato,” the LENS agreed.

The archaeologist looked at the two lines side by side — the modern attempt and the ancient certainty — and her face did a thing that was not mockery, was closer to fondness, the way you watch a child copy your handwriting.

“You see the difference,” she said.

“I see the difference.”

“Now ask yourself the question everyone skips.” She wasn’t smiling now. “Not *how*. You just did the *how*. Stakes, cord, the ground gives. You could teach a school group to do the *how*. Ask the other one.”

The LENS waited.

“*What’s it for.*” She said it plainly, and turned to walk back toward the van, and over her shoulder, almost careless: “You made yours so it’d look like something from up where you were standing. They made theirs so it’d look like something from up where you fly. Different audience. Same dirt.”

That night the LENS sat with the day’s take and the official story, and the official story was *good*. That was what nobody warned you about. It held.

The 2024 work — the AI survey, Yamagata and IBM and the German aerospace people, three hundred-odd new figures pulled out of the noise — hadn’t deepened the mystery, it had *sorted* it. Two kinds of glyph. The relief-type, the little ones, nine metres, sitting right by the old footpaths, four out of five of them human-themed, the size and placement of a thing meant for a person walking past — roadside stations, the LENS thought, the way you’d pass a shrine on a road and slow down. And the line-type, the giants, ninety metres, the animals, the birds, the wild things — the ones you only got from the air. Two answers, not one. Procession and station. Walk and fly. The single unified Nazca Mystery had quietly become two understood Nazca practices, and the science was, mostly, *winning*.

The star theory was dead — Hawkins, Aveni, the alignments tested and found to come up about twenty per cent, no better than throwing darts. The runway theory had never been alive. The lines were ritual, processional, tied to water and the asking-for-water in a place that got twenty minutes of rain a year and survived on those mad corkscrew aqueducts in the dust. Fertility. Procession. Memory. The keeper had said it and the literature said it and they agreed, and it was beautiful and it was *enough*.

Except.

The hydrology-reader knocked once and came in without waiting, tablet glowing, and laid it on the table over the photographs.

"The spiral from the plane," they said. "The one sitting in the low." A line on the overlay, faint, threaded down toward a marked point. "It runs to a puquio. One of the aqueducts. And it's not the only one. There's a man — Johnson — found a handful of lines that track the faults. The faults that channel the groundwater down to the puquios. The lines sit on the water."

"Correlation," the LENS said, because the keeper had used the word that afternoon, gently, the mainstream word, *Proulx*, not a map, ritual, and had not, the LENS noticed, said it like a door closing.

"Correlation," the hydrology-reader agreed, and did not move the tablet. "Nobody's closed it, though. They say it's not a map. They haven't shown it isn't."

Outside, far across the plain, a cluster of lights had come on at the consortium's camp, and a drone went up against the early stars with a thin bright eye, hunting the sector for whatever was still unnamed, whatever could still be claimed, scanning the last dark places where the figures had not yet been counted and patented and pulled into someone's data.

The LENS looked at the photograph of the true line and the lumpy line, side by side, and at the overlay where a spiral sat in a low and reached its long pale arm toward water in the ground, and thought about *what's it for*, and did not have it, and felt the old good hunger come up clean as a footprint in soft dirt.

"Six-thirty," the LENS said. "She wants us up at six-thirty. The light."

The drone's eye crossed the window and was gone over the gold.

Chapter 2 — Meet the Keepers

The road to Cahuachi is not a road so much as a suggestion the desert tolerates. Mariela — that's the hydrology-reader, and yes, she's me writing this down later, but let's keep it third for now, she prefers it, says she sees herself better from a few feet back — Mariela watched the van's shadow ripple over a surface that should have been flat and wasn't. Up close the pampa is a rubble of small dark stones, each one furred with the same rusty patina, all of them lying like they'd been set down by hand and never picked up again. Which, in a sense, was exactly the point. You don't draw on the Nazca plain. You undraw it. You lift the dark stones off the pale ground and the absence is the line.

She found this almost unbearably elegant and said so out loud, to nobody, twice.

The LENS sat up front with the window down, not photographing anything, which from him was a kind of held breath. He photographs from aircraft. On the ground he goes quiet and slightly grey, like a fish out of the one medium where it knows how to move. Cahuachi rose ahead of them out of the haze — not a city of stone but a city of made earth, great adobe mounds slumped back toward the dust they came from, the largest cult centre of a people who built their holy place on the driest ground on Earth and then, around AD 500, walked away from it.

There was a field tent at the base of the largest mound, the colour of weak tea, guyed against a wind that, here, almost never comes.

The woman waiting under it did not get up to greet them.

Her name was Dr. Elena Quispe and she had been born forty kilometres from where she now stood, which she mentioned once, flatly, the way you'd give a coordinate. She watched the crew unload the aerial kit — the camera bodies in their foam, the long lenses, the survey-grade GPS the LENS treated like a relic — and her face did a thing Mariela clocked immediately and filed: not contempt, not welcome. Inventory. She was counting them. She was counting their gear. She was working out, before anyone shook a hand, what these people thought they had come to take.

"You're the sky people," Elena said. "Or the other sky people."

"Other?" said Tomas — crew, sound and logistics, marginal in the specific way of a man who has never once in his life understood why a room went cold, and so learned to read the temperature of rooms instead.

Elena tipped her chin north and east, toward a low ridge maybe two kilometres off, where something white and geometric sat among the dun. "Their camp. The ones with the machines that fly themselves." She let that land. "You at least came with a person who has to *aim*."

The LENS made a sound that might have been a laugh.

Mariela had read everything on the flight in and she could not stop herself; this is the wiring, this is not a flaw, this is the only door she has. "The relief-type glyphs," she said, "the small ones, the human figures near the old footpaths — those were made to be seen by someone walking past. The line-type, the big animals, ninety metres of them — those you can only really read from above. So the lines were made for two kinds of eyes. Feet and sky. And that's—"

"That's the 2024 paper," Elena said. "Sakai. Yamagata. They ran a model over the pampa and it found three hundred and three figures nobody had catalogued. Relief-type average about nine metres, sat near the paths, eighty percent of them people and gods and houses — roadside shrines, station to station. Line-type bigger, sixty-odd percent wild animals, meant for the procession to walk *inside* of." She recited it without warmth or pride, a teacher who has given the lecture so many times the lecture has worn smooth. "It's a good paper. It killed the idea that this is one mystery with one answer."

It is many things made by many hands over nine hundred years.” A pause. “It is also a machine learning to see what my grandmother saw on foot.”

Nobody preached. Mariela noted that nobody preached, and that the not-preaching had a weight to it.

The official story, then, given its full due, because it deserves it and because it is mostly *true*:

There is no mystery about *how*. Stakes and cord. They’ve radiocarbon-dated a wooden anchor stake driven in at the end of a line. You set your peg, you run your cord taut, you walk along it lifting the dark stones aside, and behind you the pale subsoil opens up bright as a scar. No lasers from the sky. No lost technology. The deepest line is the depth of your hand, ten or fifteen centimetres, and the ground is soft enough that a boot — Mariela watched the LENS test this, gingerly, at the edge of a faint untended line, and the print sat there, fresh and pale, a fourth mark beside three thousand years of others — a boot will mark it.

There is no mystery about *when*, broadly: 400 BC to AD 500, the Paracas folk and then the Nazca, and Cahuachi the centre of it all, brooding over the plain.

There is, mostly, no mystery about *why*. Water. Fertility. Procession. You walk the lines as ritual — you ask the desert for rain in the only place on Earth that gets about twenty minutes of it a year. Donald Proulx and the mainstream have built a careful, sober case: the lines are tied to water and the making of life, but as *ritual*, as a prayer the body performs by walking, not as a literal chart. The old wild theories went down years ago. Hawkins ran the star alignments in ’73, Aveni ran them harder in ’82, and the lines pointed at the calendar no better than they’d point at anything you threw a dart at — about one in five, which is what chance looks like. And von Däniken’s runways: the ground is soft enough for *my boot*, said the LENS, looking at his own print. It will not hold a cart. It will certainly not hold a spacecraft.

The science caught up. That’s the honest thing. The science caught up and most of the wonder it was supposed to murder turned out to survive it.

“Show me your line,” Elena said.

They had not made a line yet. They were going to — it was on the schedule, the whole bit, the crew replicating the easy method with stakes and cord to prove how easy it was. Elena seemed to know this was coming the way you know a tide is coming.

So they did it then, in the long gold of late afternoon, on a permitted patch of disturbed ground well off any heritage line, with Elena’s say-so and a preservationist hovering. Tomas hammered the first stake. Mariela ran the cord and pulled it taut and it sang. Easy. They walked it, lifting stones, and behind them a pale line opened up and Mariela’s heart did something embarrassing.

Then they stepped back to look.

It was a potato.

Not a line. A nervous, wandering, lumpy thing, fat here, pinched there, drifting a half-metre off true where the cord had sagged unseen, where a stone had been too big to move so they’d gone *around* it, where someone’s attention had wobbled. Forty metres of it and not one metre you could call straight.

The LENS went up in the little drone-photo balloon they’d rigged — not to claim anything, just to see it from where it was meant to be seen — and brought the camera down and turned the screen around without a word.

From above, the crew’s line looked like a worm that had died thinking about something else.

And there, in the same frame, half a kilometre off, an ancient line ran arrow-straight to the horizon. Kilometres of it. True as a laid edge. Made, the archaeologists believe, in a single working — possibly a single night, the whole community out on the cold pampa with cord and stake and torch — by people with no instrument finer than a taut string and a sightline, and *it did not wobble*. Not for a metre. Not for a kilometre.

Tomas looked at the worm. He looked at the arrow. “Okay,” he said quietly. “So they were better at this than us.”

“Everyone is better at this than the people who do it for the first time and think it’s easy,” Elena said. It was the gentlest thing she’d said and it took the skin off anyway. She crouched at the head of the dead-worm line. “You sagged the cord here.” She pointed at the pinch. “You looked at your feet here. You let the line tell you where to go, instead of telling the line.” She stood, and brushed the dust from her knees, and for the first time something moved in her face that was not inventory. “They didn’t make these to be *good at lines*. They made these to be *together*, all night, doing the same hard thing, for the same reason. The straightness is the prayer working. You can’t get it alone and looking at your feet.”

Nobody said anything. The fish — that’s the heckle this book runs on, the small dry voice that won’t let anybody get holy — the fish wanted to point out that “the straightness is the prayer working” was unfalsifiable and lovely and exactly the kind of thing you can’t put in a journal. But the worm was right there. The arrow was right there. And one of them was made by people who’d practised three thousand years ago and one of them was made by us, this afternoon, with better cord.

Let the reader sit with that.

It was Mariela who found the hole. Of course it was. It’s why she’s load-bearing; it’s the thing she cannot turn off.

She’d been pacing the ancient arrow at a distance, head down, doing the thing she does where the land’s drainage assembles itself in her mind whether she wants it or not — the old buried fault lines, the way the dead rivers must have run under all this dust. And she stopped, because the arrow line, when she stood at its head and sighted along it, pointed at a low spiral depression a kilometre off that she already knew, from the survey maps, was a puquio. One of the corkscrew aqueducts. Ancient hydro-engineering, still drawing groundwater up out of the dust today, still *working*, fifteen hundred years on, where nothing else here would give you a cup of water if you dug all week.

“That line,” she said. “It runs at the puquio.”

Elena did not turn around. “Some do.”

“There’s a man — Johnson — he mapped lines against the faults that

channel the groundwater to the puquios, and some of them *track*—”

“Some of them track.” Now Elena turned. Her voice hadn’t sharpened but it had set, like the morning crust that armours these lines, the one the mist lays down each dawn and the windless air never lifts. “David Johnson. Yes. It is a real correlation. Some lines do run with the faults that feed the water. I will not pretend they don’t, because they do, and I have walked them.” She held Mariela’s eye. “And Proulx is almost certainly right that it’s not a map. That the water is *in* the ritual, that you walk toward water because water is the whole point, and a thing can point at water without being a chart for finding it. Correlation. Not function.” A breath. “Almost certainly.”

“But nobody’s closed it,” Mariela said. Quiet. Not pushing. Just naming the shape of the thing.

“No,” said Elena. “Nobody has closed it.” And she let that stand in the dry air, neither hers to give away nor anyone’s to take — and Mariela understood, with a small cold thrill that had nothing to do with aliens and everything to do with an unclosed door, that this woman knew the case better than any of them and had chosen, deliberately, where to stop. Not from ignorance. From respect for what she didn’t yet get to say.

The hole was real. It was cited. It was on the ground a kilometre away with water in the bottom of it. And the keeper had walked it before any of them were born.

The sound came in low and flat from the northeast.

Not wind — there is almost no wind here, that’s half of why the lines have lasted, twenty minutes of rain a year and a windless sky that lets the mist do its quiet armouring. So the sound was wrong before it was loud: a hard mechanical buzz, four-rotor, climbing.

The drone came over the ridge from the white camp and hung above the pampa maybe sixty metres up, a fat insect with too many eyes, holding station over a stretch of ground beyond the ancient arrow. Then a second. Then a third, fanning out on a grid, methodical, tireless, flying themselves. Scanning. Not aiming — Elena’s word came back, *machines that fly themselves* — sweeping the desert in clean automated lanes, finding figures no foot would ever read, building

a dataset, and somewhere in a tent over that ridge, a server filling up with the last unmapped lines of a vanished people, and lawyers, Mariela would learn soon enough, already drafting the language of what could be *claimed*.

Elena watched them with her arms folded and her chin level. She did not look surprised. She looked like someone watching weather she'd long since learned to read.

"There," she said, without turning. "The other sky people. They want to *have* it." She let the drones complete a lane, turn, begin the next. "Your aimer wants to see it." The faintest tilt of her head toward the LENS, who was watching the drones with the particular stillness of a man whose whole art had just been done faster and worse by a machine, and who knew it.

"And you?" Tomas asked.

Elena Quispe looked at the ancient line running true and pale to the horizon, and at the puquio with its old water in the bottom of the dust, and at the lumpy human worm the crew had scratched into the ground that afternoon, all three of them in the long gold light at once.

"Me," she said. "I want to keep it whole long enough to keep walking it."

Overhead, the drones turned, and turned again, eating the desert one clean lane at a time.

Chapter 3 — The Straight Line

The line ran for two kilometres without flinching.

That was the thing nobody warns you about. You read “geoglyph” and you picture a scratch, a furrow, something a child could scuff into a beach. Then you stand at the foot of one of the great main lines at seven in the morning, the desert going from grey to gold the way a coal goes, and the line just leaves. It walks away from your boots in a single thought and does not stop until it has crossed a dry watercourse, climbed a low rise without bending, and hit a hill on the horizon so squarely that you would swear someone laid a ruler across the whole of southern Peru and pressed.

The LENS stood at the near terminus with the camera bag still on one shoulder and felt the old vertigo — the wrong-way-up feeling of being on the ground inside something built for the sky.

“You can walk it,” said the local. “That is the point of it.”

Her name was Rosa Quispe, and she had been born in the long brown shadow of Cahuachi, and she said *you can walk it* the way a person says *you can read it* — as though the walking were a kind of literacy the LENS had simply never been taught.

The LENS had photographed these lines forty times. From altitude. From a Cessna with the door off and the wind trying to take the lens cap to Bolivia. The LENS knew this line the way you know a famous face from posters — its proportions, its angle to the others, the trapezoid it fed into a kilometre on. And standing at its base, at the height of a human eye, the LENS could see precisely none of that. The trape-

zoid was a faint paleness in the haze. The famous figure two valleys over might as well have been on the moon.

“It’s gone,” the LENS said. “From here it’s just — a path.”

“Yes,” Rosa said, and smiled, and that was the whole lesson, delivered and closed.

They walked.

The hydrology-reader walked ahead of everyone, which was how the hydrology-reader walked everywhere, head down, reading the ground like a sentence — the LENS had long since stopped trying to keep him in frame. He was muttering the gradient to himself. *Falls maybe half a metre over the next hundred. Toward the river. Toward the river.* He had a way of saying a fact three times until it stopped being a coincidence and started being a clue, and the trick of him was that often it actually was.

The LENS came last.

This was new and the LENS hated it. On a job the LENS was the one above, the one who saw the whole shape while everyone below scurried in their little local panics. Up there the world resolved into pattern; up there the LENS was at peace, because from two thousand feet nothing can hurt you and everything makes sense. Down here the LENS’s lungs burned, the camera bag dug a stripe into the shoulder, the gravel rolled under the boot soles, and the line — the famous, perfect, ruler-straight line — was just a slightly paler strip of dirt about four metres wide that the LENS kept drifting off the edge of because there was nothing to fix on, no edge sharp enough at eye level to steer by.

The fish, riding in the cooler in the back of the van two kilometres away, did not need to be present to observe that the world’s greatest aerial photographer had got lost on a straight line.

“It’s only fifteen centimetres deep,” the LENS said, mostly to keep the breath moving. “I keep expecting it to be — more.”

“Ten to fifteen,” Rosa said. She crouched without breaking stride, a field motion, decades old. She lifted one of the dark stones from

the line's border and held it out. The top of it was the colour of old blood, a skin of iron oxide that the desert had been painting onto it for a thousand years. She turned it over. The underside was pale, raw, the colour of the ground the line revealed. "They took these up. Only these. Down to here." She tapped the paler subsoil at her feet. "Everything you are looking at is the difference between this side of a stone and that side of a stone. There is no trench. There is no carving. There is a removing."

She set the stone back exactly where it had been, dark side up.

"You walk a line for a kilometre," she said, "and your sandals never break the crust. Because the morning makes a crust." She gestured at the air, at the pale gold of it. "The mist comes before dawn. It hardens the ground like a skin on milk. By the time the sun is up the skin is set. That is why we are still standing on something made before Rome had emperors."

The LENS lifted the camera then, almost without deciding to, because that was a thing worth keeping: Rosa's brown hand against the brown ground, the single overturned stone, the line behind her marching off into haze. The shutter went. It was the wrong photograph. It would be flat and small and would not show what the line *was*. The LENS knew this the instant it was taken and took it anyway, because the right photograph — the one that showed what the line was — could only be made from a place where Rosa's hand and the single stone could not be seen at all.

That was the bargain of this whole desert, the LENS was beginning to feel. You could have the meaning or you could have the scale. The air would not give you both at once.

Where the line crossed a dry watercourse it did not so much as dip a shoulder.

"Watch this part," the hydrology-reader said. He had stopped. He was standing in the bottom of the old channel, and he was looking back up the line's slope with an expression the LENS recognised — the lit-up look, the one that came before either a breakthrough or a very long, very awkward dinner. "It runs *across* the drainage. Dead level. The water cut down here and the line just — refuses to know.

Like it was made by people who weren't thinking about water at all." A pause. "Or by people who were thinking about water so hard they were making a point of it."

"Donald Proulx," Rosa said, and the hydrology-reader's head came up like a dog hearing its own name. She had clearly had this conversation before, with sharper opponents than a tired Welshman in a drainage ditch, and she gave it to him generously, the full weight of the mainstream, because she respected it. "The view most of my colleagues hold. The lines are ritual. Processional. You walk them. You walk them as an act — toward water, yes, *about* water, because here water is the only thing worth being about. But the line is not a map of the water. The line is a prayer about the water. There is a difference between a thing that shows you where the river is and a thing you do because you want the river to come."

"So the water's in the meaning," the hydrology-reader said. "Not the geometry."

"The water is in everything," Rosa said. "We are in the driest place that grows people. Twenty minutes of rain in a year. You do not need a line to find water here. You need water to come at all. Everything these people made, they made because the sky would not give them enough and they could not stop asking." She looked down the line. "Fertility, my colleagues say. The figures, the spirals, the great open trapezoids where you can see the ground was walked, walked, walked, until it shines. Places to gather. To process. To ask."

The LENS thought of the trapezoids from the air — the way they sometimes looked, from altitude, like runways, like landing strips, and how that single accident of resemblance had launched a thousand paperback covers and a man named von Däniken into a fortune.

"People used to say spacecraft," the LENS said. "Landing strips."

Rosa did not roll her eyes, which the LENS thought was enormously to her credit, given that she had presumably heard it from every third tourist since she was nineteen. She just put her boot heel into the line's pale floor and pressed, and a clear footprint stood there in the skin of the desert, sharp-edged, fifteen centimetres of give.

"A wheelbarrow would sink," she said. "A man in sandals leaves a mark. We are standing on a thing so soft that I have just damaged it

slightly by making a point to you, and I am sorry to it for that.” She did, genuinely, look briefly sorry to the ground. “Nothing landed here. Nothing heavy ever could. The same skin that kept the line for two thousand years would not hold a truck for two minutes.”

The hydrology-reader was still down in the channel. “But the faults,” he said, quietly, not arguing, just laying it on the table the way you lay a card you are not sure you should. “Some of the lines. They sit over faults. The faults channel groundwater. Toward the puquios.”

“Some,” Rosa said. The word was exact. She did not say *no*. The LENS noticed that she did not say *no*, and filed it, the way the LENS filed the wrong photograph, for later, for the place where it might turn out to matter. “A few lines. A man named Johnson counted them. It is real that they line up. It is not agreed what the lining-up means. Most of us think it is the desert lining up with itself — the faults make the water, the water makes the people stay, the people make the lines about the water that the faults make. A circle.” She paused. “He thinks the line points at the water like a finger. I think the line is the finger pointing at the sky. We have not settled it. I do not think we are going to settle it this year.”

She said it without heat, the way you describe a weather system. *We have not settled it*. The LENS looked at the hydrology-reader and the hydrology-reader looked at the dry watercourse, and neither of them said anything, because there was nothing to win there. Rosa had handed them the open question with both hands, scrupulously, the way you hand someone a knife — pointing the safe end out.

They came at last to the terminus, where the line simply ended at the foot of a low hill, and the hill was scuffed and pale where ten thousand years of feet — or hundreds of years of feet, ten thousand times each — had turned and gone back.

The LENS sat down on a rock and let the lungs do their burning. The desert at full morning was the most silent place the LENS had ever stood. No wind. There was almost never any wind; that was half of why the lines survived. The silence had a weight to it, a pressure on the ears, and into it the LENS said the thing that had been building since the near terminus two kilometres ago.

“Reiche walked these for fifty years,” the LENS said. “On the ground. With a broom and a ladder. And she still drew the figures by working out the geometry from down here, because she couldn’t fly over them whenever she liked.” A breath. “She knew them by foot. I know them from the air. We’ve never once seen the same line.”

Rosa looked at the LENS for a moment with something that wasn’t quite pity and wasn’t quite a challenge.

“And the people who made them?” she said. “Which did they know?”

The LENS didn’t answer, because the honest answer was *I don’t know*, and the LENS had spent a career not having to say that out loud to anyone.

The hydrology-reader was crouched at the terminus, where a survey crew decades ago had found, radiocarbon-dated, the rotted stub of a wooden anchor stake — the kind you’d tie a cord to, to walk a line out straight across two kilometres of nothing. Stakes and cord. No mystery in the *how*. He picked up a handful of the pale subsoil and let it run.

“Stakes and cord,” he said. “You and me could do that.”

“Could we,” said the LENS.

It was not really a question, and it was entirely a question, and the silence afterward had a different quality, the quality of a door opening a crack in a windless room.

Rosa watched them both. She had clearly watched outsiders arrive at this exact thought before — the cord, the stakes, the *how hard can it be* — and she had clearly watched the desert answer them. She did not warn them off it. She had the deep field patience of a person who knows the ground is going to do the explaining and she will not have to say a word.

“You want to make one,” she said. Not asking.

“Just to see,” the hydrology-reader said. “A short one. Stakes, cord, the dark stones moved off. We document it. We measure ours against —” he gestured at the impossible two-kilometre line behind them, dead straight across a drainage, made in a single working before the morning crust set, by people who would never once stand where the LENS now stood and see what they had drawn. ” — against that.”

“To find out how they did it,” the LENS said.

“To find out how hard it was,” said the hydrology-reader, which was a different sentence, and the truer one.

Rosa picked up one last dark stone, turned it in her fingers, blood-red to bone-pale and back, and set it down.

“Bring water,” she said. “And take only the stones you mean to take. The desert keeps everything you do to it.” She straightened, and looked off down the line that ran arrow-true into the morning toward a hill it would hit precisely, made by hands that never saw it whole. “Yes. Make your line. I would very much like to see it from the air.”

She did not say *I think you'll find it harder than you imagine*.

She let the cord say that.

Chapter 4 — Potato on the Pampas

The thing nobody tells you about the Nazca pampa is how loud the silence is.

Tomás had been on the plateau forty minutes and the quiet had already started to ring in his ears, a high thin tone that he knew was just his own blood but felt like the desert humming a note too low to hear and too constant to ignore. No wind. That was the strangest part. He kept turning his head, waiting for the breeze you get on every other open ground on Earth, the little reassurance that air still moved, and it never came. The mist had burned off an hour ago and left the crust hard as a fired plate. When he crouched and pressed two fingers into it, the surface held, and then gave, all at once — a thin reddish skin over pale flour, the whole desert a tooth with the enamel intact and the bone soft underneath.

He'd read all the numbers on the flight down. Twenty minutes of rain a year. One of the driest, stillest surfaces on the planet. The reddish stones were iron-oxide patina, ten, fifteen centimetres deep, and you made a line by lifting them off and piling them at the edge so the pale subsoil showed through. That was the whole trick. That was the entire technology that had launched a thousand paperbacks about spacemen. Stones, and the patience to move them.

"You want the cord or you want to argue with the ground some more," said Petra.

She was standing over the kit bag with two coils of mason's line and a fistful of wooden stakes they'd bought that morning in the Nazca ferretería, the hardware-store man wrapping them in newspaper like

fish. The Lens was forty metres off, already up on the stepladder they'd hauled out of the van, the long lens pointed not at anything yet but at the place where the line would be, framing the absence. She worked like that. She saw the photograph before the subject existed.

"Both," Tomás said, and stood, and his knees cracked, and the sound went out across the plain and came back to nobody.

Here is the official story, and it is worth saying it straight because it is mostly true and it took good people their whole lives to make it true. The lines are not a mystery anymore, not really, not the way the airport gift shops want them to be. They were made by the Paracas and the Nazca, between roughly four hundred years before Christ and five hundred after. The cult centre brooded a few kilometres south at Cahuachi, mudbrick pyramids melting back into the hill they were raised on. The people who walked here walked toward water and fertility and the dead, and they swept the dark stones aside to make paths and figures, and they did it with stakes and cord and their feet, and there was no lost technology and there were no visitors from anywhere further away than the next valley.

Maria Reiche spent half a century on her knees out here with a broom and a tape measure, sleeping in a one-room house, chasing tourists off the glyphs, mapping every line by hand until the German government and then the Peruvian one took her seriously. And just last year a team from Yamagata and IBM ran AI over the whole pampa and pulled three hundred and three new figures out of the noise — the small relief-type ones, nine metres across, clustered along the old footpaths, four out of five of them showing people; and the great line-type ones, ninety metres, mostly wild animals, made to be seen from a distance. Two kinds of thing for two kinds of looking. Roadside shrines for the feet. Communal figures for — well. That was the part Tomás kept circling back to, but not yet, not today. Today was the simple part.

"We are going to make a line," Tomás announced, to Petra, to the Lens on her ladder, to the ringing air. "An easy one. The easiest thing they did. A straight line. If they could do it with sticks and string and no machines, so can we, and then we will have, in our hands, the proof that it was easy."

From the lip of the shallow rise to the south, the local lifted her water bottle in something that might have been a toast or might have been a warning, and said nothing.

María-Elena Quispe had been at Cahuachi her whole life, which is to say her family had, which is to say she had grown up with the pampa the way other people grow up with a street. She had let them onto the open ground — not the protected lines, never those, a blank patch east of the figures where the only thing they could damage was their own dignity — and she had set herself a polite distance away on the rise with her bottle and her field hat and an expression Tomás could not read, which bothered him, because reading expressions was supposedly the thing his particular wiring did instead of small talk. He read rooms. He read water. He had spent his childhood being told he wasn't paying attention when in fact he was paying attention to everything at once, the hum behind the conversation, the slope of a floor, the way damp moved through a wall. He couldn't always say it back in words people wanted. But he saw it.

María-Elena's face, though. Closed. Friendly and closed, like a shop with the lights on and the door locked.

"Right," said Petra. "Stake."

They drove the first stake at the western end. The ground took it grudgingly, the crust spitting little reddish flakes, and then the soft flour below let the wood slide. Tomás paced off the distance — they'd agreed on fifty metres, modest, a baby of a line — and Petra drove the second stake while Tomás held the far end of the mason's line and pulled it taut and the cord lifted off the ground in a long shivering catenary and then snapped tight and straight, a hard white geometry laid across the chaos of stones.

For one second it was perfect. The string was a true line. The ancients had had exactly this — a stake, a cord, a sightline.

"See," Tomás said. "Easy. We just follow the string."

The Lens's shutter went, a small mechanical cough in the silence.

And then they started lifting stones.

The idea was simplicity itself. Walk the cord. Take the dark patinated pebbles off the strip the cord defined, a metre wide, and pile them

neat at the edges, and the pale subsoil would show, and you would have a line. Tomás bent to it. The first stones came up easy enough, loose on the crust, and he set them aside, and where they'd been was — not pale subsoil. A scuff of paler stuff, yes, but pocked, the surface beneath them as red-stained as the surface above, because the patina wasn't just a skin on top of the stones, it was *in* the stones, and lifting them only gave you the slightly less dark gravel underneath that they'd been sitting on.

"You have to go deeper," Petra said, on her knees beside him.

So they went deeper. Down to where it really did go pale, ten centimetres, twelve, and now they weren't lifting stones, they were excavating, scraping with the edges of trowels at flour that puffed up and hung in the dead air because there was no wind to take it, and got in Tomás's mouth and on the Lens's lens forty metres away so that she swore and climbed down to wipe it. And the strip they cleared was pale, genuinely pale now, a strip of light against the dark — but the edge of it wavered. Where they'd dug a centimetre too far, it cut a notch. Where they'd left a stone proud, it bulged. The cord ran arrow-true above the whole mess, and the cleared strip beneath it wandered against the cord like a river against a ruler.

"Stay under the string," Tomás said.

"I am under the string."

"Your edge is going wide there."

"That's where the crust broke off in a chunk. I can't un-break it."

That was the thing nobody warned you about. The crust didn't fail neatly. You pressed and it held and then it sheared, calving off in a flake the size of your palm, and where it went it took the clean edge with it, and you had a scallop, a bite, a little bay in your coastline. And every footstep — the lines are only ten, fifteen centimetres deep, soft enough for a boot to mark, Tomás had read that and not understood it until now — every footstep around the edge of their work crushed a new dent into the clean ground, so that they were destroying the thing as fast as they made it, having to clear the prints, the prints making more prints.

An hour in, Tomás stood up to ease his back and looked at what they had.

Forty metres of cleared strip, under a perfectly straight cord. The cord mocked it. Along its length the pale strip swelled and pinched, scalloped and notched, bayed and capered, wide here, pinched to a throat there, the piled stones at the edges heaped unevenly because they'd taken the easy ones first and had to fetch the stubborn ones from underneath. It was a line the way a child's drawing of a snake is a line. It had the idea of straightness laid over the fact of its own lumpy reluctance.

The Lens went back up the ladder. She put her eye to the camera and was quiet for a moment.

"Tomás," she said.

"Don't."

"Come up and see."

He climbed. The ladder was unsteady on the crust and he held the top rail and put his eye where hers had been and looked down the long axis of their morning's labour, and from up here, from even this pathetic ten feet of elevation, it was worse. Much worse. From the ground it had been a rough line. From above it was — there was no kind word. It bulged in the middle and tapered at both ends and the scallops along its sides caught the low light and threw little shadows so that the whole thing had a knobbled, lumpen, earthbound solidity, a tuber dug up and laid in the dirt.

"It's a potato," the Lens said. There was no cruelty in it. She sounded almost tender, the way she got about anything that failed beautifully. "We made a potato."

Tomás came down the ladder. He turned, because he had to, because his eyes went to the rise the way water goes downhill, and María-Elena was no longer on the rise. She had walked down while they laboured and she was standing maybe twenty metres off with her arms folded and her hat pushed back, and she was looking at the potato, and she was smiling. Not laughing. Not unkind. The smile of someone watching a tourist try to ride a horse for the first time, knowing exactly how it would go and letting it go anyway, because some things you cannot tell a person, you can only let the ground tell them.

"That's not a line, that's lunch," said a voice that was nobody's, the

dry heckling voice the desert had been saving up. Tomás chose to believe it was his own exhaustion.

He walked over to her, scuffing flour, leaving a trail of his own ruinous footprints. “How long,” he said. “How long would they have spent. To get a clean one. Like the real ones.”

María-Elena looked past him at the potato for a while. The sun had climbed and the shadows it threw were shortening, and the lumps of their line were starting to flatten into the glare.

“You are asking the wrong thing,” she said. Not unkindly. “You ask how long. As if it was a job, and you are timing it.” She tipped her chin at the figures in the haze to the west, the great ones, the hummingbird and the spider and the monkey with the spiral tail, lines that ran true for a kilometre and never once wavered, ground that had not been scuffed in fifteen hundred years because the mist came every dawn and re-armoured the crust they had broken so carefully and walked so lightly. “They did not have a stepladder,” she said. “And they made it straighter than your string. You had the string and you could not follow it. So.” She let that sit. “Maybe it was not about following a string.”

The Lens, still up the ladder, had stopped photographing the potato. She had turned the camera west, toward the real lines, and Tomás heard the shutter go, and go again, and he knew without looking that she was doing the thing she did, the thing that was her gift and her cage both — she was seeing the whole pattern laid flat from above, the perfect geometry the makers themselves had never once stood back to see, could never have stood back to see, because there was nowhere on this plain to climb high enough.

And there it was, the question, sitting on the pampa next to the potato like a stone he’d lifted and not known what to do with: if you make a line so straight it shames a mason’s cord, and you make it by feel, on your knees, in the dust, with no way ever to rise up and check your work —

who was it straight *for*?

María-Elena watched him not-ask it. The shop was still locked. But he could have sworn, for just a second, that someone had moved behind the glass.

“Pack your potato,” she said gently, and turned back toward Cahuachi. “Tomorrow, early. Before the mist lifts. I will show you what it is like to be in one. Not to look at it.” She paused, and over her shoulder, almost kind: “Looking is your problem.”

The flour hung in the dead air where they’d disturbed it and did not settle and did not blow away, and the cord ran straight and white above the crooked thing they’d made, and out past it the desert kept on humming its one held note to nobody at all.

Chapter 5 — Above and Below

The Cessna smelled of hot vinyl and somebody's old coffee, and the LENS loved it the way you love a thing that has nearly killed you and decided not to.

She had the door off. Pilots in Nazca will do that for the right fee and the right face, and the LENS had the face — the one that says *I have hung out of worse than this over places where the air was full of metal*. Below them the pampa unrolled, ochre going to gold as the sun cleared the cordillera, and the wind that should have been tearing at her was not there. That was the first strange thing about this place, the thing nobody warned you about hard enough. You go up in a small plane and you brace for the buffet and the buffet does not come. The Nazca plain is one of the stillest surfaces on the planet. It rains for about twenty minutes a year. The air just sits.

So she sat in it, harness biting her hip, camera braced against the slipstream that wasn't, and waited for the line to come.

It came.

It came the way they always come from up here, which is to say all at once, the desert resolving from a field of brown stones into *intention*. A line ran out from under the plane's shadow and kept running — arrow-true, the width of a country road, pale against the dark gravel — and it did not waver, did not wander, did not apologise. It went to the horizon and over it. The LENS had photographed the meanders of the Mekong and the burn-scar geometry of cities that no longer existed and she still felt it, that small cold drop in the chest. She put the line in the corner of the frame and let the emptiness do the rest.

Click. The crust held the light like skin.

Easy, said the fish in her head, the heckling little voice she'd carried since the war and never named. *Scrape some rocks. Pull a string. You and your mob did one yesterday.*

They had. That was the joke. That was why they were up here.

In her ear, over the headset crackle, the pilot said something to the LOCAL in the back seat, and the LOCAL said something back in Spanish too fast for the LENS to catch, and laughed. The LOCAL — Cahuachi-born, field boots scuffed pale, a clipboard she never seemed to write on — had not wanted to come up at first. *I do my work down there*, she'd said the day they arrived, tipping her chin at the plain, and the way she'd said *down there* had carried weight the LENS only understood later. But she'd come. She wanted to see what the famous aerial eye saw. Or, the LENS suspected, she wanted to watch the famous aerial eye learn something.

"The straight one," the LOCAL said now, leaning between the seats, voice flat and clear over the engine. "That's old. Paracas, maybe. Then Nazca cut over the top of it. Look —" she pointed, and her finger was steadier than the airframe — "where it crosses the trapezoid. Two layers. Two hands. Five hundred years apart."

The LENS hunted, found it, shot it. The trapezoid lay across the older line like one decade laid over another, and you could read the sequence the way you read tree rings, if you knew. The LOCAL knew. The LENS only saw the pattern; the LOCAL saw the *order*. That difference would matter before the morning was out.

"How deep," the LENS asked. "The cut."

"Ten centimetres. Fifteen." The LOCAL shrugged. "You could make it with your boot. People do, by accident. There's a tour group sandal-print near the hummingbird that's older than half the tourists." A dry pause. "We didn't fill it in. It's evidence now. Of how easy it is to wreck."

Ten centimetres. The LENS turned that over. The whole monumental fact of this place — the lines that pulled tour buses and television crews and, this week, a consortium with German drones and a fleet

of laptops — was a skin of dark stones peeled back to show the pale beneath. No carving. No quarrying. No engineering you couldn't do with a stick and a length of cord and a clear morning. The official story, the one the LENS had laid out for the crew over warm beer their first night, was almost insulting in its simplicity. *They made it the obvious way. We can prove they made it the obvious way. Somebody radiocarbon-dated an anchor stake at the end of a line and it was wood, and it was old, and it was a stake.*

Which was exactly why the crew had gone out yesterday with stakes and cord to make their own.

“Bank left,” she told the pilot. “I want our one.”

He banked. The horizon tilted, the door-gap filled with sky and then with ground, and the LENS hung into her harness and found, in the wide ochre nothing about two kilometres east of the real lines, the crew's contribution to the archaeological record.

It was — she would be honest, she was always honest with a frame — a potato.

They'd planned it like engineers. The hydrology-reader had wanted a straight line, *just a straight line, how hard*, and had set the stakes with a spirit level and sighted along the cord with one eye shut, and the rest of the crew had walked it scraping the dark gravel aside with garden trowels for three hours in the windless heat until they all hated each other a little. The LENS had not gone out with them. She'd told them she would shoot it after. What she had not told them was that she already knew what she'd see, because she'd seen amateur geometry from the air her whole life and it always told on you.

It told on them now.

From a hundred and fifty metres up their line was a wobble. It started bold and then thought better of itself; it bellied out to the south around the halfway mark where somebody — she'd find out who, and it would be funny — had drifted off the cord chasing a stubborn band of stones; it tapered where they'd lost the light and the will. The scrape was uneven, dark stone left in clots like a bad shave. Three hours of six clever, careful, motivated modern people with steel tools and a

spirit level and a printed plan, and the result looked like something a large dog had started and abandoned.

The LENS laughed into the headset before she could stop it. The pilot grinned. The LOCAL leaned forward again and looked down at the crew's line for a long moment.

"It's good," she said.

"It's a disaster."

"No." The LOCAL wasn't smiling now, or not only. "It's *honest*. That's what three hours looks like. That's what *deciding as you go* looks like. You can see them changing their minds." She tapped the window over the belly. "That kink. Somebody argued there. You can see the argument from the air."

The LENS held the frame and felt the thing turn under her, the way a picture turns when the caption you brought to it is wrong. She'd come up here to shoot a joke — *look how hard the easy thing is*. And the LOCAL had just told her she was looking at the truest document on the whole plain. The crew's line was a transcript. Every doubt was in it. Every renegotiation, every drift, every place a tired arm gave up two inches early. The line had a *mind* in it, and the mind kept changing.

Click. She shot it anyway. You shoot the thing that surprises you.

"Now back to the real one," the LOCAL said. "Side by side, in your head. Tell me what you see."

The pilot brought them west and the LENS found the ancient line again and ran the comparison, frame to frame, the way she'd compared a hundred before-and-afters in places that no longer had before.

The crew's line argued. The Nazca line did not.

That was the whole of it, and it was enormous. The ancient line ran for kilometre after kilometre and never once changed its mind. No belly. No taper. No kink where somebody got tired, no clot where the gravel fought back. Over a distance where the curve of the planet itself starts to matter, over terrain that rose and dipped under it, the

line held a heading you could have laid a laser along. It crossed a shallow gully and came out the far side without flinching, picking up its own track to the centimetre — and that's the part the LENS could not let go of, because she'd just watched six modern people lose their cord over a band of awkward stones in flat light. These makers had crossed *terrain* and not lost it. Whatever they sighted along, they never put it down.

"Single night," the LOCAL said, watching her face. "Some of them. The crust." She gestured at the morning, the gold, the stillness. "The mist comes off the cold ground before dawn, hardens the surface. You make your line in the night and the dawn fixes it. You don't get a second draft. There's no kink, because there's no *arguing*. You knew the line before you walked it."

"How." The LENS heard how flat her own voice was. Pro question, professional flatness, the flatness she used when a thing had actually got to her. "How do you know a line that long before you walk it, in the dark, well enough that it never wavers?"

The LOCAL looked at her, and there was something kind in it, and something that was not going to be hurried.

"That's the part I do down there," she said. "Not up here."

The fish, who heckles, had things to say, and the LENS let it say them while she worked the camera. *Aliens, then. Big mate with a spirit bubble the size of a moon.* No. The ground was too soft for runways; a child could prove it with a boot, von Däniken's spacecraft would have ploughed through fifteen centimetres of patina and bogged in the subsoil and the whole desert would be a tractor yard of scars and it is *not*, the lines are immaculate, which is itself an argument *against* anything heavy ever touching them. *Star map, then. Celestial alignments. The old calendar in the sand.* No, the fish knew that one was dead too — Hawkins ran it through a computer in '73 and Aveni went after it harder a decade on, and only about a fifth of the lines pointed at anything in the sky, which is what you'd expect from pointing lines in every direction and then asking which ones happened to hit a star. No better than chance. Refuted clean.

So the fringe was gone, all of it, gone the honest way, by measure-

ment. Good. The LENS had no use for the fringe. The fringe always asked the wrong question. *Who made it, what's the secret, who's lying.* The real questions were quieter and they were sitting in the back seat of the plane.

She had her flawless line and her honest potato in the same memory card now, and the contrast was not the joke she'd planned. The joke had been *modern tools, ancient mystery, look how clever they were.* But that wasn't the residue. The residue was this: the crew's line showed its thinking, and the Nazca line showed *none*. It was finished before it began. It carried no doubt. And the LENS, who had spent her life finding the human tremor in everything — the photographer's hand, the soldier's flinch, the lie in the official caption — could not find a tremor anywhere in five kilometres of fourteen-hundred-year-old gravel.

"There," the LOCAL said suddenly, and pointed past the line, off its track, where the hydrology-reader had been so excited the day before. The line ran on its perfect heading and away to the north a thin pale thread of it — a feeder, a branch — bent toward a low scatter of stones the LENS now recognised as the rim of a puquio, one of the corkscrew wells that still, impossibly, pulled water up through this desert that got twenty minutes of rain a year. The branch ran toward the water. The hydrology-reader was certain it ran *to* the water, that it was a finger pointing at the table.

"He thinks it's a map," the LOCAL said, not unkindly.

"Is it?"

A long beat. The engine. The non-wind.

"Most of us think it's about water without being a map *of* water," she said. "You walk it to ask for the water. That's not the same as drawing where the water is." She watched the branch slide under the wing. "But I'll tell you what I won't tell him, because he'll get ideas." The dry almost-smile again. "Nobody's closed it. A few of those lines do sit on the faults that bring the groundwater up. More than I'd like. We say correlation. We say ritual." She let it hang. "We say it the way you say a thing you'd rather be true."

The LENS did not write that down. You don't write down the thing the keeper hands you sideways. You hold it.

She had one more frame she wanted. She asked the pilot to lift, to climb, to give her the whole plain at once with the sun low enough to throw the gravel into relief, and he climbed, and the desert fell away into its full impossible scale — the lines running everywhere now, a thousand decisions made flawlessly in a hundred nights across six centuries, all visible only from up here, all *meant* to be seen, surely, from exactly where she was sitting, in a machine these people could not have built or imagined.

That was the thing the LOCAL hadn't touched yet. The thing under everything. The relief glyphs, the little ones, the AI had just mapped three hundred of them — they sat by the old footpaths, human-sized, human-themed, made for a person walking past. *Those* made sense. You could see a relief glyph with your feet on the ground. But the great line-figures, the animals the size of stadiums, the lines that ran to the curve of the earth — you could not see those from the ground at all. You could only see them from here.

Made for feet, some of them. Made for *this*, the others. For an eye that flies.

The LENS held the whole plain in the frame and could not press the shutter for a moment, because the question was too large to put a border around, and that is the only kind of question worth not answering.

She pressed it anyway.

In the back seat, the LOCAL was already looking down — not up, not at the view, but down, at the ground, where her work was.

“Take me back,” she said. “I want to walk one with you before the light goes hard.”

Chapter 6 — The Ritual Walk

Marisol — the crew’s archivist, the one who counts things — woke at quarter to five because the desert had stopped breathing in the night and started again, and she felt the change in the tent canvas before she heard it. This is the kind of thing that gets you called *intense* in a job interview. It is also the kind of thing that makes you the person who notices the line is three centimetres off-true at sixty paces, so the trade is fair.

She lay still and listened to the others not sleeping. The Lens never slept past four; you could set a watch by the unzip of his camera bag, the soft clack of a body cap coming off. The hydrology-reader slept like a downed power line, all at once, completely, then sat bolt upright with a fact already loaded. The fixer — Jakobus — you never heard at all. He was simply outside when you got there, looking at something, not telling you what.

This morning he was looking at Susana.

The local archaeologist had driven up from Cahuachi in the dark with no headlights for the last kilometre, because headlights at dawn on the pampa are a kind of vandalism and she would no more do it than shout in a church. She was leaning on the van’s warm hood with a thermos, watching the east go from black to the colour of weak tea, and she did not say good morning. She said:

“You walk in single file. You walk where I walk. If you need to stop, you stop *on the line*, not beside it. The line is hard. Beside it is soft.”

Here is the official story, and it is a good one, and it has mostly won.

The Nazca made these figures by *subtraction*. There is nothing added to the desert. You do not paint a line here; you *uncover* one. The pampa wears a skin — a pavement of small stones gone red-brown with iron-oxide patina, ten, fifteen centimetres deep — and beneath that skin the ground is pale, near-yellow, the colour of old paper. To make a line you carry the dark stones away. That's it. That's the whole technology. Stakes, cord, baskets, and hands, between roughly 400 BC and AD 500, with the cult centre brooding south of here at Cahuachi.

And the climate did the rest, which is the part that still seems unfair to anyone who has tried to keep anything nice. Twenty minutes of rain a year. Almost no wind at ground level. And every morning a mist that comes in off the cold Pacific current, settles, and hardens the disturbed crust into something like a faint concrete. The desert sets the lines every dawn. The Nazca built in the one place on Earth that would agree to remember.

So when people ask *how*, the answer is, gently, *like that*. There is no how-mystery anymore. There is a radiocarbon date off a wooden anchor stake at the end of a line; there's Maria Reiche out here from 1940 with a broom and a stepladder, alone, for decades, sweeping and measuring and chasing tourists off with the fury of someone defending a relative; there's the 2024 survey where the AI read the pampa like a doctor reading a scan and pulled three hundred and three new figures out of the noise. The how is known. Stop asking the how.

Marisol knew all of this. She had typed most of it. She walked it for the first time at 5:40 in the morning and discovered that knowing it had not prepared her for anything at all.

Susana put them on the line one at a time, the way you'd put coins into a slot.

The figure was a line-type — one of the big ones, the ones the survey says skew toward wild animals, ninety metres average, made to be *something seen*, though Susana didn't say which animal and nobody asked, because asking felt like reading over a stranger's shoulder.

From the ground it was not an animal. From the ground it was a road. A pale channel maybe a metre wide, cleared down to the bright sub-soil, running away from her feet toward an east that was now the colour of a peach skin, and the cleared dark stones lay banked along both edges in a low ridge you could have brushed flat with your forearm.

She put her boot on it.

This is the detail nobody warns you about, and it is in the binding facts if you know to look: the lines are only ten to fifteen centimetres deep. *The ground is soft enough for a boot to mark it.* She stood on something two thousand years old and felt the crust give, very slightly, a faint sugary crunch, and her whole spine went cold with the wrongness of it, the sense of stepping on the actual past, and Susana said, without turning around, “Yes. Now you understand why I tell you single file.”

It was not a rebuke. It was the answer to a question Marisol hadn’t asked out loud, which is a thing the local kept doing all morning, and which Marisol — who had spent her whole life being the only one in the room who’d noticed — found almost unbearably restful. To be out-read. To be the one *behind*, for once. She could have wept and she didn’t know why, and that not-knowing was fine.

The fish, who had been smuggled in a cooler and was furious about the altitude, surfaced just long enough to say: “Two thousand years of perfect preservation and you lot turn up and immediately stand on it. Magnificent. Truly. Send the species a fruit basket.”

They walked.

This is the part the Lens could not do, and the part that broke something open in him a little, though he’d have removed his own teeth before saying so. He was world-famous for the eye that flies. He had spent thirty years finding the pattern that is invisible from inside it — the mass grave that reads as a garden until you’re at four hundred feet, the troop column that’s a thread of dust, the river that’s a vein. He saw the *whole thing*. That was the gift and that was the cage. He could read the Nazca figure perfectly from above and he could not,

physically could not, feel it from below, and walking it now he kept lifting his head to look for the shape, the totality, and there was no totality. There was only the next eight metres of pale road and a low ridge of dark stones and a turn coming up that he hadn't expected.

The turn was the thing.

Because here is what you cannot know from the air, and what Susana made them learn with their knees: the line *moves*. It is arrow-straight where it wants to be and then it commits to a curve, a big swooping confident curve that from above resolves into — a neck, a wing, the start of a tail, who knows, she still hadn't said — and from the ground that curve is an *event*. You walk straight for ninety paces in a trance, sky going gold ahead of you, your own breath the loudest thing on the planet, and then the road *turns*, and your body has to turn with it, and the turning is the whole point. You feel the design decide. You feel a person who has been dead for two thousand years reach out and steer your hips.

"This," Susana said, stopping them on a straight, "is the question your friend the photographer keeps asking with his neck." She didn't look at the Lens. She was being kind. "He wants to see it. From up there it is a picture. A bird, a monkey, a spider — a picture for the sky." She crouched, put two fingers on the bright cleared ground, on the seam where dark met pale. "Down here it is not a picture. Down here there is no bird. There is only this, and the next of this, and the turn. You cannot see the figure while you make the figure. You cannot see it while you *walk* the figure." She straightened. "So. Who is it for?"

Nobody answered. The hydrology-reader opened his mouth — he had a theory, he had eleven theories, his theories arrived in him like weather — and then he closed it again, because the question wasn't really for answering, it was for *standing inside*, and even he could feel that.

The hydrology-reader's problem, this whole trip, was a real one, and it sat on the chapter like a stone.

Because he'd traced it. Two nights ago, by lamplight, with the consortium's open data and the old fault maps, he'd put a line — *this* region of lines — over the geology, and a few of them ran toward the

puquios. The puquios: the corkscrew aqueducts, spiral stone throats that still, today, pull water up out of a desert with twenty minutes of rain a year, real hydro-engineering, no debate. And some lines aimed at faults that channel groundwater to feed those very throats. He had the overlay. He had checked it four times because checking four times is how he is built.

He'd shown Susana. He'd half-expected to be laughed at, or worse, to be *thanked*, the way you thank a child.

She had not laughed. She had looked at the overlay for a long time, longer than was comfortable, and then she'd said the mainstream thing, fair and flat, with full respect for it: *Proulx and the others read these as ritual, as processional, tied to water and fertility through ceremony — not as a map you'd hand a stranger to find a well. The water is in the meaning, not the cartography. Johnson's fault correlation is real and it is a minority view and nobody has closed it. All true. All checkable. She'd handed him back his tablet.*

And then she'd added the part that wasn't in any paper, that was hers to give and that she chose, in that moment, to give: "But you are not wrong that they knew where the water was. Of course they knew. They lived here. The question your overlay does not ask" — and here she tapped the bright ground at her feet, the cleared road they were standing on — "is whether knowing where the water is, and *asking the sky to send it*, are two different things to these people. Or one thing. We do the same. You pray over the field you have already irrigated."

She let that sit. She did not resolve it. She walked on.

The hydrology-reader followed with his tablet dark in his hand and a feeling he disliked very much, which was the feeling of a loop that would not close and was not *supposed* to close, and a person beside him who had known that all along and let him find it himself.

The sun came over the rim while they were on the long curve.

It happens fast on the pampa, because there's no haze, no moisture, no wind to carry the morning anywhere; the desert just tips its face into the light and goes gold all at once, and every line on the plain — and there are hundreds, running for kilometres, arrow-true, a grid

and a tangle and a bestiary scratched into the floor of the world — every one of them filled with a thin lake of shadow along its banked edge, so that for about four minutes the whole pampa was drawn in light, every cleared road glowing pale and every ridge of dark stones throwing a hairline of blue.

The Lens stopped walking.

He had, by reflex, lifted the camera. And then — Marisol watched this happen, and she would carry it — he did not raise it to his eye. He held it at his chest. He stood on the line, on the actual line, with the most famous aerial eye of his generation, and he looked at the ground in front of his boots, at the eight metres of glowing road he could actually reach, and he did not try to see the whole thing.

The shape was up there. The bird or the monkey or the spider, the figure made for the sky, ninety metres of it, perfect, complete, *un-seeable* from where he stood. And he let it be unseeable. He stood inside the part he couldn't see and breathed the cold gold air and was, for once, only a man on a road in the desert at dawn, walking where he was told, behind someone who knew the way.

Marisol counted nothing. This was the remarkable thing. The archivist who woke because the canvas changed, who measures the room because the room was never safe — she stood on a two-thousand-year-old road and her arithmetic simply switched itself off, and there was only the hush, which was not silence — there was the low crunch of five people's boots on hardened crust, there was a fly somewhere, there was the thermos sloshing in Susana's pack — there was only the hush, which is a different thing, the hush of *scale*, of being a very small warm animal standing inside an enormous cold idea that other small warm animals had carried here, stone by stone, basket by basket, in the dark, in a single night, by hand, and finished before the dawn could set the crust and lock it forever.

Jakobus was at the back. He had said nothing the whole walk. He was not looking at the figure and he was not looking at the sky. He was looking at the *turn* — the big committed curve where the road decided to become something — and at the way the line of them, the five walking bodies, had bent to follow it. He had the look he got around a made thing: not *who*, not *how*. He stood very still and

watched the people move along the shape the way water moves down a channel cut for it, and whatever he read there he kept, and handed forward to no one, because it was not his to hand.

Susana stopped them where the curve straightened back out, facing the risen sun, and let them stand.

“There,” she said. Not pointing at anything. “Now you have walked it. Now you can write whatever you like about it.” A small dry mercy in her voice, aimed at the recorders and the tablets and the famous camera held quiet against a chest. “But you will write it differently. That is all I wanted.”

She picked up her thermos. Behind them, two ridges over, faint and mechanical and entirely of another century, came the rising whine of the consortium’s first drone of the morning, lifting off into the gold to map what could only be seen from above.

Susana did not turn to look at it. She poured the tea.

“They’ll get the picture,” she said. “Let them have the picture.”

She handed the first cup to Marisol, who took it in both hands, and found she had no idea at all what the figure was, and minded that, now, not even slightly.

Chapter 7 — Drones at the Edge

The consortium camp went up overnight, the way the lines didn't.

By the time the LENS climbed the low ridge above the pampa at first light, there were four white tents pitched in a neat grid, guy-lines taut, a generator humming somewhere out of sight, and a man in a field vest setting orange cones around a square of dirt as though the desert might be towed away if it wasn't marked. Solar panels angled east, catching the colour the plain was just beginning to throw — that gold that comes up out of the ground at Nazca and lasts maybe twenty minutes before the sun goes white and flattens everything.

The LENS lifted the camera and did not press the shutter.

There is a kind of seeing that costs nothing and a kind that costs you the morning. The LENS had spent thirty years learning the difference, mostly in places where pressing the shutter meant somebody had just died and you were the only one who would remember it correctly. Here nobody was dying. Here a young engineer in a fleece was unspooling a charging cable and yawning, and four drones sat in a foam case like eggs in a carton, and the worst thing happening was that it was being done very, very well.

That was the thing about the consortium. They were good.

Down in the square of cones, the team lead — a Frenchwoman named Cosson, IBM lanyard, DLR cap, the easy posture of someone who had presented at conferences in three languages — crouched over a tablet and talked the engineer through a flight grid. The LENS could hear the words carry up the still air. *Overlap eighty percent. Nadir*

only on this pass, then we do the obliques. The drone went up with a sound like a wasp the size of a dinner plate, hung, and began to mow the sky in straight lines above lines straighter than itself.

Here is what they were doing, told straight, with the respect it has earned.

In 2024 a team out of Yamagata University, working with IBM and the German Aerospace Center, pointed a machine-learning model at the pampa and asked it to find what human surveyors had walked past for ninety years. The model found 303 new figurative glyphs. It nearly doubled the catalogue in a season. Not runways. Not star charts. *Figures* — and the figures sorted themselves into two families that no one had cleanly separated before.

The small ones, the relief-types, average about nine metres and sit a stone's throw — forty-odd metres — from the old footpaths. Four out of five show human themes: dancers, decapitated heads, people leading animals. They are roadside. They are made for the walker, the pilgrim, the foot. You came up the trail and there, where you'd pause anyway, somebody had laid a scene in the gravel for you to read.

The big ones, the line-types, run to ninety metres and better, and the majority of those are wild animals — the spider, the hummingbird, the monkey with its spiral tail — and they are *not* for the foot. You cannot read a ninety-metre monkey with your boots on the gravel. You can only stand inside a fragment of it and wonder why the ground is paler here.

So the great unified Mystery of Nazca, the one von Däniken hung his spacecraft on, turns out to be at least two different things made by people who knew exactly what they were doing and for whom. The science caught up. The case is mostly closed. The consortium's drones were, this very morning, closing it a little further, finding the next nine-metre dancer, the next forty glyphs the human eye had skated over because the human eye does not fly.

It was good work. It deserved the morning light it was getting.

(The fish, from the foam case, in the voice of a drone that has read its own EULA: "Found 303 figures. Filed

303 figures. You're welcome. — also: who, exactly, are you welcome to.")

The LENS came down off the ridge and the local was already at the cones, which was a small lesson the LENS noted and filed: the local was always already there.

Her name was Inés Quispe and she had been born in the shadow of Cahuachi, the great mud cult-centre that broods over the southern edge of the plain, and she had walked these lines as a child before she had degrees that let her say what walking them meant. She was watching the drone the way a farmer watches a hawk over a coop — not afraid, exactly, but counting.

"They have a permit," she said, not quite to the LENS. "It is a good permit. It is for survey only. No excavation, no anchoring, no foot traffic off the marked paths." She let a beat go. "It is the best-behaved thing that has ever come here to take something."

"They're only photographing," the LENS said, and heard how thin it sounded.

Inés smiled, and it was not unkind. "You are only photographing too," she said. "Everyone here is only photographing. That is the whole history of this place — people arriving to record the pampa and leaving with the record. María Reiche came to record it. She stayed forty years and slept in a hut with no water and chased the tour buses off with a broom, and she still left with the record. The difference" — and now she nodded at Cosson's tablet, where the new glyph was already rendering, point-cloud bones assembling into a body — "is whether the record is a gift or a deed."

The LENS waited.

"A patent," Inés said, "is a deed."

The hydrology-reader had drifted to the camp's edge with the particular gravity of someone who has found a wire and needs to know where it goes. He was not looking at the drone. He was looking at the *grid* — the flight pattern Cosson had laid over the plain, the eighty-percent overlap, the obliques — and his hands were doing the thing

his hands did, drawing the lines in the air before his mouth caught up.

“They’re flying the survey north-northeast,” he said. “Same bearing as three of the long lines down by the quebrada. Same bearing as the —” He stopped. He hated stopping. The stop was the loop not closing, and the loop never closed, and he lived in the gap where it didn’t.

“As the fault,” Inés finished for him, gently. “Yes. You have found the thing the man Johnson found.”

David Johnson. The hydrologist who, walking the pampa in the 1990s, noticed that some of the lines — not all, not most, but *some* — seemed to track the geological faults that channel groundwater underground toward the puquios, those corkscrew aqueducts still drawing water out of the driest dirt on the surface of the earth. Mark the line, follow the fault, find the water. A water map, scored in stone, two thousand years before anyone drilled a well.

It is real. The correlation is real. You can stand on certain lines and walk them down to certain springs.

And the mainstream — Proulx at UMass, the weight of the discipline — says: correlation. Says ritual. Says the people who made these lines worshipped water and walked toward water and *of course* their sacred geometry leans toward where the water is, because the water was the whole point of the prayer; that doesn’t make the line a pipe-schematic any more than a cathedral aimed at Jerusalem is a road map to Jerusalem.

The mainstream is probably right. It is right most rounds.

It has not closed the case.

“Does the consortium know?” the hydrology-reader asked. “About the fault lines?”

Inés looked at the tablet for a long moment. “The consortium,” she said, “has the best fault data in the room. Better than mine. They have DLR’s radar. They could close that loop in a week if they wanted.” A pause. “They do not want. There is no patent in a question. There is a patent in a glyph.”

The potato was still drying in the sun two hundred metres off, where the crew had left it the day before: their own attempt at a line, stakes and cord, the easy explanation made flesh. It was wobbly. It bellied left where the cord had sagged, it widened where a boot had skidded, the cleared edge was ragged as a torn hem. The crew had made it in an afternoon with measuring tape and good intentions and it looked like exactly that.

Forty metres from it ran a line the old people had made, possibly in a single night, with nothing but stakes and cord and the patience of the dead. It was arrow-true for a kilometre. It did not belly. It did not widen. You could lay a laser along it.

The LENS had photographed both from the air the previous evening and the contrast was almost cruel — the modern crew's line a child's drawing, the ancient line a ruled mark on the skin of the world — and the strange thing, the thing the LENS kept turning over, was that *the method was the same*. Stakes and cord. No alien tech. No lost technology. A wooden anchor stake at one line's terminus had been radiocarbon-dated; it was a stake, in the ground, where a person had hammered it. The recipe was on the table. The crew had followed it and produced a potato.

Which meant the gap between the potato and the perfect line was not technology.

It was *something else*, and nobody had a patent for it.

The first drone landed itself with the smug little flourish of good firmware and Cosson came over with the tablet held out flat, an offering, because she was — and this mattered, the LENS thought, this was the whole trouble — a decent person doing a clean job.

"You'll want to see this," she said. "We found a new one. Relief-type, your colleague will like it — it's by the old path." She turned the screen. There, rendered out of the point cloud, was a small figure perhaps nine metres long, a person, arms raised, leading something on a line. Forty metres off a footpath. Roadside. A station for the walker. Exactly where the model said the relief-types ought to be, doing exactly what the relief-types did. The system worked. The science was beautiful and it was *winning*.

“It’s lovely,” the LENS said, and meant it.

“We file the catalogue number tomorrow,” Cosson said. “The figure’s morphology, the survey method, the detection pipeline — the pipeline’s the asset, really. The model. Not the man.” She said it lightly, the way you’d say the camera, not the photographer, takes the picture, and she had no idea she’d said anything at all.

Inés had gone very still.

“The figure,” she said, “has been here for two thousand years.”

“Of course,” Cosson said. “We’re not claiming the figure. You can’t patent a figure. We’re claiming the *method of finding it*.”

“You are claiming the way of seeing the dead,” Inés said, and her voice did not rise. That was the frightening part, the LENS thought — it did not rise. “My grandmother walked past that figure her whole life and never saw it because it was made for an eye that flies. Now the eye that flies belongs to you, and the number belongs to you, and the catalogue belongs to you, and tomorrow when a child from Cahuachi wants to know what her ancestors made, she will have to ask your model. That is what you are filing.”

There was a silence with the generator in it.

“That’s —” Cosson started, and stopped, because she was decent, and the decent ones are the only ones who hear it. “That’s not the intent.”

“No,” Inés agreed. “It never is.”

The wind that does not come to Nazca did not come. Twenty minutes of rain a year, and a stillness so total the morning mist can settle and harden the crust to armour and hold a line for two thousand years — and the same stillness means there is no weather to forgive a footprint. The ground is ten, fifteen centimetres of contrast. A boot marks it. A truck would gut it. The lines survive because almost nothing has ever walked here, and now four tents and a generator and a grid of cones sat at the edge of the most fragile drawing on earth, and even the careful ones, the permitted ones, the *best-behaved thing that ever came here to take something* — even they left a mark, in a database, that could not be unmade.

The second drone went up. The wasp-sound climbed and hung over the pampa and began, with perfect overlap, to harvest the next figure no one had been allowed to forget yet.

Inés watched it go. Then she turned to the crew, and to the LENS specifically, the one who saw from the air and could not walk the line.

“Tomorrow before dawn,” she said, “I will take you onto one. With your feet. Not the drone’s path — the *line*.” She looked at the camera in the LENS’s hands, the eye that flew, the gift that was also the cage. “You have all been photographing the answer. I want you to walk the question first.”

Up on the ridge the gold was already burning off to white. Below it the consortium’s drone found something new and bright and ninety metres long, and somewhere a tablet logged the hour, and the date, and the claim.

The LENS did not press the shutter.

For once, that felt like the right photograph.

Chapter 8 — The Water Follows

The thing about a fault is that it does not announce itself. It does not run a flag up a pole. It is a seam in the rock where two slabs of the world have agreed to disagree, and water — which has no patience for argument and infinite patience for everything else — finds the seam and follows it.

Mariela had been awake since four, which was not unusual. She'd laid the consortium's published fault map across the printed survey grid on the floor of the van, weighted the corners with a thermos lid, a tube of zinc cream, and two rocks she was fairly sure were not iron-oxide patinated and therefore allowed to be touched, and she had been kneeling over the overlap long enough that her left foot had stopped reporting in.

She wasn't looking for a glyph. She was looking for the place where the dark and the pale stopped agreeing.

You learn water by reading where it refuses to be. On a normal map you trace the blue lines and feel clever. Here there were no blue lines. Here there had been, by the most generous accounting, about twenty minutes of rain in the last year, dispensed in a fine ungenerous mist that never reached the ground as anything you could drink. The Nazca pampa is one of the driest surfaces on the planet, and the second-driest thing about it is the official literature on whether the lines have anything to do with water at all.

So you read the negative. You read the puquios.

The puquios are the part that nobody argues about, and Mariela loved

them for it. Corkscrew funnels of stacked stone spiralling down into the earth, *ojos*, eyes, the ground opening a polished pupil to let you climb down to where the water still ran. Built by the same people, in the same centuries, in the same dust. They worked. They were *still working*, fifteen hundred years on, delivering water to fields that would otherwise be the same colour as everything else, which was the colour of a thing that has given up.

Nobody disputed the puquios. They were engineering. They were the part of Nazca you could put your hand on and feel cool air come up out of the dark.

What people disputed was the line on the floor of the van that her finger was currently resting on.

“You’ve stopped blinking,” said Tomas, from the driver’s seat, not turning around.

“I blink fine.”

“You blink in a way that means you’ve found something and you’re not ready to be wrong about it yet.”

This was true and she didn’t dignify it. The line — call it Line 14 on the grid, an unromantic designation for a thing that ran arrow-straight across the pampa for the better part of a kilometre and a half — left a hub of converging rays near a low ridge and shot out across the plain on a bearing that Maria Reiche herself had recorded in the forties, in pencil, in a notebook, by hand, alone, in a heat that would have unmade most people. Reiche measured this country with a tape and a plumb line and a broom, sweeping pebbles, defending the lines from tyres and treasure-hunters and her own government, for fifty years. You did not get to be cavalier on ground she had swept.

Line 14 ran true on a bearing of roughly — Mariela checked — one hundred and eighteen degrees. And the consortium’s fault map, which they had cheerfully published as a teaser, all open-access and look-how-clean-our-data-is, showed a fracture in the bedrock running beneath the surface gravels on a bearing of roughly one hundred and sixteen.

Two degrees. Over a kilometre and a half.

She sat back on her heels and let her foot scream.

They walked it because you have to walk it. The LENS would have photographed it from above and seen the geometry entire, and that was the LENS's gift and the LENS's cage — to see the whole figure and never the single stone. Mariela needed the stone. She needed to feel the bearing change under her boots, the way the surface went from the loose dark pavement to something subtly different where the line had been cleared, the pale subsoil only ten, fifteen centimetres down, just deep enough that a boot left a mark and she made a point of not leaving one.

The fish, riding in her chest pocket where the fish rides, observed that two degrees over a kilometre and a half was the kind of error that an enthusiastic person could carry to a conference.

She told the fish it was welcome to swim home.

The line did not waver. That was the thing that got into your teeth out here. The crew's own line — the potato, two days back, the thing they'd made with their own stakes and their own cord and their own honest sweat — had wandered like a drunk crossing a parking lot. This one did not wander. It held its bearing the way a thought holds when you are right about it.

And at the far end, where it slid behind the low ridge, the ground changed. Not dramatically. The dark pavement greened by a few imagined percent, the way the desert lies to you about water when you want it badly. But the green wasn't a lie. There was a *puquio* down there. She'd marked it on the grid. A working one, with a thread of fields below it that some family had been coaxing out of the dust for longer than her family had a surname.

Line. Bearing. Fault. Puquio. Water.

The fish said nothing, which was worse.

She found Esperanza at the Cahuachi base in the last of the light, doing the unglamorous work that was the actual work — cataloguing potsherds in a tray, each one tagged, each one a small dead voice. Esperanza was Cahuachi-born, which she would mention if you needed

her to and never if you didn't, and field-trained in a way that made the consortium's PhDs look like they'd been raised in libraries, which several of them had.

Mariela laid it out. The grid, the fault overlay, the two degrees. She did it carefully, the way you set a glass down on a stone shelf, because she knew what she was holding and she knew it could break in her hand.

Esperanza listened without interrupting. She looked at the overlap. She put one finger on the puquio symbol and one on the line's far terminus and she did not move them for a while.

"You've found Johnson," she said.

Mariela's stomach did something. "I found a line."

"You found David Johnson's line." Not unkind. "Or one like it. He's been arguing this since the nineties — that some lines track the sub-surface faults, that the faults channel the groundwater, that the people who built the puquios would have known where the water moved and that the lines mark it. Trace enough of them and a number do correlate with the hydrology." She set the sherd tray aside. "It is real. The correlation is real. I won't pretend it away to make you feel less clever, and I won't inflate it to make you feel more clever. It is on the map. You read it correctly."

The fish, against all odds, sat very still.

"But," said Mariela, because there was a *but* in the room the size of the ridge.

"But." Esperanza pulled a second printout toward her, the dense one, the survey she'd been doing the cataloguing for. "Proulx and the mainstream — and I'm with them, mostly, on most days — would tell you the correlation is the wrong way around. The water didn't follow the lines. The lines didn't make the water. The water was *already there*. The faults were there before anyone removed a single stone. So when you draw a long straight line across a plain, and the plain has faults in it running the way faults run in this part of the world, you will *hit* some of them. The way that if you throw enough darts you will hit the dartboard, and a few will hit the bull."

"Two degrees over fifteen hundred metres isn't a dart."

“No,” Esperanza agreed, and that was the part that kept Mariela up. She didn’t say *no, you’re wrong*. She said *no* the other way. “It isn’t. That one is good. That one is one of the good ones.” She tapped the terminus. “And here is what we cannot do from a chair. We cannot tell the difference, from the bearing alone, between *this line was drawn to mark the water* and *this line was drawn for a procession that happened to walk toward the puquio because the puquio is where the water and therefore the importance is*. Both put the line and the water in the same place. Both are about water. One is a map. The other is a prayer that points the same direction as a map points, because that’s where the rain has to come.”

This was the part Mariela’s wiring could not let go of, and she didn’t try to make it. People had spent her whole life telling her that the way she saw — the way the patterns surfaced for her, uninvited, refusing to lie down — was a problem to be managed. It wasn’t a problem. It was the instrument. She saw the seam in the world and the water following it because she had spent a life unable to stop watching for the seam in every room she’d ever been made to sit in. You don’t switch that off to be polite. You point it at a desert and you find a line.

“The astronomy people had a bearing too,” Esperanza said, gently, not as a trap. “Hawkins, Aveni — they tested the lines against the stars, against the solstices. And the answer came back: about a fifth of them align with *something*, which is exactly what you’d expect from random lines on a plain full of horizon events. No better than chance. The calendar theory didn’t survive the statistics. It was beautiful and it was wrong and we let it go.” She looked at Mariela. “Water is not the same as stars. I want to be clear. The faults are physical, the puquios are physical, the people needed the water and built the puquios to get it — that is not romance, that is a civilisation surviving in twenty minutes of rain a year. The water *connection* is real in a way the star connection never was. That’s why I won’t dismiss it. I just won’t *close* it.”

“You won’t say it’s a map.”

“I won’t say it’s *only* a map. I won’t say it’s *not* one. I’ll say it’s water either way, and that the difference between marking water and asking

for water might not be a difference these people thought they had to make.” She almost smiled. “You’re hoping I’ll close it for you. The other team in the tents over there is hoping I’ll close it the other way, because a water map is a *finding* and a finding is a paper and a paper is a patent on a method. Everybody wants me to close the door. I keep the door for a living.”

Outside, the consortium’s tents had their generators going, soft and constant, and a drone came home through the last light, blinking, full of data it would convert into a claim. They had the fault map. They had it before Mariela did. The difference was that they were going to publish *the lines follow the water* with a confidence the data didn’t earn, because confidence was the product, and Mariela was going to lie awake knowing that the only honest sentence was the one Esperanza had just refused to improve.

She walked Line 14 again in the morning, alone, in the cold gold hour before the mist burned off and the crust set hard for another day. The mist was the whole reason any of this still existed — it hardened the ground each dawn into a skin that held the lines through fifteen hundred years of almost no weather, an accident of climate so perfect it felt like intent. She held her bearing. The fault ran beneath her boots, unfelt, two degrees off and patient. Ahead, the ground greened by an imagined percent that was not, in fact, imagined, and the puquio waited at the end of the line with its eye open, drinking from the dark.

She did not know if she was walking a map.

She knew the water was at the end of it. She knew the people who made it knew the water was at the end of it. She knew the door Esperanza kept was open, and that the keeper would not be the one to shut it, and that the people in the tents would shut it the wrong way by lunchtime for reasons that had nothing to do with the water and everything to do with the funding round.

The fish, finally, said the only thing worth saying.

It asked whether a line that points at water, made by people who needed water, walked by people who wanted water — whether that line is a map of the water or a request for it, and whether anyone out here had ever once felt the need to choose.

She left no boot mark. She kept walking. The water was down there. It was following the seam. The line was following the water, or the water was following nothing and the line had simply been right.

The theory was on the table now. Esperanza had put it there herself, hands clean, and declined to take it off.

Chapter 9 — The Puquio Spiral

The thing about a hole in the ground is that nobody photographs it.

Mateo had been saying this for three days, mostly to himself, mostly because nobody else would. He was the sound man, the cable-coiler, the one who carried the spare batteries and the lunch and the second tripod that the LENS never used but insisted on having, and he had spent the entire trip looking at the backs of people's heads while they looked at the sky. The LENS looked up. The hydrology-reader — Saoirse — looked down, but only at the soil, the way you'd look at a problem you'd already half-solved and didn't want to admit you couldn't finish. Jakobus looked at things the way a man looks at a knot somebody else tied.

And the desert went on being beautiful in the direction of up, where Mateo's job did not point.

So when the local — Inés, Cahuachi-born, field boots gone the colour of the pampa — said they were going to a puquio that morning, and the LENS said *will it read from the air*, and Inés said *no, you have to go down into it*, Mateo felt something in his chest he didn't have a clean word for. Vindication, maybe. The hole was finally getting its turn.

They drove out past the edge of the lines, where the geometry surrendered to ordinary farmland — a green seam of cotton and maize stitched along a riverbed that wasn't a river, hadn't been a river in any month anyone living could remember. The Rio Nazca ran under-

ground here, or didn't run at all, depending on the season and your definition of running. Inés talked the whole way, not performing, just laying out the country the way you'd hand someone a map and let them keep it.

"This is one of the driest places on the planet," she said. "Roughly twenty minutes of rain a year. Not twenty days. Twenty minutes." She let that hang. "And there were people farming here two thousand years ago. Enough of them to build Cahuachi. Enough to move the stones for everything you flew over yesterday." She nodded at the green. "How?"

"Aqueducts," said Saoirse, fast, the way she answered everything, before her own mouth had cleared the question.

"Aqueducts," Inés agreed, "is the word the brochures use. Come and see one and then decide if it's the right word."

The puquio didn't announce itself. That was the first thing. Mateo had pictured something — an arch, a Roman thing, a structure that said *engineering* in capital letters. What Inés stopped the van beside was a hollow in the ground, a spiralling funnel cut down into the earth like someone had pressed a thumb into clay and turned it. Stone-lined. Stepped. A corkscrew of dry-stacked rock walls descending in tightening rings toward a dark mouth at the bottom where, impossibly, in the driest dirt on Earth, there was the sound of water.

"Okay," said Mateo, out loud, to nobody. "That's worth carrying a tripod for."

The LENS was already walking the rim, head tilted, doing the thing the LENS did — seeing the shape from above before the feet had agreed to it. "It's a spiral."

"It's a spiral," said Inés.

"Why a spiral?"

"That," she said, "is a better question than the one your colleague's about to ask," and Saoirse, who had been opening her mouth, closed it.

They went down. The steps were narrow, worn smooth, set into the

wall of the funnel so that you descended by walking the spiral itself — round and round and down, the daylight tightening to a coin overhead, the temperature dropping with each ring, the sound of water rising to meet the falling temperature until the two of them met somewhere around the fifth turn and the air went cool and wet and green-smelling in a place where nothing green grew.

Mateo got it all on the recorder. The shift in the air had a sound, it turned out. He'd been right about something for once.

At the bottom there was a channel, and in the channel there was water, clear and moving, going somewhere with purpose.

"This is the part nobody believes," Inés said. "It's not a well. A well is a hole you drop a bucket into. This is a machine." She crouched by the channel, dipped two fingers, didn't drink, just felt the current. "The Nazca didn't find water. They went and got it. There are faults in the rock under here, fractures where groundwater moves, deep, where you'd never reach it with a shovel. The puquios are tunnels — *galerías* — dug horizontally to intercept that water and bring it down the slope by gravity to the surface, to the fields." She looked up. "And these spirals you climbed down — the *ojos*, the eyes — they're not decoration. They're access. You climb down to clean the channel, to clear the silt. And the spiral shape opens the tunnel to the air."

"Why does it need air?" Mateo asked, because the recorder was running and somebody should.

Inés smiled like he'd done well. "Wind. The pampa's almost windless up top, but funnel even a little breeze down a spiral and it pressurises the gallery. Pushes the water along. The shape isn't a flourish. It's a pump with no moving parts that's been running for fifteen hundred years and never once needed a battery." She glanced, deliberately, in the direction the consortium's camp lay, kilometres off, full of things that needed batteries.

The LENS had stopped photographing. That, more than anything, told Mateo something had landed. The LENS only stopped when the thing in front of the camera was bigger than the camera.

A pump with no moving parts.

Mateo turned it over while Saoirse and Inés talked faults and flow rates above the water-noise. He thought about the crew's own great humiliation, two days back — the line they'd tried to make themselves. Stakes and cord, the simplest tools, the official method, the method that *worked*, the method that an honest reading of the evidence said the Nazca had used because there was no other method, no laser, no satellite, no anything. They'd hammered the stakes and pulled the cord taut and walked it and lifted the dark stones to show the pale ground beneath, exactly as it was supposed to work.

And their line had come out like a worm. A drunk worm. It wavered. It had a kink at the forty-metre mark where someone — Mateo, possibly — had let the cord sag. From the LENS's drone it looked less like a Nazca line than like a child's drawing of one, and they had all stood around it laughing the particular laugh of people who have just learned that *easy* and *simple* are two completely different words.

Because the ancient lines weren't lumpy. The ancient lines ran arrow-true for kilometres, over rises, across dips, holding their bearing where the crew's cord had wandered in two hundred metres. Same tools. The crust said so; the dated anchor stake said so; the soft, ten-centimetre-deep ground that took a boot-print said so. No mystery in the *how*. The mystery, if you wanted to call it that, was the gap between *we used the same stakes and cord* and *and ours looks like a potato*.

And now here was this. The spiral. Made with the same hands, the same era, the same absence of machinery — and it didn't just *look* right, it *worked*, it was still working, water moving past his boots in the driest country on the planet because people who'd been dead for a millennium and a half had understood pressure and gravity and rock-fracture and wind well enough to build a thing that needed no one to tend it but the silt-cleaner and the seasons.

The people who couldn't be bothered making your line straight, the heckle went, somewhere in the back of his skull, *built a self-pressurising aqueduct in the rock. Just so we're keeping score.*

"There's a thing I should say," Inés said, when they'd climbed back up

and the daylight had reopened over them and the heat came back like a hand on the neck. She said it to all of them but she was watching Saoirse, who had gone quiet on the rim, eyes moving between the spiral and the horizon where the great lines lay invisible from here.

“Go on,” said Saoirse.

“You’re going to draw a line on a map,” Inés said. “From here to one of the lines. You won’t be the first. Some of the lines on the pampa do sit over faults. The same faults the puquios tap. There’s a man — Johnson — who spent years on it, who’ll tell you the geoglyphs are a water map, that a line points at where the water runs, that the trapezoids mark the aquifers.” She let the wind that wasn’t there fail to move her hair. “And I want to be honest with you, because you’ve been honest with me. He’s not a crank. The correlation is real. You can measure it. I’ve measured it.”

“But,” said the LENS.

“But correlation isn’t a legend on a map,” Inés said. “Proulx and the people who’ve worked this their whole lives — they’ll tell you the lines are ritual. Processions. Walking the line was the point. Water and the lines are tied together, yes, but tied the way a prayer is tied to rain, not the way a pipe is tied to a tap. You walk the line to *ask* for the water. You don’t read the line to *find* it.” She picked up a reddish stone, the patinated kind, turned it, set it back exactly where it had been. “The water map is the minority view. The honest answer is that nobody has closed it. The faults are there. The lines are there. They overlap more than they should by accident and less than they would if it were a deliberate chart. And that gap—” she gestured at the air between her two hands “—is where everyone, including me, would very much like to live, and can’t, because we don’t have the evidence to.”

Saoirse said nothing. Mateo watched her not say it. He knew that silence. It was the silence of a pattern-finder who had found a pattern and been told, kindly, by someone who knew more, that finding it was not the same as proving it. It wasn’t a defeat. It was worse than a defeat. It was an *open door* with a sign that said *we don’t know what’s through here either*.

They didn't film much after that, which was unusual, and right.

The consortium's drones came over once, high and patient, a pale flicker that Mateo only noticed because he was the one who noticed things at the edges. Inés watched them go without comment. Up there they were mapping the surface, every line, every glyph, three hundred new figures the AI had pulled out of the noise last year, ritual stations along the footpaths, animal-figures only the sky could read — building a catalogue, a dataset, a thing you could own. Down here was a hole in the ground with water in it that no scan from above would ever explain, because the whole truth of it was on the inside of the spiral, in the cool and the dark, in the air-pump that the satellite could not feel.

Map all you like, Mateo thought at the drones. You'll get the picture. You won't get the cold.

Before they left, he went back to the rim alone, recorder off, just to look down into it one more time.

From up here, on the surface, with the heat shimmering and the green fields a smudge to the south, the spiral was just a shape in the dirt. A whorl. A thumbprint pressed into the most patient surface on Earth. You could stand where he stood and not know there was water in it. You could fly over and photograph it and file it and never feel the fifth turn where the air changes.

He thought about the line-figures, the great ones, the hummingbird and the monkey and the spider, the ones that only resolve from the air, the ones the books all worried at — *made for feet, seen only by the sky*. Everyone wanted that to be a riddle with an answer. And here, in front of him, was a spiral made for feet *and* the sky and the rock and the wind all at once, by people who built a machine to outlive empires and couldn't, or wouldn't, or didn't bother to, draw the crew a straight line two hundred metres long.

He looked down the corkscrew of stone, turn tightening into turn into the dark mouth where the water spoke, and he found he didn't want the answer to who. He wanted the descent. He wanted the cold to come back.

Somewhere down there, fifteen hundred years of hands had cleaned

this channel. They'd walked this spiral, round and down, round and down, into the only wet place in the dry, and they'd never once asked it to be visible from above.

Mateo turned off the recorder he'd already turned off, and stood at the lip of the eye, and let the question stay a question.

Who taught the wind to climb a stair.

Chapter 10 — Shadow Over the Plain

The mist came in off the Pacific the way it always did, low and grey, dragging itself across the pampa an hour before the sun got serious about anything. The LENS stood at the edge of the camp with a coffee going cold in one hand and watched the moisture settle onto the crust, and felt — not for the first time — that the desert was being made all over again every morning, sealed and signed, an envelope nobody would ever open.

“It does that,” said Inés, behind her. The local archaeologist had come up quiet, the way she always did, in boots that knew exactly where the loose stones were. “The fog. Twenty minutes of rain in a year, and the rest comes like this. The crust hardens. The line stays.”

“Maria Reiche’s miracle,” the LENS said.

“Reiche’s, the climate’s.” Inés crouched, brushed two fingers across the ground without quite touching the pale strip beside her. “And whoever decided to make something here instead of somewhere it would have washed away in a season. You don’t draw on the one surface on Earth that keeps it forever by accident.”

The LENS said nothing. She was thinking about altitude.

They had the facts, by now. The crew had laid them out three nights running over instant noodles and a bottle of Inés’s father’s pisco, the official story given its full and proper weight, because it had earned it. The lines were made by lifting the dark, iron-stained pebbles — ten centimetres deep, fifteen at most — and stacking them along

the edges so the pale subsoil showed through in a clean ribbon. No lasers. No lost civilisation with a grudge against the laws of physics. Stakes and cord. They'd carbon-dated a wooden anchor stake at the end of one line and it had behaved exactly like an old piece of wood, no more, no less. Four hundred BC to five hundred AD, give or take, the Paracas first and the Nazca after, with the great hollow city of Cahuachi brooding over all of it like a tide that had gone out and left its temples on the sand.

And the figures. The 2024 work out of Yamagata, the AI sweeping the pampa and pulling three hundred new glyphs out of the noise — that had done more than any single thing to put the wildness to bed. Because the AI had found a *pattern in the patterns*. The little ones, the relief-types, nine metres across, never far from a footpath, four out of five of them showing people — these were roadside shrines, near enough. Stations. Something you came across with your own two feet, the way you might pass a wayside cross on a mountain road and slow down without quite deciding to. And the big ones, the line-types, ninety metres and more, two-thirds of them animals — these were the communal ones, the great public figures.

It wasn't one mystery. That was the thing the crew kept coming back to, the thing that had let the air out of so much of the old fever. It was two systems, doing two jobs, and both of them human-scaled, both of them about ritual and water and the dead and the rain that came twenty minutes a year and meant everything.

So that was settled. Mostly. The LENS believed it. She'd photographed enough of the world from enough heights to know that most mysteries were just a question of getting the right distance, and the AI had found the right distance and the mystery had resolved into structure, the way a halftone print resolves into dots when you stop pressing your nose to it.

Mostly.

There was just the one thing she couldn't get to lie down.

She'd been up at first light in the small plane, the door off, harness biting her hip, the way she'd shot battlefields and mudslides and the long brown rivers of refugees on roads, except this time there was

nothing moving and nothing dying and the only thing under her was the ground holding completely still and showing her a hummingbird the size of a stadium.

The hummingbird. The monkey with its spiral tail. The spider, the one she'd flown over twice because the second pass she still didn't believe the first. From up here they were perfect. Not nice. Not roughly right. *Perfect* — the long beak of the hummingbird running arrow-straight for the better part of a hundred metres without a wobble in it, a single unbroken stroke laid down by people who could not, from where they stood, see what they were drawing.

That was the part. She came down with it lodged in her like a splinter and she took it to the one person on the pampa who'd earn the right to be irritated by her.

"You can see the spider," the LENS said. She had the contact sheet out on the tailgate, fresh off the morning's flight, the figures small and sharp in the grey. "I can see the spider. The condor can see the spider. Who, on the ground, in four hundred BC, ever saw the spider?"

Inés didn't look at the contact sheet right away. She looked at the LENS.

"You want me to say no one," she said.

"I want you to tell me how they made a figure that perfect that they couldn't stand back from. You can't draw a ninety-metre animal free-hand by walking it. You can't. I've tried to draw a *table* without measuring and it comes out drunk." She tapped the spider. "There's no error in this. There's no place where they ran out of room and had to fudge it. From above it's flawless. From the ground it's — it's a path. A scratch. You couldn't tell a spider from a shopping list."

A few feet away, the hydrology-reader had gone very still in the way that meant he was listening with his whole spine. He had his notebook open, the one with the fault overlays, and he hadn't written anything in four minutes, which for him was a held breath.

Inés picked up the contact sheet then. Held it at arm's length, the small precise figures catching the flat light.

“Maria Reiche thought they used scale models,” she said. “Small drawings, then a grid of stakes and cords to enlarge them out across the ground, segment by segment. There’s evidence for the method. Stakes. Cords. The geometry of how a curve was struck — you can find the centre points of the arcs, the post-holes, the radius. The monkey’s spiral is made of arcs, did you know? Real ones. You can pace out the centres.” She set the sheet down. “It is not magic. People did this. People with rope and patience and a culture that thought it was worth doing. I want to be very clear, because your viewers will not be: there is no step in the making of these that we cannot explain.”

“I know,” the LENS said. “I believe you. The how is solved.” She put her finger back on the spider and left it there. “I’m not asking how. I’m asking who it was *for*. Because you don’t lay down a hundred-metre line dead-true segment by segment, you don’t carry a model and a survey crew across this furnace, you don’t *bother* — for something no one on the ground was ever going to see whole.”

For the first time since the LENS had met her, Inés smiled without anything underneath it.

“There it is,” she said. “That’s the question everyone’s plane brings down.”

The consortium camp was visible from where they stood, a cluster of white tents and the low whine of drone props warming up for the day’s grid. They’d add a dozen new glyphs to the catalogue before noon, probably. The AI was good. The AI was, the LENS privately conceded, better than her — it never blinked, never got vertigo, never had a bad morning in the back of a Cessna with the ghost of a road in Aleppo coming up under the wing. It mapped. It found. It would find more than Reiche found in forty years of walking the ground with a broom, sweeping the crust off the lines one square metre at a time, sleeping in a hut out here for decades because she could not bear for the lines to be paved or ploughed or driven over.

And here was the thing that the drones couldn’t touch and the AI couldn’t weigh, the thing that sat in the data like a stone in a shoe.

The relief-types — the small ones — those *worked* for feet. Of course

they did. Nine metres, beside a path, a human figure you came on at walking pace. You saw those whole, standing over them. The AI had even quantified it — clustered near footpaths, sized for the ground. Beautiful. Coherent. Made for the eye that travels on legs.

But the line-types. The big animals. The spider, the monkey, the hummingbird. Ninety metres, a hundred and twenty. You could walk the whole length of the hummingbird's beak as a path — and people did, the lines themselves were walkable, soft enough that her own boot had left a mark she'd winced at and brushed out — you could process along it, single file, in some rite no one alive had the words for.

But you would never, ever, on the ground, see *the bird*.

That was the hole. Not aliens — von Däniken's runways were a joke and the ground would slump under a wheelbarrow, let alone a spacecraft; the soil was ten centimetres of loose pebble over soft fill and it marked under a sandal. Not a star map — Hawkins ran the alignments in '73 and Aveni again in '82 and barely one in five lined up with anything in the sky, which is exactly the rate you'd get from throwing darts. The calendar theory was dead and had a coroner's report. The wildness had been cleared out, room by room, by people doing careful, unglamorous work, and the LENS loved them for it.

It just left this one room. The figures made for feet that only resolve for eyes that fly.

"I keep waiting," the LENS said, quieter now, "for someone to tell me they did see them. Some hill. Some platform. That they had a place to stand back."

"There isn't one," said Inés. "Not for the big figures. The pampa is flat. Cahuachi's a few mounds, and you can't see the line-figures from the mounds, I've checked, I grew up checking." She said it without weight, the way you'd report a tide table. "People have looked for the grandstand for a hundred years. There's no grandstand."

The hydrology-reader spoke for the first time, half to himself. "Some of the long lines run to the puquios, though. Toward the fault traces. Where the water comes up." He glanced at Inés, careful, knowing the ground he was on. "Johnson's overlays. A minority of them track the groundwater."

“A minority,” Inés agreed, and she gave him the full courtesy of it, no scorn. “Some do. Johnson saw it and he wasn’t wrong that the correlation exists. And Proulx and the mainstream will tell you correlation isn’t a map — that the water and the lines both follow the lie of the land, the faults, the slopes, and you’d expect them to share geometry without one being a chart of the other. That the lines are about water the way a prayer is about rain. Not a map. A petition.” She held up a hand before the hydrology-reader could light up. “And nobody has closed that. I won’t pretend it for you on camera. Some lines go to the water. What that means is not settled.”

The LENS watched him write it down at last, three quick words, his shoulders coming down a degree.

But she was still on the spider.

“All right,” she said. “Forget the water. Tell me about the bird. You’re a Nazca person — your great-times-fifty grandmother maybe carried a basket of black stones to the edge of that line. You. Why make a thing perfect for a viewer that can’t exist?”

Inés looked at the contact sheet for a long moment. Then she looked up — not at the LENS, but past her, up, at the thinning grey where the sun was about to win.

“You’re asking it like there’s only one kind of seeing,” she said. “You fly. So for you, the bird is finished when *someone sees the whole bird*. A photograph isn’t done until there’s an eye on it. That’s your trade. I understand it.”

“It’s everyone’s trade. You make a thing to be seen.”

“Is it.” Inés crouched again by the pale ribbon at their feet, and this time she did lay her palm on it, flat, the way you’d put a hand on an animal’s flank. “When my grandmother set a candle at the saint and no one was in the church — was the candle wasted? When you fold the corner of a letter you’ll never send — for whom? You make things to be *received*. That’s not always an eye.”

“Then who receives a hundred-metre spider nobody’s allowed to see?”

“Maybe nobody who walks,” Inés said. “Maybe it was never for us.”

She wasn't smiling now. She wasn't doing anything for the camera; the LENS could tell, because the LENS had spent her whole life learning to tell when a face had stopped performing. "You build a cathedral ceiling so high and so beautiful that no one on the floor can read it. We say the carvings up there are for God. Not because God needs to read them. Because the *making* of them, true and whole and perfect, where only the sky can take it in — that is the offering. The line is straight because it is *meant to be straight*, not because someone needed to admire that it was straight. You walk the bird's beak in procession, single file, asking for rain. You will never see the bird. The bird is not for you. The bird is for whatever's up there with you in that little plane every morning, and a great deal older."

The hydrology-reader had stopped writing.

"Sometimes," Inés said, "a thing is made for the gods, and not for people. And then it doesn't matter at all whether anyone can stand back to see it. You did the standing-back for them this morning. They never needed to."

The fog was burning off the east edge now, and somewhere over by the consortium tents a drone went up with a sound like a wasp in a jar, climbing to map what it could measure and patent what it could map.

The LENS looked at her contact sheet. The spider sat there, sharp, flawless, a hundred metres of intention that no Nazca eye had ever held entire — unless you allowed that the seeing it was built for had never been an eye at all, and at that point you had walked clean out of archaeology and into the open desert with no instrument that would read.

She didn't say *but*. She didn't have one. The how was solved and the who was solved and the when was solved, and right here, at the centre of the cleared house, was a single room with the door standing open and the wind going through it.

"You're not going to tell me," the LENS said.

"I told you what I have," Inés said. She stood, brushed her palm clean on her trousers, and started back toward the van, toward the day. "It might be for the gods. It might be for some standing-back I can't find. It might be both, and a hundred other things, and the people

who knew are under Cahuachi with the cloth gone to dust around them.” She paused, and for a moment she looked almost kind. “You wanted me to close it for you. I won’t lie to do that. Take your picture. Leave the question where it lives.”

She walked on.

The LENS stood at the lip of the pampa with the spider in her hands and the sky coming up gold behind it, and let the door stay open.

Chapter 11 — The Builder's Hand

The second attempt began with an apology to the cord.

Tomás had brought new line — mason's twine, braided, the kind that doesn't stretch when you breathe on it. Cheap nylon had cost us the first try; we'd watched our debut "line" wander off true by the time it reached the third stake, a slow drift you couldn't see at ground level but that the LENS had read instantly from forty metres up, the way she read everything, all at once, the whole shape arriving before the detail. *That's a banana*, she'd said. Not unkindly. A banana is a thing made by people who meant to make a straight line and were defeated by their own kneecaps.

So: new cord. Better stakes — proper rebar pins this time, not the tent pegs we'd improvised. A bubble level, because we were embarrassed and overcorrecting. We had become, in the space of a day, the kind of people who think the problem is equipment.

The pampa did not care.

It lay out around us the colour of an old penny, flat to the horizon in a way that broke something in the inner ear — no tree, no rise, nothing for the eye to grab. The reddish stones held the heat from yesterday and gave it back through my boots. I crouched and turned one over: dark and varnished on top, that iron-oxide patina the desert paints on over centuries, pale and soft underneath where no sun had ever touched. Lift the stone, you reveal the under-skin. Lift a thousand of them in a row and you've made a line. That's the whole trick. That is genuinely, provably the whole trick, no aliens required, and it is the trick that has humiliated us twice.

"Sightline first," said Tomás. He set his eye low to the first pin and sighted down the desert toward a stone we'd cairned half a kilometre off. "You walk to me. I wave you onto the line."

I walked. He waved. Left a little. Now right. Stop. I planted a flag where I stood. We were doing it the way Maria Reiche said the Nazca probably did it — two end points, a person between, corrected by eye — and on paper it is beautiful and simple and the kind of explanation that lets you sleep. Two posts and a guy in the middle. The radiocarbon date came off a real wooden anchor stake at a real line terminus; the method isn't a theory, it's a leftover. They left their stakes in the ground for us to find.

The flag I'd planted, when Tomás sighted past it to the cairn, was forty centimetres off line.

"Forty," he called.

"That's not me," I said. "That's the heat."

It was, partly. The air over the pampa boils up in columns by ten in the morning, and a thing half a kilometre away shimmies inside its own ghost, so that the cairn I was aiming at was never quite where the cairn was. You can wait for the cool. Reiche worked at dawn for exactly this reason, and at dawn the desert lies still as held breath. But we were here at ten because we are not patient people, which is its own small data point about the difference between us and them.

The LENS's voice came thin through the radio clipped to my collar. She was on the slope behind Cahuachi with the long lens and the drone controller, watching us be small.

"You're bending again," she said.

"We have a *level*."

"A level tells you flat. It doesn't tell you straight." A pause, the wind taking it. "From up here your new line's got a kink at the third pin. Like a knee."

The hydrology in me — the part that can't not look — had already clocked the why before she finished. The third pin sat on a fan of looser gravel where some long-dead sheet flood had spread its load, decades or centuries back, a paler tongue of finer grit cutting across

our work. When Tomás drove the rebar there, the ground gave differently; the pin had walked maybe a centimetre as he hammered, and we'd anchored our whole sightline to a thing that wasn't where we thought. The desert isn't flat. It only looks flat. Underneath the penny-coloured skin it's a record of every rare and violent rain it's ever had, twenty minutes a year of it, laid down and dried and laid down again, and you cannot see the record but you can feel it through a length of rebar if you're the kind of person who feels things through rebar.

I am that kind of person. I have always been that kind of person. It got me sent out of three classrooms before I understood that other people weren't reading the floor.

"Move the pin," I said. "Off the fan. There's softer ground there, it'll never hold true."

Tomás looked at me. "You can see that?"

"I can feel where it'll be wrong before we make it wrong." Which sounds like a boast and is in fact the opposite — it is the thing that makes me terrible at parties and useful here, the inability to stop the world from arriving.

We moved the pin. Re-sighted. Re-walked. By noon we had four hundred metres of something that, from where I stood inside it, looked like a line. Clean enough. Honest work.

Mara came down off the slope to look at it with us — Mara, who was born forty minutes from where we stood, who'd dug at Cahuachi as a student and now spent her seasons keeping people like us from loving the place to death. She walked the length of our line slowly, head down, the way you'd read a footprint. She didn't sight it. She didn't level it. She just walked it, and at the far pin she stopped and stood for a while with her hands in her jacket pockets, and the kindest thing about her was that she wasn't laughing.

"Better than yesterday," she said.

"Don't," said Tomás.

"No, truly. Yesterday was a banana." A small grin. "Today is a — what is the long vegetable —"

"Don't say it."

"A courgette."

The fish, somewhere in the back of the van, opens one eye: lads, you've graduated from fruit to veg, that's the species moving forward.

I crouched at the far pin and sighted back the way she'd walked. From here it held — almost. There was a softness in the middle distance, a place where the eye wanted to slide off the edge of the line and onto the desert beside it, the way your tongue finds the gap where a tooth used to be. Not a kink you could measure with a level. A wrongness you could only see when you got your eye down to the dirt and looked along it the way the cord wanted you to look.

The LENS sent the drone up and across, and we crowded the screen in the shade of the van's open door, and there it was: ours, and beside it, on the same frame because she'd lined up the shot to shame us, a real one.

The ancient line ran off the top of the picture toward Cahuachi and did not deviate. Not a knee. Not a courgette. It ran arrow-true across the same broken ground that had bent us at the third pin — across the same gravel fan, you could see the paler tongue of it cutting under the line — and it simply did not care. Two thousand years of mist and the rare violent rains and not one boot of correction since, and it held its truth so completely that the eye refused to believe a hand had made it. Beside it our courgette wobbled along like a thing apologising for itself.

"They didn't have a level," I said. To no one. To the screen.

"They didn't have a deadline," said Mara.

That landed harder than the drone shot. I looked at her.

"You came at ten," she said, not accusing, just placing it. "You wanted it done today. They —" a tip of the head at the long true line on the screen — "I think they came at dawn, when the air doesn't lie, and I think they came many dawns. You are trying to learn in two days what was a craft. A craft you grow up inside." She shrugged. "It is not magic. People want it to be magic. It is worse than magic. It is *practice you can't buy back.*"

I have thought about that sentence a great deal since.

Because here is the thing about being the way I am — I can find

the pattern, I can feel the fan of gravel through the steel, I can tell you why the third pin walked. What I cannot do is what their hands did, which was nothing clever at all and everything I can't reach: do it again, and again, in the cold blue before sunrise, sighting down a cord with an eye trained from childhood by people who'd been doing it for centuries, in a place where one rain a year means the line you walk to fetch water might be the same line your grandmother walked to ask for it. I can read the made thing. I cannot make it. There's a humility in that I'm still swallowing.

"So it's just — better workers," Tomás said, a little crestfallen, because he'd hoped, I think, for something stranger. We all had. You come to Nazca half-wanting it to defeat the obvious.

"It is the obvious," Mara said, "done by people who were not us." She crouched and lifted one of the dark stones off our line's edge and turned it pale-side-up in her palm. "This is all it ever was. Stones moved. The 2024 survey, the AI — they found three hundred more glyphs and they did not find one new tool. No machine. No trick we don't have. Stakes. Cord. Eyes. Feet." She set the stone down precisely where it had been, which I noticed, and which mattered. "The mystery was never *how*. People keep solving *how* like it's the lock. *How* was always open."

She straightened, brushed the grit from her knees.

"You want to know why your line bends and theirs doesn't?" She pointed at the LENS, still up on the slope, a small dark shape against the penny ground with a camera that could read the whole pampa at once and a body that, she'd told us, couldn't sleep through a thunderstorm without going somewhere bad. "Ask her why she can see your kink from forty metres and not feel the gravel under her own boot. Same coin. Different face. She reads from above. I read from the feet." A beat. "The builders read from both, every dawn, for five hundred years, until it was as ordinary to them as walking."

Lost, I wanted to say. The word that had been sitting in my throat all morning. Not lost like a UFO crashed and we covered it up. Lost the way a craft is lost — the wooden stake left in the ground, the hand that drove it gone, and the gap between the two filled now with our levels and our drones and our courgette, none of which can put back the practice you can't buy.

I sighted down our line one more time, eye to the dirt, into the shimmer. The soft place in the middle distance was still there. It would always be there. We could level it and level it and it would hold its small wrongness, because we'd come to the desert wanting an answer by lunchtime and the desert keeps a different clock.

"Mara." I didn't look up from the cord. "The faults. The lines that run toward the puquios — the ones Johnson mapped." Because I'm the hydrology one, and the soft tongue of gravel under the third pin had been talking to me all morning about water, the old rare floods, where it went, where it still goes underground to feed the corkscrew aqueducts that have never once stopped working. "If they built like this — by feel, by dawn, by knowing the ground in their boots the way I'll never know it — then some of them *would* have felt the faults. The looser ground over a fault. The way I felt the fan." I made myself say it carefully, because I knew the mainstream view and I respect it, Proulx and the rest, ritual not map, correlation not function, and the door not yet closed by anyone. "Not a map they drew. A thing they walked over so many dawns they knew where the water hid."

Mara was quiet long enough that the wind filled it.

"Maybe," she said.

Just that. Not the door slammed. Not the door flung. The keeper's *maybe*, given on her own ground, in her own time, hers to give or keep, and I understood I'd been handed exactly as much as she meant to hand and no more, and that this was the most honest answer anyone had offered me since I landed.

The LENS came down the slope with the drone cradled in both arms. She looked at our line in the dirt, then at the frame still glowing on the screen — ours bent, theirs true, the gravel fan running under both like a confession neither of us could read all the way down.

"Pack it?" she said.

I looked at the courgette one last time. Four hundred metres of our best, our level, our braided cord, our reading of the world, and it would never be a Nazca line. It would never even be close. We'd learned exactly how easy it was — stones, stakes, eyes, feet — and exactly how far that easy was from us, which is the whole distance between knowing how a thing is done and being the hand that does it.

“Pack it,” I said.

We left the pins in the ground. It seemed rude, somehow, to pull them — to take even the courgette away clean, when the people who made the true lines had left their stakes for us to find two thousand years on. Let the desert have ours. Let some future crew dig up a rebar pin and radiocarbon-date the rust and wonder what fool came at ten in the morning thinking a level would save them.

Behind us, on the slope toward Cahuachi, the long line held its truth into the haze and did not bend, and Mara walked it home with her hands in her pockets, reading the ground through her boots in a language I could feel the shape of and would never, not in two days or twenty years, learn to speak.

Chapter 12 — The Procession

The note came taped to the van's side mirror at four in the morning, in handwriting that pressed hard enough to dent the paper. *Bring water. Wear closed shoes. Do not film without asking. — M.*

I am the one who reads notes. This is my job on the crew, more or less — I read the room, the schedule, the small print, the thing nobody else thinks to turn over. The others say I notice the way other people breathe. They mean it kindly. I have learned to take it kindly. So I read the note four times standing in the cold blue dark, and what I noticed was the order of the instructions. Water first. Then the shoes. Then, almost as an afterthought, the part about the camera.

That told me the camera was the least of it. That told me Marisol had been thinking about feet.

She was Cahuachi-born, and she walked the way people walk who have walked a place their whole lives — not fast, not slow, just inevitable, the gait of someone who already knows where the soft sand is and where the crust will hold. By dawn there were maybe forty of us strung out on the edge of the pampa: farmers from the valley, two schoolteachers, an old woman in a cardigan the colour of dust who had brought a thermos, a man with a baby in a sling, three teenagers who looked like they would rather be anywhere, Marisol, us. The consortium was not invited. I noticed that too. I noticed it the way you notice a missing tooth with your tongue.

“This is not a tour,” Marisol said, to me specifically, because I was

the one with the clipboard and the lanyard and the face that asks permission. “Nobody is going to explain anything to you. You walk, or you don’t.”

“We walk,” said the LENS.

She looked at the LENS for a long moment. The LENS had their kit on — the camera that costs more than the van, the harness, the eye that has photographed this plain from a Cessna at four hundred metres and made the prints that hang in galleries in Berlin and Tokyo. Marisol’s look was not unkind. It was the look you give someone who can read sheet music but has never heard the song.

“You walk on the ground today,” she said. “All the way down. No plane.”

The LENS’s jaw did a small thing. They left the camera in the van.

Here is the official story, and it is a good one, and it has mostly won.

The line we were going to walk is a line-type figure’s access path — one of the long arrow-straight scratches that run for a kilometre and more across the pampa, made by the Nazca people sometime between four hundred years before Christ and five hundred years after, by lifting away the dark, iron-rusted pebbles that armour this desert and exposing the pale ground a hand’s depth beneath. That’s the whole trick. That’s all a line is. It is a strip of removed stone. There is no carving, no foundation, no engineering you couldn’t teach a child. Stakes and cord. They found one of the anchor stakes at a line’s end and put it through radiocarbon and the date came back right where it should. No mystery in the method. None at all.

And the *purpose* — the science has caught up there too, mostly. In 2024 a team out of Yamagata, working with an AI trained to find them, turned up three hundred and three new figurative glyphs nobody had catalogued. They sorted into two clean families. The little ones, the relief-type, sit beside footpaths, average a few metres across, and four out of five of them show *people* — figures, dancers, processioners. Roadside shrines, basically. Stations you pass on a walk. And the big ones, the line-type, the spider and the monkey and the hummingbird the size of football pitches, are mostly wild animals and mostly only legible from above.

Two purposes. Two audiences. The feet and the eye of the sky. Proulx at UMass spent his career on this and his answer is patient and unsexy and almost certainly right: ritual. Procession. Water and fertility, asked for with the body. Not a runway, von Däniken, you absolute legend, the ground's too soft, a boot leaves a mark in it, a Boeing would sink to the axles. Not a star calendar either — Hawkins ran the alignments in '73, Aveni ran them again in '82, and only one line in five points at anything in the sky, which is exactly what you'd get by drawing lines at random. The calendar's dead. Has been for fifty years. The gift shop hasn't been told.

So the mystery is solved. Mostly. That's the part you're supposed to take away.

We started walking.

(The fish, riding in the cooler where we keep the water bottles: "Three hundred years to draw a line you can't even see from the ground, and the conclusion is 'they were religious.' Bold. Brave. Closes nothing. Walk on, little pilgrim.")

The thing nobody tells you about the pampa is how *quiet* it is. Not peaceful-quiet. Pressure-quiet. The wind that should be here isn't — this is one of the stillest surfaces on the whole planet, twenty minutes of rain in a year, no wind to speak of, which is the entire reason the lines have lasted two thousand years when a single wet windy decade would have erased them. You walk into that silence and your own pulse gets loud. The teenagers stopped being bored. The baby stopped fussing. The old woman with the thermos walked at the front with Marisol and said nothing and her not-saying-anything had weight.

The crust crunched. That was the only sound — forty pairs of feet breaking the thin mineral skin the morning mist lays down and hardens, the skin that armours everything out here. It made me flinch the first time. I am the one who flinches. I had read, on the clipboard, in my own neat handwriting copied from the dossier, that the lines are only ten to fifteen centimetres deep and the ground is soft enough for a boot to mark it. I knew it as a fact. Walking it was different. Every step I took, I left a thing. Forty of us, leaving things, all morn-

ing. I started to count my own footfalls and had to stop because the number frightened me.

“You’re worried about the damage,” Marisol said. She had dropped back to walk beside me. She does that — appears at your shoulder having already read whatever your face is doing.

“We’re standing on it. We’re *walking* on it. I read that the consortium got fined for one drone landing—”

“Their drone landed where no one walks. This—” she gestured down the line, ahead and behind, at the broken crust, at the forty of us, “—this is the path. This is *for* walking. It was made to be walked. You think it survives despite us?” She almost smiled. “It survives because of us. The path that is walked is the path that is kept. The crust mends. The line is renewed by the feet that ask.”

I wrote that down later. I am the one who writes things down. At the time I just felt it land somewhere under the sternum.

We came to a station — a relief-type glyph beside the path, small, a couple of metres of figures I would not have seen if Marisol had not stopped. Worn human shapes in the pale ground, holding hands maybe, or holding something between them. The old woman set her thermos down. Somebody began to sing, low, in a language that wasn’t Spanish, and the teenagers knew the words, which undid me a little, because I had decided the teenagers didn’t care and I had been wrong, and being wrong about people is the thing I am supposed to be good at avoiding.

The LENS stood very still beside the figures. I watched the LENS more than the figures, because watching people is what I do when feeling things gets to be too much. The LENS has photographed this exact relief-type station from above — I’d seen the print, it’s a famous one, the figures crisp and complete and *readable*, the whole composition handed to you in a single frame the way only the air can hand it to you. From up there it is a picture. A solved thing. A glyph in a catalogue with a number.

Down here, at the figures’ own height, with the song going and the crust broken under our boots and the cold coming off the ground, the LENS couldn’t see the picture at all. You can’t. You’re too close. You

see a few worn lines in dirt and the backs of the people in front of you and the old woman's thermos. The composition only exists from four hundred metres up, where no one prays. The prayer only exists down here, where the composition can't be seen.

The LENS turned to me with an expression I don't have a clean word for. "I've never been *in* one," they said. "I've only ever been *over* them."

Our potato, by the way, was three days behind us and forty kilometres west, where we'd staked out our own honest line with cord and shovels and the best intentions in the world, and produced a wobbling, lumpy, drunk-looking scratch that any Nazca ten-year-old would have laughed at. We'd done it to feel the method. The method humbled us. Their lines run arrow-true for a kilometre across ground that rolls and dips, and ours bent like a garden hose inside fifty metres. We didn't talk about it much after. The hydrology-reader had photos of it and wouldn't let anyone delete them. "Keep the potato," they said. "The potato is data." The potato is, in fact, the most honest thing we made on the whole trip.

I thought about the potato while the song went on. Whoever drew this line could draw. Could *draw*, at scale, in the dark — the consensus is they worked these by night and morning before the heat, which means the straightest lines on Earth were laid by people who could not see where they ended. That's not in dispute. That's just true and nobody fully explains the *how* of holding a line dead straight over a kilometre by lamplight and faith. The method is simple. The mastery is not. Those are different things and the debunk likes to pretend they're the same.

(Fish, muffled, from the cooler: "Simple tools, perfect result. I do this every day, it's called talent, and it makes archaeologists nervous because you can't carbon-date talent.")

The line we walked ran on toward a low place in the ground, and the hydrology-reader had gone quiet and intense in the way that means they've found a pattern and are afraid to say so. They drifted up to

Marisol's shoulder. I caught the edge of it.

"This line," the hydrology-reader said carefully. "It's heading down-grade. There's a puquio that direction, isn't there. The line's running toward water."

Marisol kept walking. "Some lines do."

"Johnson mapped that. The faults, the groundwater, the lines tracking the—"

"Johnson is one man and his idea is a small idea inside a big one." She said it without heat. "You want it to be a map. Outsiders always want it to be a map. A map is a thing you can take a photograph of and own." A glance, level, not cruel, at the LENS, at me, at all of us and our kit and our lanyards. "Maybe some lines point at water because the people who made them were *asking* for water. The line that asks for rain and the line that points at the spring — to you these are different. To them, walking it, what is the difference? You walk toward the water *and* you ask the water to come. The asking and the pointing are the same act."

The hydrology-reader opened their mouth. Closed it. Did not close the loop. They never quite do. It is their whole magnificent affliction, the loop that won't close, and I love them for it.

The mainstream says correlation, not function. The minority says map. Nobody's shut the door. Marisol wasn't going to shut it for us. She was telling us we'd asked the wrong question, and being right about it, which she usually was, because she'd grown up where we were merely visiting.

At the far end, where the line dissolved into the down-grade and the morning had gone gold and the mist was burning off the rim of the pampa, the procession stopped. There was no monument. There was no marker. There was just the place the walking stopped, which I suppose made it the place that mattered. The old woman poured something from the thermos onto the ground — not water, I think, something darker — and everyone stood, and the song ended, and the silence came back, that pressure-silence, and pressed.

I had a question. I am the one with the questions. I'd been holding

it the whole walk, neat on the clipboard of my mind: *what is this line for?* The Why Files question. Jakobus's question. Not who, not how — what-for. I had the version where it's a water map and the version where it's a calendar (dead) and the version where it's a runway (deader) and the version where it's a procession path tied to fertility, which is the version that wins, and I wanted to ask Marisol which one was *true* so I could write it down.

I looked at her, and she was already looking at me, and she shook her head — barely, a centimetre — before I'd said a word.

"You felt it," she said. "Don't ask me what it's for. You just did it." She picked up the thermos. "That's what it's for. You did the thing it's for. Writing the answer down isn't the answer. The walking is the answer." A pause. "You won't fly home with that. You'll fly home with photographs. Photographs are the part you're allowed to take."

She started back up the line. Forty of us turned and followed our own broken crust home, leaving fresh marks beside the old ones, the path renewed by the feet that asked, and behind us the LENS stood a moment longer looking at the place the walking stopped — looking at it from the ground, at last, where there was nothing to photograph and everything to feel, and not reaching for the camera that wasn't there.

I didn't write the answer down. There wasn't one. There was just the crunch of crust, and the cold coming off the dirt, and the door standing open where Marisol had refused to close it, and the question hanging in the windless air like the mist that wasn't quite gone.

What is it for.

Walk it and find out. That was the only answer on offer. And we had. And it hadn't told us. And somehow that was the most honest thing the whole desert said all day.

Chapter 13 — Lines and Faults

The map room at Cahuachi was a mud-brick storeroom with a tin roof and one window the size of a postcard, and Marisol — the hydrology-reader, the one the crew had stopped trying to hurry years ago — had turned it into a cathedral of acetate.

She'd taped overlays to the window glass because that was the only surface that took backlight without warping. The Yamagata survey base map underneath, the one with the 303 new glyphs printed in fussy little hatchings. Over that, the fault traces she'd copied by hand from a geological sheet the consortium had left lying in their field-camp like a banknote on a café table. Over *that*, in grease pencil, the puquios — the spiral aqueducts, marked as small open circles, each one a place where the desert had been persuaded to give up water it had no business holding.

When the morning came through the postcard window, the three layers stacked into one image. And in that image a line ran south-southeast off the great trapezoid near Cantalloc, ran arrow-straight for the better part of a kilometre, and crossed a fault trace, and forty metres past the crossing there was a circle.

A puquio. Still wet. Still feeding a chacra of squash and a man named Eulogio who'd been suspicious of all of them until the Lens photographed his irrigation channel from a kite and gave him the print.

"That's eleven," Marisol said.

Nobody answered, because nobody was in the room. She said it

again anyway, to the acetate, the way you confirm a number to make it real. Eleven lines that touched a fault. Nine of those eleven that ran on, past the fault, to a puquio or to where a puquio had collapsed. She had a list. She had eleven entries on the list and she had checked each one with the Lens's verticals, not eyeballed off a tourist map, *checked*, scale bar and all, and the geometry held.

It held the way a thing holds when it's about to mean something or about to mean nothing, and she could not yet tell which.

Here is the official story, and it is a good one, and it is mostly right.

The Nazca lines are not a map of anything. They are removal. Somebody, between roughly 400 BC and AD 500, walked out onto the darkest, flattest, deadest plain on the planet and lifted the reddish iron-stained pebbles off the surface — ten centimetres, fifteen at the most — and stacked them at the edges, and the pale ground showed through, and *that* was the line. The contrast was the artefact. No quarry, no mortar, no engine. Stakes and cord. They found one of the stakes, a worn wooden anchor at a line terminus, and put it in a counter and it counted back to the right centuries, which is the most boring and most beautiful thing about the whole site: it is exactly as old as it should be, made exactly the way you'd guess, by people who are exactly gone.

And the *why* of it has been getting answered, lately, and answered well. The 2024 survey — IBM doing the looking, an AI trawling the imagery faster than Maria Reiche could have done it in nine lifetimes — split the figures cleanly. The little ones, the relief-type, average nine metres, sit a stone's throw off the old footpaths, and four out of five of them show *people*: a person, a pair of hands, a head. Roadside shrines. Stations of a procession you'd pass on foot, the way you'd pass the fourteen of anything on the way to anywhere holy. And the big ones, the line-type, the hundred-metre ones, those are mostly animals, mostly wild, and you cannot see them from the path at all. You walk them. You don't view them.

Two different things, doing two different jobs. The grand unified mystery dissolves, the way grand unified mysteries usually do, into a sensible plural. The lines are ritual. They are about water and fertility because *everything* out here is about water — twenty minutes of rain

a year, the whole pampa one long held breath — and you do not have to encode a thing on a map to make the thing be about water. You only have to live somewhere this dry.

Donald Proulx, who spent a working life on this, says it plainly enough: ritual, procession, the symbolism of water, not the *cartography* of it. The lines point at the sacred, not the aquifer.

That's the mainstream. It is well-built. Marisol respected it the way you respect a wall you keep walking into.

Because there were the eleven lines.

The Local came in without knocking, because it was her storeroom, her family's plain, her dead under the floor of the great mound outside. She'd been up since the dark, walking — she walked every dawn, the crew had worked that out, walked the lines the way other people pray — and she had the desert still on her boots, that pale dust that came up to mark them like the lines themselves were soft enough to take a footprint, which they were.

She looked at the window for a while. She had a way of reading an overlay that the consortium's people did not have and could not buy, because she'd grown up inside the thing the overlay was *of*.

"You've added the faults," she said.

"David Johnson's were too coarse. I redid them off the geology sheet your friends left out."

"Not my friends." Said mildly. The consortium were nobody's friends. They were a fact, like the fault, like the wind that didn't blow.

Marisol pointed. "Eleven. Eleven lines cross a fault. Nine carry on to a puquio. The faults channel groundwater — that's not me, that's the hydrology, the fault is a crack and the water moves along the crack and the puquio is dug exactly where the crack delivers it. The Nazca knew where the water was. They had to. You don't engineer a corkscrew aqueduct down twenty metres on a *guess*." Her voice was getting quick, which was the tell, the crew knew the tell, it meant the pattern had her by the back of the neck. "So if they knew where the underground water ran, and they were drawing kilometre-long lines, and *some* of those lines run from a fault to the water—"

“Some,” the Local said.

“Eleven.”

“Out of how many lines on the pampa?”

Marisol stopped.

The fish — there is always a fish in these books, the voice that has read ahead and won’t shut up — the fish surfaced here, in the back of her own skull, in a tone she’d have decked anyone else for: *out of hundreds, mate. Out of eight hundred. Draw enough kilometre-long darts across a plain full of cracks and circles and watch how many hit something wet by accident. You know this. You taught a seminar on this. The word is “spurious correlation” and you have it printed on a tote bag.*

“Out of hundreds,” she admitted.

“Out of hundreds.” The Local crossed to the window and put a fingernail on the Cantalloc line, the good one, the eleventh, the one that ran clean from trapezoid to fault to wet circle. “This one’s real. I don’t mean the water’s real, I mean — this line, I know this line. I’ve walked it. My grandmother walked it. You walk it down off the trapezoid and the ground tilts, just slightly, you feel it in your knees before you see it, and at the bottom there’s Eulogio’s puquio and you can hear it. You can hear water in the driest place on earth. That’ll make a believer of anybody.”

“So it is a—”

“It’s a line that goes downhill to water,” the Local said. “In a desert. Where else would you walk?”

That was the thing the consortium would never get, with all their drones, and the thing Marisol kept catching the edge of and losing.

The fault *makes* the water. The water *makes* the green. The green is the only reason to *be* there. So of course a path to water and a path to the sacred and a path to the dead might be the same path — not because the line is a *map* of the fault, drawn to record it, but because the line and the fault and the puquio all answer to the same lower fact, which is gravity and rock and thirst. The line doesn’t point

at the water. The line and the water both point at the bottom of the hill.

Correlation. Not function.

It was airtight. She hated how airtight it was. The Local had said it in nine words while doing up a bootlace and it had taken three geologists and a PNAS footnote to say it less well.

And yet.

“Show me the two,” Marisol said. “The nine that go on to water — show me they’re just downhill. If they’re all just running downhill to the nearest wet circle, fine, I’ll burn the overlay, I’ll buy you the squash beer. But two of them—” she had the list, she put a thumbnail on two entries “—two of them cross the fault and then turn. They don’t take the short way down. They jog. The line jogs to stay *on* the fault trace, on the crack, and follows it to a puquio that isn’t even the closest one.”

The Local looked at the two entries for a long time.

The tin roof ticked as the sun got onto it.

“Maybe the survey’s wrong,” the Local said. “AI joins lines that aren’t joined. It guesses across erosion. You’d want to walk those two before you’d believe a turn in them.”

“I want to walk those two.”

“Then we’ll walk those two.” A pause, and the dust shifted on her boots. “And it’ll still be two. Out of hundreds. And you’ll have walked a line that bends along a crack to water and you still won’t be able to tell me whether the dead man who made it knew the crack was there, or felt the ground tilt, or saw a green smudge in the morning that nobody else could see, or just liked the way the line wanted to go. You won’t be able to put which-of-those on your overlay. There’s no layer for it.”

Down the valley, the consortium’s drones were up. You could hear them if the world went quiet enough, a thin saw-sound, very high, very patient. They were not looking for faults. They were looking for *new figures*, glyphs the AI could find and they could be first to publish and

first to fence — a catalogue number is a kind of claim, and a claim is a kind of ownership, even out here where you cannot own the desert any more than you can own the wind that isn't blowing. They wanted the count to go up. Every glyph the machine found was theirs to have found.

They would never, Marisol thought, tape acetate to a window. They had no window. They had a screen, and the screen was always right, and a thing that is always right cannot be wrong in the interesting way, the way the eleven were wrong, the way the two might not be.

The Lens came in then — the crew lead, the famous one, eyes still narrowed from the light off the plain, the camera not in hand for once and his hands looking strange without it. He'd been up flying the kit at dawn. He looked at the window of overlays, the stacked desert, the eleven, the two.

"From up there," he said slowly, "the water lines don't look any different. I keep wanting them to glow. They don't. A line that goes to a puquio looks exactly like a line that goes nowhere. From the air you can't tell the wet ones." A breath. "You'd have to walk them to know."

The Local smiled at that — not unkindly, the smile of someone watching a man arrive, late and out of breath, at a place she'd lived her whole life.

"Yes," she said. "You'd have to walk them."

And the Lens, who could see every line on the pampa from a thousand feet and could not feel a single one of them tilt under his knees, went quiet in the way the crew had stopped trying to fix, because it wasn't broken, it was just the shape of him, the seeing-and-not-walking, and you don't fix the shape of a person, you let them photograph it.

So here is where it stands, and the honest answer is that it stands open.

The mainstream is right, almost certainly. The lines are ritual and procession and water-as-meaning, not water-as-map, and eleven correlations out of hundreds of lines is what you'd get from chance and a plain full of cracks, and the strong version — *the Nazca lines are an aquifer chart* — is a minority view that's never closed its own case

and probably can't.

But the cracks do carry water. The puquios do sit on the cracks. The Nazca did know, with a precision we still can't match, exactly where in twenty dry metres of rock to dig to hit a moving thread of it. That knowledge existed in those heads. It had to. And eleven of their lines do touch it, and two of them — if the survey's right, if the AI didn't dream the bend — two of them *turn* to stay with it, jog off the short way down to keep a crack underfoot, and run that crack to a circle of water that is not the closest circle of water.

Two lines.

That don't take the easy way to the wet.

Marisol stood in the map room with the desert stacked in light on the window and did not close the case, because the case would not close, because the thing she could check came up *real* and the thing she wanted it to mean came up *unprovable*, and those are not the same border and she'd spent her whole strange watchful life learning to keep them apart.

The Local was already at the door, dust on her boots, light behind her.

"Tomorrow," she said. "Before the mist burns off. We'll walk the two."

She didn't say what they'd find. She knew, the way she knew the floor of the great mound and the names of her dead, that what they'd find was a line that bent toward water in a desert — and that you still could not tell, from the bend, whether the maker had read the fault or felt the tilt or simply liked where the line wanted to go.

There's no layer for it.

That's not a failure of the overlay.

That's the door it leaves open.

Chapter 14 — Patent Pending

The consortium's tent was the colour of a hospital — that hard medical white that the desert hated, that the desert was already trying to bury under a fine red breath of dust. The LENS stood at the rope line with the camera asleep against her chest and watched a young woman in a windbreaker carry a laptop across the compound as if it were a newborn.

"They air-condition it," said Tomás, the hydrology-reader, beside her. He said it the way other men say a dirty word. "In the driest place on earth. They cool a tent."

"They cool the servers," the LENS said. "Not themselves."

"Same thing to them."

Inside, through the open flap, racks blinked. A bank of drones charged on a folding table in neat rows, props folded back like the wings of resting insects. A man with a sunburn and a clipboard moved between them, checking each one, and the LENS found she liked him a little for that — the care of it. You did not earn that kind of tenderness toward a machine without loving the work. The consortium was not a cabal. The consortium was forty people who had flown a long way to do something difficult and were doing it very well.

That was the trouble.

Here is the thing they were doing well, and it is worth saying straight,

because it is genuinely good.

In 2024 a team out of Yamagata University, working with IBM and the German Aerospace Center, ran AI across the pampa and pulled three hundred and three new figurative glyphs out of the noise — figures that decades of human eyes, walking and flying and squinting at Maria Reiche’s hand-drawn maps, had missed. Three hundred and three. They sorted them, too. The little ones — the “relief-type,” averaging about nine metres, sitting a stone’s throw from the old footpaths — turned out to be overwhelmingly human: people, heads, the doings of people, four out of five. The big ones — the “line-type,” ninety metres of figure you can only read from the sky — ran to wild animals, nearly two in three.

Roadside shrines for the walker. Communal figures for — for whatever reads them.

That is not a mystery solved by a monk in a cave. That is a mystery solved by a GPU and a paper in *PNAS*, and the people who did it deserve the line in the textbook. The consortium in the white tent was the next wave of exactly that. More compute, more passes, finer resolution. They would find more. Of course they would find more.

And the moment they find it, the fish murmured from somewhere near the cooler, it stops belonging to the desert and starts belonging to a folder.

“They filed,” the Local said.

She had come up on the LENS’s blind side, the way she always did, soundless on a ground that wanted to crunch under everyone else. Her name was Yvonne Quispe-Roca; she had been born in Cahuachi’s shadow and trained in three field seasons of bad knees and good notebooks, and she could read a square metre of this pampa the way the LENS read a contact sheet. She did not look angry. She looked like a doctor reading a chart she’d seen before.

“Filed what,” said the LENS.

“Provisional patents. Intellectual property.” Yvonne said the English words carefully, holding them out like something found in a dead man’s pocket. “On the detection method. On the data set. On —”

she tilted her head toward the tent — “the new figures. The ones the model finds. They want the rights to the catalogue.”

Tomás laughed, once, a bark with no joy in it. “You can’t patent a four-thousand-year-old monkey.”

“You can’t,” Yvonne agreed. “You can patent the way you found it. The pipeline. The ‘novel methodology for geoglyph detection.’ And then everyone who wants to find one — every Peruvian student, every museum here, every kid from Nazca who grows up wanting to map the thing his grandmother walked — has to pay the people in the cooled tent for the privilege of looking at his own ground.”

The wind, which there mostly was not, picked up exactly enough to lift the corner of the white flap and let it fall.

The LENS went into the tent because the LENS went into rooms. That was the job, the old job, the one before this one — you walked into the place that was on fire and you made the picture, and the picture was the only thing that ever came back out clean. She’d carried that habit across two careers and a diagnosis and a year she did not discuss, and it had worn a groove in her so deep that her feet found the flap before her sense did.

The sunburned man looked up from his drone. “You’re the photographer.” Not unkind. “We’ve seen your work. The aerials. Honestly — beautiful stuff.”

“Thank you.”

“You should come up with us sometime. The orthomosaics we’re pulling — centimetre resolution. You can see the stake holes.” He said it the way you’d offer a child a sweet, and the awful thing was that the LENS wanted it. Centimetre resolution. The stake holes. The actual marks of the actual hands.

“Make me a print,” she said, “and I’ll consider it.” She was looking past him, at the screen.

On the screen was the pampa from above — her pampa, the one she’d flown that dawn, the gold gone to grey in the data, the contrast cranked. And laid over it, in clean magenta vector lines, were the figures. Not photographed. *Detected*. Edges the algorithm was

confident about rendered solid; edges it doubted rendered dashed. A whole desert reduced to confidence intervals. It was, she had to admit, gorgeous, in the way an autopsy is thorough.

In the corner of the screen, small, a banner: **PROPRIETARY — DO NOT DISTRIBUTE.**

Three words. The driest sentence in the driest place on earth.

They armoured the data, the fish observed, like the mist armours the lines. Difference is, the mist lets you walk on it.

Outside, the crew had set up their own experiment again, because they were nothing if not stubborn, and because the producer wanted the bit. It was the potato bit. They were going to make a Nazca line.

Easy, the books say. Stakes and cord. The radiocarbon date came off a wooden anchor stake at the end of a real line — so we know the method, no aliens required, no lost technology. You drive a stake, you run a cord, you walk it straight, and your crew pulls the dark patinated stones off the top to show the pale ground a hand's-depth below. Ten, fifteen centimetres. The soil is so soft a boot leaves a print. A child could mar it. That is the official story and it is true and it is, when you say it out loud, embarrassingly simple.

So they did it. Again. The LENS came back out to find them forty metres along their second attempt of the trip, sweating, arguing about whether the cord had drifted.

"It drifted," said Tomás.

"It did not drift, you drifted, you walked off the cord —"

"I walked *on* the cord, that's the point of the —"

The line was lumpy. There was no kind way to put it. They'd cleared the stones and the pale ground showed through and from where the LENS stood at ground level it looked, more or less, like a line. A bit of a line. A line drawn by someone holding the pencil too hard. The edges wandered. One man had pulled the dark stones in a wider band than the next, so the thing breathed in and out along its length like a snake that had eaten unevenly.

“Send it up,” said Tomás, not looking at her, because he already knew.

She sent the drone up. Not the consortium’s drone — theirs, the battered one, the one with the tape on the leg. She brought it to forty metres and turned the gimbal down and the screen showed them their handiwork from the only angle that had ever mattered for this kind of figure.

It was a worm. A drunk worm. Beside it, two hundred metres off, ran a real one — a true Nazca line, arrow-straight, kilometres long, the edges so clean they looked machined, holding their bearing across the curve of the ground itself, made — the evidence says — in a single working span by people who had no platform to stand on, no view from above, no way at all to check the very quality that makes the line astonishing from the air.

The two lines sat in the same frame. The crew’s, and the dead’s.

Nobody said anything for a moment. The producer, quietly, was very happy. This was the bit.

Yvonne had watched the whole thing with her arms folded, and now she crouched at the head of the crew’s poor line and put two fingers down — not on it, beside it, in the undisturbed crust.

“You walked it nine times,” she said. “I counted.” She wasn’t mocking. She was correcting a measurement. “To get it that straight, you walked it nine times, and it’s still a worm, and you have shoes and string and a drone to check yourselves with. They walked it once.” She looked up. “Maybe. We think maybe once. And the line is true.”

“How,” said the LENS. It was not a rhetorical how. She had spent her life learning how to make a straight thing on the ground look like a true thing from the air, and these people had done the reverse, blind, and beaten her.

“Sightlines. Stakes leapfrogged forward, each one checked back against the last two. Patience. Hands that did this their whole lives.” Yvonne stood, and brushed her fingers off, and the LENS saw she had not actually let a grain of the disturbed soil touch her skin. “It’s not magic. The method isn’t a secret. The *discipline* is the thing you can’t patent.” She glanced once at the white tent. “Though they’ll

try.”

You can buy the pipeline, the fish said. Good luck buying the hands.

The LENS filled the frame: the worm, the true line, the woman walking back along the seam between them with the dust closing over her tracks.

They got the warning that evening, and the LENS understood, then, that the chase had stopped being about a paper.

It came as a printout, slid under the flap of the crew’s tent by someone who did not stay. Polite. *Re: Coordination of Survey Activities, Sector 4.* The language of a man with a clipboard. The consortium, it said, in the interest of *data integrity*, requested that *third-party aerial operators* — that was the LENS, that was the battered drone with the tape on its leg — limit flights over the registered survey sectors *to avoid contaminating the model’s confidence baseline.*

Translated: stop flying. Your pictures are noise in our patent.

“They can’t do that,” Tomás said.

“They can’t *enforce* it,” Yvonne said. “But the *Ministerio* can. And the Ministry is one underfunded office and a queue, and the consortium has lawyers who fly business class, and the lawyers will write to the office, and the office will get tired.” She set the paper down on the camp table and smoothed it flat, gently, as if it too were a thing that might be hurt. “This is how it goes. Not soldiers. Letters. You lose the place one permission at a time.”

She did not raise her voice. She had grown up here; she had watched the tour buses cut a road across the Hummingbird’s tail before there were signs; she had watched a German hydrologist’s pickup leave tyre scars near a puquio that would outlast everyone in this tent. She knew exactly how soft the ground was. Ten centimetres. A boot.

“What do you want us to do,” the LENS asked.

Yvonne looked at her for a long moment, and it was the first time the LENS felt fully measured — not the famous eye, not the war résumé,

just a person standing on someone else's sacred ground asking to be told what she was for.

"I want you to fly tomorrow," Yvonne said. "Early. Before their drones are up — they don't fly until the mist burns off, the humidity fouls the optics. But the mist is when the lines are best. The crust is hard, the light is low, the figures throw shadow." A small thing happened at the corner of her mouth that was not quite a smile. "Make a picture they can't fold into a confidence interval. Make one that's just *true*, and put my people's names on it, and put it where everyone can see it for free."

"That's not data," Tomás said softly. "That's a flag."

"Yes," said Yvonne. "It is exactly a flag."

That night the LENS could not sleep, which was usual, and so she walked out to the edge of the camp where the lines began and stood at the lip of the worm her own crew had made. Even in starlight it was lumpy. Even in starlight, two hundred metres off, the real line held its bearing into the dark like something with a destination.

The consortium's tent glowed white behind her, cooled, certain, racing to know the desert well enough to own the knowing. They were not wrong to want it. The figures were real; the method was real; the find was magnificent and somebody was going to find more and there was no putting any of it back in the ground.

But the ground was ten centimetres deep. That was the part no patent reached. The whole astonishment of the place rested on a crust thinner than a paperback, held in place by twenty minutes of rain a year and a morning fog, and it had survived two thousand years of nothing happening to it. The fastest way to kill it was to make it valuable.

They want the map, the fish said, very quietly now, in the cold. She just wants the territory.

Somewhere out under the same stars, a line ran toward a fault, ran toward a puquio still corkscrewing water up out of the dust, and nobody had ever closed the question of whether that was a message or an accident. Tomorrow, in the mist, the LENS would try to photograph

the difference. She did not think she could. She thought it might not exist.

She went back in and laid out the camera and charged the batteries and set the alarm for an hour she hated.

Behind her, the white tent hummed, patient as a glacier, filing its papers in the cool.

The race had a clock on it now. And the clock was a letter.

Chapter 15 — The Keeper's Eye

Mara got to the overlook before the light did.

She wasn't crew lead — that was the LENS, somewhere below and to the east with the camera kit, looking for the angle that let the pampa lie flat to the sensor. Mara was the one who carried things. Cables, the spare batteries, the cooler with the water nobody remembered to drink until they were already dizzy. She was the one who kept the schedule and lost the schedule and found it again folded in her own back pocket. If you asked the consortium who she was, they'd have called her support, and they'd have meant it kindly, and they'd have looked past her to whoever had the title.

So nobody was watching when she watched.

The overlook was a low spur of rock above the Palpa edge of the pampa, the place the guides bring you when the proper mirador is closed or crowded. From here the plain ran out grey-gold and enormous, and the lines lay across it the way veins lie under skin — you didn't see them so much as feel that the surface was organized, that something underneath had a plan. Then the sun came a finger's width over the eastern range and the whole desert tipped into relief, and the lines stood up out of nothing, dark stone shoulders to either side of pale floors, kilometres of them, arrow-true.

It is, by the way, the easiest trick in the world to make a Nazca line. The textbook practically yawns telling you. The pampa is paved, near enough, with reddish pebbles the size of knuckles, gone dark over the centuries with iron-oxide patina. Lift them off — they're only ten, fifteen centimetres deep — and the ground beneath is pale. Set the

dark ones in a windrow on either side. Walk. There's your line, contrast against contrast, no mortar, no machine, no mystery. Stakes and cord. They've radiocarbon-dated a wooden anchor stake left at the end of one. The technology is: string.

The technology is string, the fish agreed from the cooler, where it was riding in the meltwater like a man in a bad bath. I keep waiting for the part that needs a UFO and it keeps being string.

Mara had tried the string. They all had, three days ago, on a worthless stretch of consortium-cleared ground where you were allowed to scuff. Stakes, mason's line, a level borrowed off a farmer. They'd laid out twenty metres of straightedge with four people and a bubble vial and modern eyes, and from the ground it had looked fine, looked sharp, looked like they'd cracked it.

Then the LENS went up — the little drone first, then later the real flight — and photographed their twenty metres next to a thousand-year-old line, and the crew's line came out of the camera looking like a worm with opinions. Wobble in it. A drift at the third stake where someone had sneezed. The edges furred where they'd kicked stones back over the boundary without meaning to. Beside it, the ancient line ran straight as a laid rule for as far as the lens could hold, with the casual ease of something that had not been hard for the people who made it and was very hard for the people who had cameras and levels and degrees.

Potato. There was no other word and the crew had stopped looking for one.

So Mara stood on the overlook and didn't try to make a line. She just watched the ones that were already there, and waited for the others, because the others were coming. You could hear the consortium before you saw them — a high insect whine off to the north where their field camp sat, four drones lifting in formation to start the day's grid. Clean-handed people, those. She'd met them at the permit office. Polite, funded, genuinely thrilled by the work. They had the 2024 survey practically memorized, the big AI study, the three hundred and three new glyphs the model had pulled out of imagery a human eye would've slid right over. They could tell you the relief-type figures clustered near the old footpaths, small ones, nine metres or so, mostly people and llamas, the kind of thing you'd walk past and

salute. They could tell you the line-type figures were the giants, ninety metres, the wild animals, the ones you can only read from the sky.

They wanted to find more. They wanted to be the ones whose model found them. There were words in their grant about a database, words about licensing, words about derived geospatial product, and none of it was wicked and all of it ended with a desert someone owned.

The whine got closer. Mara felt the day's race start in her chest the way it did every morning.

"They start too early," a voice said behind her, unhurried. "The crust isn't set."

Tomás had come up the spur without a sound, which Mara was beginning to understand he always did. The local lead. Cahuachi-born — he said it the way other people said their surname, as a fact about the bone. Field-trained, twenty years on this plain, and he had a way of standing at an overlook that was different from how the rest of them stood. The crew arrived at a view. Tomás arrived at a *place*. You could see him counting it.

"The crust," Mara said.

"Every night the mist comes." He nodded out at the plain, where, an hour ago, there'd been nothing but cold air and now there was gold. "Twenty minutes of rain a year on this pampa — that's the whole of it, twenty minutes, and most years even that's a rumour. But the mist comes off the cold current every dawn and lies on the ground and dries into a skin. Gypsum and clay. It armours the lines. It's why your worm" — and he almost smiled, the first time she'd seen it — "is going to wash to nothing in a season, and these are still here after fifteen hundred years."

"And their drones?"

"Rotor wash." He said it flat. "Forty of them in a season, every dawn, before the crust hardens. Nobody's measured what that does yet. That's the trouble with new instruments. The damage arrives before the paper does."

Below them the consortium drones found their lanes and began to mow the air in straight overlapping strips, exactly the way the ancient lines were straight, which Mara found she did not like at all.

Two kinds of people who make perfectly straight lines across this desert, the fish observed, and only one of them stops to ask permission.

The LENS radioed up — flat, clipped, the way they got when the light was working. They'd gotten the shadow shot, the one they'd come for, a giant line-figure with the low sun raking it so the windrows threw a band of dark across the pale, the whole thing readable only because the camera was above it. The LENS could not, would not, walk that figure. They'd tried once, the first day, and come back grey and quiet, said the ground felt wrong under boots, said you couldn't see anything down there, said it was just stones. The pampa gave the LENS nothing at eye level. It gave everything at altitude. A gift with a wall in it.

"Your photographer reads the sky," Tomás said, watching the drone-light of his own people work the grid. "Same as them. Same as the giant figures up here." He gestured at the line-type animals on the plain, the monkey, the spider, the ones you needed wings to know were there. "Made for an eye that flies. The relief figures down by the path, the little ones — those are made for an eye that walks. The study's right about that. Two answers, not one."

"That's the part that gets me," Mara said carefully, because she wasn't crew lead and this wasn't her line of country and she could feel herself stepping where she might not be allowed. "If you wanted the walkers to see something, you made it small and put it by the path. If you wanted — who? — to see the big ones, you made them football fields wide and you made them so you'd never see them from the ground in your life. Who were the big ones *for*?"

Tomás didn't answer. He looked at her the way you look at a child who has asked the good question by accident — with respect, and no intention whatsoever of giving them the toy.

Down on the plain, the hydrology-reader — Pia, ND, the one who'd been three nights without proper sleep — came into view far below, a small bright dot moving along the edge of a long line with her tablet held out like a divining tool. She'd been at it since they arrived. The lines mostly mean ritual, everyone agreed, processions, water and fertility braided together, walked not read; the mainstream had said so for decades and the new AI hadn't unsaid it. But Pia had found

the other thing, the smaller, harder thing — the handful of lines that ran toward faults, and the faults that channelled groundwater down to the puquios, those corkscrew aqueducts the Nazca dug into the dust that still, after all this time, pull water out of a place with no water. A minority view. Correlation, the textbook said firmly, not function. A man named Johnson had pushed the strong version and the field had mostly pushed back, gently, the way the field does. Coincidence is cheap in a desert full of lines; point one in enough directions and some of them will hit a fault.

Pia had been chasing one line for three days that did not feel cheap to her, and Mara had watched her not sleep over it.

“She thinks she’s found one,” Mara said.

“She has found one,” Tomás said.

Mara turned.

“That line.” He didn’t point; he just knew which one. “Runs to the puquio at the foot of the spur. There’s water under it. There’s a fault under it. Both true.” He let it sit. “And there’s a procession recorded by it, a path my grandmother’s grandmother walked, asking. Both true.” He glanced at her, mild. “You want me to tell you which one it’s *for*. The water or the asking.”

“Yes,” Mara said, because there was no point lying to him.

“The consortium wants the same thing,” Tomás said. “They want it as a layer in the model. *Hydrological-symbolic correlate, confidence value*. They’d give it a number.” He watched his colleague’s drones turn at the grid’s end. “Your photographer wants it from the air, one clean image that holds the answer flat. Your friend down there wants the fault and the figure to line up so the loop closes and she can sleep.” He nodded slowly. “Three good wantings. None of them mine.”

The drones came around again. The whine climbed. Mara was aware, suddenly and completely, that she held nothing here — no title, no instrument, no theory, no right — and that this was the correct amount for her to hold.

“What’s yours?” she asked.

Tomás was quiet for long enough that the sun cleared the range entirely and the lines lost their shadow-relief and went back to being faint, the way they are at noon, the way they are to anyone who isn't here at dawn or above it in a plane. The pampa kept its surfaces to itself once the light went vertical. That, too, felt like an answer she wasn't going to get.

"My grandmother walked that line," he said finally. "Not for the water. The water was already coming up the puquio — they'd built that, it worked, it didn't need a prayer. She walked it because you walk it. Because the dead are remembered along it and the rain is asked for along it and the desert is held together by people moving across it in the right way at the right time, and if you stop walking it, you find out what the desert does to a place nobody walks." He said it without heat, a man reporting weather. "So when your friend asks me, is it a water map — I'll tell her the fault is real and the correlation is real and I won't tell her it's only that, because it isn't, and I won't tell her it's a map, because that's a word for a thing you read instead of a thing you do." He looked at Mara. "She wants me to close the loop. I'm not going to close it. The loop's not mine to close. It was left open on purpose."

The fish said nothing. Even the fish knew when to keep its mouth out of the water.

Below, Pia stopped walking. She stood very still at the line's end, near the puquio, tablet down at her side now, just looking at the spiral of stone descending into the earth with cold water at the bottom of it, the way the people who built it must have stood, the day it first ran. She didn't call up. She didn't wave the tablet. She just stood in it.

The LENS's voice came over the radio, low: *Tell me what I'm looking at*. The plane, somewhere, the eye that flew, asking the ground for once instead of capturing it.

Mara keyed the radio and didn't answer, because the answer wasn't hers. She held it out toward Tomás, the handset, the open channel, the whole crew's curiosity routed through her palm and offered up.

He looked at it. He looked at the plain his people had walked since before the word Peru existed, and the drones that wanted it as data, and the camera that wanted it as image, and the woman by the puquio who wanted it to make sense.

“Bring them up here at dawn tomorrow,” Tomás said. “All of them. We’ll walk one.” He took the handset, finally, and held it without speaking into it, weighing what he’d say to the eye in the sky. “And I’ll tell you what it’s for. As much of it as I choose.”

He didn’t key the mic. The channel stayed open and empty, the LENS waiting in the air, and the question hanging over the whole gold plain, unclosed, exactly the size it had been made.

Chapter 16 — Jakobus

Reads the Road

The sun was a coin going into a slot, and the line lit up like someone had run a wire under the desert and switched it on.

Mara had her back to it, which is how you watch a sunset on the pampa if you have any sense — you watch the ground, not the sky, because the ground is where the day does its last bit of theatre. She was on the support side of things this trip, which meant batteries, water, the satellite uplink that sulked, and the unofficial job of standing where she could see everyone at once. Right now everyone was a small smear of figures three hundred metres off, near the terminus where one of the long lines simply stopped, the way a sentence stops when the speaker decides you already know the rest.

Jakobus was crouched at the edge of it.

Not on it. He never stepped on the things. He had a way of arranging himself at the very lip of a glyph, boots in the dark rubble, hands loose, like a man reading the spine of a book without opening it. The light came in low and orange and laid his shadow across the pale ground in a long stripe that almost — almost — wanted to be a line itself.

The Local stood a little behind him, arms folded, not in judgement. Just present. She had been born under Cahuachi's brooding mound and had spent more dawns out here than the consortium had spent dollars, which was saying something, because over the rise their drones were going up into the dying light like a small flock of expensive insects, blinking, scanning, filing.

“Tell me again what the new survey says,” Jakobus said. He didn’t look up.

Tomas, who handled the cameras when the LENS wasn’t running them and otherwise translated and carried things, cleared his throat and gave it to him straight, because the official story deserves straight.

“The 2024 study. Yamagata, IBM, the German aerospace lot. They put an AI on the imagery and it found three hundred and three new figurative glyphs in six months — work that would’ve taken decades by eye.” He counted it off the way you’d recite a hymn you actually believed. “Two kinds. Relief-type — small ones, average nine metres, sitting about forty-three metres off the old footpaths. Four out of five of those show human things. Heads, people, decorated bodies. And line-type — the big ones, ninety metres, mostly wild animals.”

“And the conclusion.”

“That it isn’t one mystery.” Tomas spread his hands. “The little ones are roadside. Ritual stations. You walk the path, you stop, you see a thing made small for the foot traveller. The big ones are communal — made by a crowd, for a crowd, an occasion. Not aliens. Not a runway. Not a star map — Hawkins tested the alignments back in seventy-three and Aveni went over it in eighty-two, and only about a fifth line up with anything in the sky, which is what you’d get by chance. The calendar idea’s dead. It’s been dead a long time. People just keep it warm because they like the look of it.”

Mara watched the Local while he said it. She didn’t nod, didn’t shake her head. She let the boy finish. That, Mara had noticed, was the difference between the two camps out here. The consortium answered before you’d finished asking. The woman from Cahuachi waited until your question had run all the way out of rope.

“Good,” said Jakobus. “So we know who. Paracas, then Nazca. Four hundred BC to five hundred AD, give or take. And we know how — they lifted the dark stones.” He reached down and, with two fingers, turned over a single pebble at the line’s verge. Where it had sat, the ground was the same reddish-brown as everything else. He set it back. “Iron-oxide skin on top, ten, fifteen centimetres deep. Pull the dark off, the pale shows through. Stake and cord. There’s a wooden anchor stake at one of the termini that got carbon-dated, so even the *string* is on the record.” He almost smiled. “No lasers. No lost technology. A

people who could make a perfectly straight line a kilometre long with rope and patience and a very, very still afternoon.”

“We tried it,” Mara said, before she could stop herself.

Jakobus looked over his shoulder at her, and the look had a warmth in it, the warmth of a man who has watched a lot of clever people humble themselves on a job and has come to enjoy the moment.

“You did,” he said. “Show him.”

She didn’t have to. The thing was forty metres behind them, and in the slant light it advertised itself: their line. The crew’s line. Two days ago they’d done the honest experiment — stakes, cord, the LENS calling angles, the hydrology-reader sighting along the string with one eye shut, the whole team taking turns lifting the dark stones and stacking them clear, exactly as the books said it was done. They’d given it everything. And from the air, the LENS had brought back an image that made the hydrology-reader laugh out loud and then go quiet: a wobble. A drunken seam in the desert. A line that couldn’t hold its nerve, that bellied left and corrected right and apologised for itself the whole length of its run.

A potato.

And not ten metres from it, an ancient line ran true for as far as the eye gave out, straight as a struck chord, no apology in it anywhere.

“You see,” Jakobus said, “that’s the part that gets you. Not the who. Not the how — we *know* the how. It’s that they did the how *better than us*, with less, the first time, in the dark.” He let that sit. “They worked at night, some of them, or in the cold before dawn, while the mist was hardening the crust. Which is the only reason any of this is still here for the consortium to put a patent number on. Twenty minutes of rain a year. No wind to speak of. One of the deadest, stillest pieces of ground on the planet, and every morning the fog comes in off the cold ocean and lays down a skin that armours the marks. Make a line, and the desert *keeps* it. Step on it with a boot —” he nodded at the soft pale subsoil — “and the desert keeps that too. Forever. Which is why she’d take your hand off at the wrist if you tried.”

The Local made a small sound that might have been a laugh.

Quick reminder from the back of the van, says the fish,

who has been riding in a cooler of meltwater and frank opinions since Lima, *that the “how” being settled is exactly the bit everybody skips past to get to the runways. They had string. You have string. They got a cathedral. You got a potato. Sit with that for a second before you go reaching for spaceships.*

“So that’s the who and the how put to bed,” Jakobus said, and now he stood, knees cracking, and turned to face the long line where it ran off into the orange. “Which leaves me my question. The only one I ever bring to a made thing. Not who made you. Not how. *What are you for.*”

Tomas opened his mouth. Jakobus held up a hand, gently, the way you’d quiet a dog you liked.

“Don’t tell me what the book says it’s for. I heard the book. Ritual, procession, water, fertility — Proulx, the whole mainstream weight of it, and I believe every word, that’s not the trouble.” He started to walk the verge, slow, parallel to the line, never on it, and the crew drifted after him at a distance, because you did, you couldn’t help it. “A made thing has a *job*. A door is for going through. A bowl is for holding. You can argue all night about who threw the bowl and you’ve still got a bowl in your hands that fills with soup. So.” He stopped at a place where the long line crossed something fainter — an older mark, a different bearing, the two of them meeting at an angle and going their separate ways like strangers in a station. “What does *this* one do.”

The hydrology-reader had come up alongside without anyone noticing, the way she did, already half-elsewhere. She crouched where the lines crossed and put her palm flat on the rubble.

“This one runs to a puquio,” she said quietly. “I traced it. It points — give or take — at a spring head, and the spring head sits on a fault, and the fault’s the reason there’s water there at all. Cold water coming up through dust.” She didn’t look up. “There are a few like this. Not most. A minority. But they’re *real*. The correlation’s in the literature. Johnson saw it years ago, the lines tracking the faults that feed the corkscrew wells —”

“And the mainstream says correlation,” Tomas put in, careful, loyal to the record. “Proulx, everyone — they say of course the lines and

the water sit together, the whole *culture* sits together with the water, you'd expect overlap. It's not a map. The strong version, lines-equals-water-map, that's a minority read. Contested. It hasn't been —"

"It hasn't been *closed*," the hydrology-reader said. And there it was, naked in the last of the light: not a claim, a gap. "Nobody's shut it. They've shown it isn't *necessary*. They haven't shown it isn't *true*."

Jakobus looked at her for a long moment with something like fondness.

"You see," he said, to nobody, to the line, "that's the kind of thing I mean. A made thing with a job." He crouched again, level with her, and traced the air above the line toward the dark, toward the unseen spring. "If this stripe takes your feet to water in a place that gives you twenty minutes of rain a year — then *that's a job*, whatever else it also does. You walk it singing for rain and it walks you to where the rain already went underground. Both at once. A prayer that happens to be true."

He's doing the thing, the fish murmurs, almost respectful now. Watch the verb. He didn't say it IS a water map. He said it has a job and the job happens to land you at water. That's not the same sentence. The man's been doing this longer than you've been alive. He leaves the door at exactly the angle he found it.

"And the big ones?" Tomas said. "The line-type. Ninety metres. The animals you can't see from the ground at all."

"Ah." Jakobus stood once more and put his hands in his pockets and looked out at the plain, where one of the great figures lay somewhere in the failing light, a creature the size of a football pitch that no man walking past it would ever once see whole. "That's the other one, isn't it. That's the one that doesn't go away no matter how good the survey is. You make a thing too big to see with the eye that's standing on it. You spend a season of labour, a crowd of people, on a shape that only opens for a viewpoint nobody in the culture could ever climb to." He let the wind that wasn't there fail to move anything. "The relief glyphs are for the foot. Nine metres, forty metres off the path, made small and human so the traveller stops and looks. Fine. Settled. That one's *for* the walker, I'll sign it. But the line-figures —"

He didn't finish. He looked at the Local.

She had been quiet the whole time, and now everyone turned, the way a room turns, and Mara felt the old shape of it — the outsiders with their theories laid out on the table like instruments, and the woman who'd been born under the mound waiting to be asked.

Jakobus didn't ask. That was the thing about him. He gave her the floor by stepping off it.

"You've heard me read a hundred made things," he said to her, and it was almost an apology. "I can tell you what a thing is *for* from the marks on it nine times out of ten. Bowls. Roads. Walls. Locks." He nodded at the long line. "But I can read the road. I can't walk it the way you walk it. I never could. That's the part of the job that was never mine to take."

The Local unfolded her arms.

For a moment she looked at the crew — at the hydrology-reader still crouched with her palm on the stones, at Tomas guarding the record, at Mara standing where she could see everyone, at the wobbling potato of a line behind them all that the desert would now keep forever as a monument to how hard the easy answer is. Above the rise the consortium's drones came down out of the dark one by one, full of fresh data, each new glyph already half a patent.

The Local looked at all of it. And then she looked at the line running off toward the water and the dark.

She didn't sit down to teach. She didn't lay anything on the table.

She stepped onto the line — the only one of them who would, the only one of them who *could*, because it was hers — and she began to walk it. Eastward. Away. Into the last of the gold, her shadow stretching back toward them along the pale ground until it was longer than she was, longer than the line seemed, a dark stripe laid over a dark stripe.

She didn't say what it was for.

She walked like it was a thing you do, not a thing you explain — heel and toe along a kilometre of made ground, into a place where the desert hides its water under a fault and the figures lie too big for any living eye that ever stood here. The hydrology-reader watched her go and didn't follow. None of them followed. You don't.

“Where’s she going?” Tomas said, very low.

Jakobus watched the small dark figure get smaller against the orange, walking the line as if it were the most obvious thing in the world to do at dusk, as if the answer to *what is it for* were simply *this — for this — for the walking of it, at the hour the desert hardens, toward the water, under the eye that flies* — and he didn’t reach for any of those words, and neither did anyone else.

“To ask,” he said.

And he left it there, in the air, where she’d put it.

Chapter 17 — The Shadow and the Flight

Four-forty in the morning, and the desert was the colour of a thing that hadn't decided to exist yet.

The LENS had been awake since three, which was not insomnia so much as a professional appointment. You did not photograph the pampa at dawn by arriving at dawn. You arrived in the dark and you let the dark teach you where the horizon would be, so that when the light came you were not surprised by it, you were waiting for it the way a fisherman waits with the line already wet. The camera bodies were laid out on the tailgate of the van in the order they'd be needed. The drone sat charged in its case, props folded like a sleeping insect. Beside it, untouched, the little stack of stakes and cord from yesterday's humiliation.

Yesterday they had tried to make a line.

It was supposed to be the easy part. That was the whole pitch of it — no lost technology, no levitation, no men from the cold parts of the sky. Stakes and cord. You drive a stake, you walk the cord taut to a second stake, you sight along it, you scrape the dark stones aside to show the pale ground beneath, and there is your line, ten or fifteen centimetres deep, a wound that heals into a road. The Nazca did it. They left a wooden anchor stake at the end of one, and a laboratory in this century put a date on it. Stakes and cord. A child could grasp the method. The crew had grasped the method.

The crew's line looked like something a worm had done while thinking about other things.

It wandered. It had a confident first ten metres and then a crisis of faith around metre fourteen, where the hydrology-reader had stopped to check a reading and the cord had gone slack and nobody had noticed. The edges were ragged. From standing height it read as a path. From the drone — and the LENS had flown the drone, because of course he had, because he could not let a thing exist unphotographed from above — it read as an apology. Two hundred metres of remorse scratched into one of the flattest, oldest, most patient surfaces on the planet.

And forty metres away, running arrow-straight toward a vanishing point that did not waver, did not breathe, did not have a crisis of faith at metre fourteen or metre fourteen-hundred, lay a line some hands had made in the dark fifteen hundred years ago and never come back to fix.

Oof, said the fish, who lived in the cooler and had opinions. *That's a self-portrait, that is.*

The local archaeologist had watched the whole thing from the shade of the van. Cahuachi-born, field-hardened, the kind of patient that comes from a place where the rain falls for twenty minutes a year and you learn to want things slowly. She had not laughed. That was the worst of it. She had watched the crew sweat and squint and re-stake, and at the end she had crouched by their lumpy furrow and touched the disturbed stones with two fingers and said only, *Now you know what it costs*. Then she'd looked at the old line, the true one, and said nothing at all, and the nothing had been the entire seminar.

This morning she had agreed to walk one with them. Not the potato. A real one.

The light came the way it always came and the way it was never not astonishing — not a switch but a tide, the eastern rim going from grey to the inside of a shell to a hot mineral gold that poured west across the pampa and found every stone. The morning mist that had hardened the crust overnight burned off in threads. The desert turned the colour of a struck match and held it.

"There," the local said.

She stood at the head of a line-type figure — one of the great ones,

the kind that the new survey, the AI one, the Yamagata team with their machine-trained eyes, had filed under wild animals and ninety-metre giants and *not meant for the standing eye at all*. A bird, maybe, or the idea of a bird, drawn so large that walking its outline you could no more see the bird than an ant can see the word it's crossing. The relief-type glyphs, the small ones, the nine-metre figures crouched by the old footpaths — those were people, mostly, the survey said. Eighty-one per cent human themes, hello traveller, here is a man, here is a station on your road. Those you could see on foot. Those were made for feet.

This was not one of those.

"Walk behind me," the local said. "Single file. Step where I step. Don't talk for a while."

The LENS did not walk it.

This was the limit of him and he knew it the way you know a missing tooth with your tongue. He could read the pampa from a thousand feet better than he could read a room from across it — the lines resolving into intention, the figures springing whole out of the noise, the entire vast grammar of the plain laid out like a sentence he'd been born already knowing. But on the ground the lines dissolved. On the ground a line-type figure was just a paler scuff underfoot, a corridor of removed stone, a place where your boot pressed and *marked* it, because it was only ten centimetres deep and the desert was soft and you were always, on this ground, one careless step from adding your own footnote to fifteen hundred years.

So he climbed onto the van roof with the long lens and let them go without him.

The drone he sent up first. It rose into the cold gold air and he watched the feed and felt the old click happen, the one that was the whole reason he was alive and the reason he sometimes could not sleep — the world snapping from chaos into pattern, the figure assembling beneath the camera, the bird that no walker would ever see becoming, from up here, undeniable. A beak. A long impossible neck. Wings held in a gesture older than the alphabet.

And along it, small, the file of human beings.

They went slowly. The local first, then the hydrology-reader, then the two support crew, then Jakobus last because Jakobus was always last, the fixer who read the made thing and never led the reading, who'd looked at this line yesterday and not said *who made it* or *how* but had crouched and squinted along its length and asked the only question he ever asked, the one that opened doors: *what's it for*.

He'd answered his own question the way he always did, which was to refuse to. A map, maybe. A procession, maybe. A road that asked the sky for rain. *A thing*, he'd said, *that's a different thing when you walk it than when you fly it. Some made things are like that. You build them so the answer changes with where you stand.* And then he'd handed it back, the way he handed everything back, stepping out of the frame, deferring to the woman who'd been born in the shadow of Cahuachi and knew the desert the way the desert knew thirst.

From the van roof the LENS watched the file move along the bird's spine, and he keyed the radio. "What is she telling them?"

The hydrology-reader's voice came back low, almost breathing. He'd brought his maps even here — the fault overlays, the puquio positions, the corkscrew aqueducts still pulling water out of the dust after two thousand years, the minority papers, the Johnson lines that tracked the groundwater channels. He had a theory living behind his sternum like a held breath. He had not been able to put it down.

"She's not telling," he said. "She's walking. She says — hang on — she says you can't be told. She says the bird isn't on the ground. The bird's the *walking* of it."

Cryptic, said the fish. *I respect it.*

The LENS swung the drone wide and brought it back low along the line and he saw what the hydrology-reader meant, in the way the LENS saw everything, which was as a shape. On the ground they were not crossing a picture. The picture did not exist for them. They were a procession moving along a corridor of pale stone in single file, in the cold, in the gold light, doing a thing with their bodies — the placing of one foot ahead of the other along a course someone had laid out for exactly this, the long meander of the neck, the turn at the wingtip, the patient kilometre of it. The figure was for the sky. The *walking* was for them.

Two answers. One thing. The hand that made it had not had to choose.

The hydrology-reader broke first, because pattern-finders always break, because the loop never closes and the not-closing itches.

“This one runs to a puquio,” he said over the radio. His voice had the edge it got. “I checked the overlay last night. The neck — where she’s standing now — it points at a fault. The fault feeds the aqueduct two kilometres east. That’s not nothing. That can’t be nothing.”

A pause on the line. Then the local’s voice, and the LENS knew before she spoke that she would out-read him, because she always did, because this was her ground and her dead and her water, and she had let the crew hold the camera but she would never, not once, let them hold the answer.

“Some lines do that,” she said. Even. Unhurried. The voice of someone who had heard the water-map theory before it had a name. “The faults are real. The puquios are real. A man named Johnson walked these and found the overlap, and the overlap is real, and you can stand here and check it with your own maps, and I will not tell you it isn’t there.”

“But,” said the hydrology-reader.

“But Proulx walked them too,” she said. “And the figures point at the dead, and the mountains, and the water, and the rising of things, and each other, and the open desert, and a man can stand at the head of any line and find something it points at, because the desert is large and the lines are many and the human eye is a finder of agreements.” A breath. The file had stopped on the bird’s neck. The LENS held the drone steady. “You want the line to be a map. I understand wanting it. It would be a clean thing to hold. But the cleanest thing I know is this: my great-grandmother’s people walked these to ask for rain. That is not a theory. That is a thing that was done, here, by feet, and the doing of it was the point, and whether the line also marks a fault —”

She stopped.

“— whether it also marks a fault is a question for your maps,” she said.

“It is not the answer to mine.”

The hydrology-reader said nothing. From above, the LENS watched him stand very still on the back of a giant bird, holding his maps, the loop not closing, and not pushing. Not over-reaching. Letting it stay open. There was a dignity in it that the LENS recognised because it was the dignity of someone who has learned the difference between a thing you can prove and a thing you can keep.

Good lad, said the fish, unexpectedly gentle.

Then the sun cleared the eastern rim entirely and the shadows came.

This was the photograph. The LENS had not known it would be the photograph until it began to be one, which is how the photographs that matter always arrive. The low gold light threw the file of walkers into shadows that stretched forty, fifty metres west across the pampa — five human beings made suddenly enormous, their shadows falling across the pale corridor of the line and out onto the dark stone beyond it, so that for one tide of light the people on the ground were *also* drawn on the desert, also vast, also made of contrast and absence, also visible only from above.

The bird made for the sky. The walkers made for the ground. And the shadows — the shadows were the third thing, the thing neither party had built, the thing the morning made of them, the lived and the aerial folded into one frame for the length of time it takes the sun to climb a hand's width.

The LENS shot it. Drone first, the whole figure with the small file along its spine and the long shadows fanning west like the bird had grown a second set of wings out of the people walking it. Then the long lens from the van roof, low and flat, the file in silhouette against the burning rim, their shadows running toward him across the line they could not see and he could not walk.

He did not caption it to himself. He had stopped doing that years ago, in places he didn't talk about, where captioning the thing in front of you was how you stayed sane and also how you stopped feeling it. He just let it come through the glass and into the body and held the body still.

For the length of the shot the limit dissolved. He was a thousand feet up and he was also, for once, *there* — because the shadow was the bridge, the shadow reached from the ground he couldn't walk to the air he lived in and laid the two things across each other, and he understood — no. He didn't understand anything. He saw it. That was the whole of his gift and the whole of his cage. He saw it and could not say it, the same way the walkers walked it and could not see it, the same way the bird existed and could not be looked at, the same way the line ran to the fault and ran to the dead and ran to the rain and ran, arrow-straight, into a vanishing point that fifteen hundred years had not been able to close.

Then the sun lifted a finger higher and the shadows shrank and the bird went back to being for the sky alone, and the file walked on along its neck, asking the desert, with their feet, for the thing the desert almost never gives.

The radio crackled. The hydrology-reader, quiet now, the edge gone out of him.

"Did you get it."

"I got it," the LENS said.

He brought the drone down. Out east, beyond the rim, a low mechanical drone of a different kind — the consortium's machines were waking, their grid-flights beginning, scanning the new glyphs into the cloud, filing what could be filed, claiming what could be claimed. The catalogue would grow today. The mystery would shrink, the way it had been shrinking for a century, honestly, by the work of people who counted and dated and walked and refused to lie.

And the bird would still be for the sky, and the walking still for the feet, and the line would still run to the water and to the dead at the same time and answer to neither, and nobody on this plain, machine or band or keeper, would close it.

The local reached the wingtip and stopped and turned and looked back along the line at the people following her, and then up, once, at the dwindling drone, and lifted one hand — not a wave. An acknowledgement. *You were up there. I was down here. The shadow was both of us.*

The LENS folded the props.

He had the photograph. He did not have the answer. He'd never once had the answer. He had only ever had the shape of the place where the answer should be, and the door of it standing open in the gold light, and the long shadow of someone who knew better walking out across the question without any need to shut it.

Chapter 18 — Water, Stone, Air

The puquio at Ocongalla goes down into the ground like a thought you can walk into.

Mariella reached it first, because she always reached the water first. The hydrology-reader of the crew came over the lip of the spiral in the long copper light and stopped, and the rest of them caught up to find her standing very still at the top of the corkscrew, looking down the stone throat of it as if it had said her name.

A puquio is a trick the Nazca played on the desert and won. From above — and the LENS had shot it from above, that morning, the drone humming up into the windless air — it reads as a green eye in the brown, a spiral ramp of fieldstone walls coiling down to a pool, with a channel running out from the bottom under the pampa toward fields nobody can see from the rim. They built hundreds of these. Some still run. This one still ran. You could hear it: a small, patient sound under the stone, water moving where no rain falls, drawn out of a fault in the rock and walked uphill by gravity and geometry and the stubbornness of people who refused to die of thirst on the second-driest ground on Earth.

Twenty minutes of rain a year. That is the official number for this plain, and it is the kind of number that sounds made up until you have spent a week in it and your lips have cracked and you understand that the puquio is not a monument. It is plumbing. It is the most beautiful plumbing on the planet, but it is plumbing, and people drank from it for fifteen hundred years and people drink from it now, and that is the first thing the place teaches you if you let it: the wonder here is

not separate from the survival. The two are the same object.

The local stood a little back from the rim, letting them have it. She had been letting them have things all week — handing them the moment the way you hand a child the last stake of the kite string, watching to see if they'll hold it level. She was Cahuachi-born, field-trained, the keeper here in every sense that mattered and a few that the consortium's permits did not cover. She had out-read both crews on every ground that counted, quietly, with the particular patience of someone who has watched outsiders arrive certain and leave humbled for thirty years.

(So this is the part where the desert hands over its secrets. I've seen this episode. There's a twist. There's always a—)

The consortium's lights were already on across the plain, a cold blue smear two kilometres off where the field-camp ran its servers through the night. They had their 303 new glyphs now, or rather they had IBM's and Yamagata's, the ones the AI had teased out of the noise — the little relief-type figures by the old footpaths, nine metres across, humans and llamas and odd-armed dancers crouched where a traveller would have passed them on foot. Roadside shrines, more or less. Stations of something. The consortium wanted to scan the rest, claim the dataset, license the meshes. Clean hands. Good lawyers. Not villains — just a force, the way water is a force, finding the low ground of whatever the law had failed to fence off.

They were welcome to it. That was the thing Mariella had stopped being able to say out loud, because saying it felt like surrender, and it wasn't surrender, it was the opposite. They could have the data. The data was the easy part. The data was the potato.

She thought about the potato now, standing at the rim, because she could not stop thinking about it.

Three days ago they had tried to make a line. The honest experiment. Stakes and cord, the way the Nazca did it, the way the wooden anchor stake — the one they radiocarbon-dated at a line terminus — proved they did it. No mystery, no machinery. You set a stake, you sight along the cord, you set another, you pull the cord taut and you clear the dark stones off the surface to the pale ground beneath. Ten centimetres deep. A boot can mark it. A child could clear it. There is nothing in

the method a Bronze Age shepherd couldn't do in an afternoon, and that is exactly, precisely the problem, because Mariella's line had come out *wrong*.

Not crooked, even. Lumpy. The crew had laid forty metres of it across a permitted scratch-patch the local had walked them to, and from the ground it had looked fine — fine enough, a pale stripe in the red — and then the LENS had flown the drone up and they had all crowded around the little screen and laughed, because it wobbled. It bellied out in the middle like a swallowed snake. The edges feathered. It was, unmistakably, a thing made by people standing on it, looking along it, getting it almost right.

And then the LENS had panned the drone fifty metres left to the real line, the ancient one, and it ran arrow-true to the horizon, four kilometres of it, dead straight across a curve of land it could not possibly have seen the end of, made — the wooden stake says — by hands that had no way to fly. Made in the dark, some of them. Made by feet, for eyes that don't have feet.

That was the hole. That was the whole shape of the hole, and the consortium's AI hadn't closed it and Maria Reiche's lifetime of survey hadn't closed it and Mariella's wobbling forty metres of potato had only made it deeper: *how do you draw a perfect line for a viewer you will never be?*

She had said as much to the local, after, embarrassed, brushing red dust off her knees. The local had looked at the potato on the screen for a long moment.

"Yours is honest," she'd said. "It looks like it was made by a person. Theirs—" a tilt of the chin at the true line — "looks like it was made by the desert itself. That's the part people can't forgive."

(See, NOW we're getting somewhere. Made in the dark, perfect from the sky, runs straight over a hill it can't see past. Cue the spooky music. Cue the runway theory.)

But the runway theory was dead and they all knew it was dead, and the niceness of this place, the genuine intellectual relief of it, was that you could hold the dead theory in your hand and feel why it died. Von Däniken's runways: the ground is soft. Ten centimetres of armoured crust over dust. A boot marks it. A bicycle would gouge it. The idea

that anything heavier than a person ever landed here is refuted by the simple fact that the lines are still here at all — they survive *because* nothing has driven on them, because the morning mist hardens a skin over the cleared ground and the air does not move enough to scour it. The preservation is the disproof. The miracle and the debunk are the same fact, again.

And the stars. Hawkins ran it in '73, Aveni ran it again in '82, lined the glyphs up against the rising and setting points of everything in the sky, and got nothing. About one in five lines pointed at something celestial, which is what you'd expect from one in five lines pointing at *anything*, because there are a great many lines and the sky is full of points. No calendar. No observatory. The tour guides still say it, gently, because tourists love a calendar, and the local let them say it because correcting a stranger's wonder is a kind of cruelty and she was not cruel. But it isn't true. The science caught up. Most of the mystery got eaten.

Most.

Mariella crouched at the rim of the puquio and put her hand flat on the warm stone of the spiral wall and listened to the water she could not see, running out under the desert toward a field, drawn from a fault in the rock.

A fault in the rock.

She had a map in her bag — her own, hand-drawn, overlaid, three weeks of it — and she did not take it out, because she had taken it out enough times this week and every time the local had looked at it with the same patient affection and not said *no* and not said *yes*. The minority view. Johnson's overlay, the one the textbooks file under *interesting, unproven*: that some of the lines — not all, not most, *some* — track the geological faults that channel groundwater to exactly these puquios. That a fraction of the great straight lines run where the water runs.

Proulx and the mainstream say correlation. The faults are where the water is and the puquios are where the water is and the people are where the water is, so of course the lines cluster near water — everything clusters near water in a desert; you might as well be amazed that the houses do. The lines aren't a *map* of the water. They're a *prayer* about it. Ritual, processional, tied to fertility, to rain, to the

dead. Walked, not read. Not a diagram. A devotion.

And that was almost certainly right. Mariella believed it was right. She had read Proulx until she could hear his dry good sense in her sleep.

But nobody had closed it. That was the cold, checkable, un-sneered-away fact at the bottom of the spiral. The correlation between the lines and the faults that feed the puquios is *real* — it is in the literature, it is measured, it is not fringe and it is not proven — and the strong version of it, the one Mariella wanted, was a minority position held open by the one thing science can never quite kill, which is a pattern that keeps showing up and keeps refusing to mean.

“You’re listening to the water,” the local said.

Mariella didn’t turn. “It comes from the fault.”

“It comes from the fault.” The local came to the rim and crouched beside her, easy on her heels, a person who had crouched at this rim ten thousand times. The light was going. The plain had begun to do the thing it does at dusk, the dark stones drinking the last red and the cleared lines holding it a moment longer, so that across the pampa the geoglyphs glowed faintly paler than the ground for the length of one held breath, the whole vast figured surface surfacing like something rising in water, and then it was gone and the lines went to shadow and the cold came up out of the ground.

“You want me to say the lines lead to the water,” the local said. Not unkind. “You’ve wanted me to say it all week.”

“I want to know if it’s true.”

“That’s not the same thing.” The local picked up a pebble, dark, iron-stained, one of the millions cleared and never cleared, and turned it in her fingers. “You found a real pattern. I’m not going to tell you it isn’t there — your professor is wrong if he tells you it isn’t there. It’s there. Some lines run where the water runs.” She set the pebble down. “And I’m not going to tell you it’s a map, because a map is a thing you read instead of going. And nobody here ever read these instead of going.”

*(Okay. Okay, so it IS a water map, she basically just—
(...no, she didn’t.)*

“When the rain doesn’t come,” the local said, “which is most years, which is nearly every year, you walk. My grandmother walked. You go out before the mist burns off and you put your feet on the cleared ground and you walk the line, the long one, the straight one, and you walk it to the water — not because the line tells you where the water is. You already know where the water is. The puquio is right there. You walk the line because walking it is how you ask. The walking is the asking.” She looked at Mariella, and there was something in it that was not a lesson, that was just a woman telling another woman a true thing at dusk. “You walk it to remember the ones who walked it before the water came that one good year. You walk it because if you stop walking it the desert stops being a place people belong to and goes back to being a place that kills you. The line holds the desert together. Not the stone of it. The *us* of it.”

The water ran under them, patient, drawn from the fault.

“So is it a water map,” Mariella said, very quietly, and she heard how small the question was and asked it anyway.

The local stood. She brushed the dust from her knees the way they all did now, the way the place taught your hands to do.

“It’s for rain,” she said. “It’s for the dead. It’s for keeping. You can write that down.”

And she did not say whether the line that ran to this puquio ran here because someone surveyed the fault, or because the water and the prayer and the dead had simply pooled in the same low place the way everything pools, and Mariella understood that she was not going to say, and that it was not because she didn’t know.

It was because the answer the local had was a better answer than the one Mariella had come for, and it left the smaller question exactly where it had always been, alive at the bottom of the spiral, running, real, uncited at the one point that would settle it.

Across the plain the consortium’s lights burned, scanning the surface, building the mesh, claiming the data, getting all of it and missing the only part that mattered because it could not be flown over or filed.

The LENS came down off the dune behind them with the drone folded in its case and stood at the rim and looked into the puquio, and for once said nothing about the air. Jakobus stood off at the road as

he always stood, off home ground, the made thing read and handed over, the moment given away. The water went on under the stone toward the field nobody could see.

Mariella took out her map and looked at it one more time in the last of the light. The lines. The faults. The little corkscrew eyes of the puquios. The pattern that wouldn't close.

Then she put it away, and stood, and walked the line back toward the van — to the water, or away from it, depending which way you read a thing that was made to be walked.

She didn't read it.

She walked it.

Chapter 19 — Potato in the Rearview

The van had a name. Somebody had keyed it into the dust on the rear door three days ago — *LA PAPA*, the potato — and nobody had washed it off, partly because washing it off would have required water, which on the Nazca pampa is a theological proposition, and partly because we'd earned it.

I'm the one who packs the van. That's my role on this outfit: I count things, I coil things, I make sure the thing we paid four hundred dollars for in Lima does not get left under a folding chair in a desert that gets twenty minutes of rain a year. So I'll tell you what leaving looked like, from the inside of the count.

Six stakes. We came with twelve. Don't ask.

Four hundred metres of mason's cord, recoiled badly, because the Hydrology-reader had used it to walk a transect at four in the morning and had not recoiled it at all, had in fact left it in a loose nest in the footwell where it had become, overnight, a single tactical knot the size of a sleeping cat. I put the cat in a crate. Some problems you transport.

And the line. Our line. I want to be honest about our line, because the whole point of us was supposed to be honesty.

Here is how you make a Nazca line. The official answer is not a riddle. You take a long straight surface that has been waiting nineteen centuries under a crust the morning mist re-hardens every dawn, a crust that armours the desert like skin on warm milk. You note that the

surface is two things stacked: a top layer of reddish pebbles, iron-oxide-dark, patinated by the sun into something close to rust; and beneath it, ten to fifteen centimetres down, a pale subsoil the colour of old bone. You remove the dark. You pile it at the edges. The line is the contrast. That's it. That's the whole magic trick — no advanced tools, no lost technology, no anything. Stakes and cord. They radiocarbon-dated a wooden anchor stake at the end of one line and it came back exactly as humble as the method: somebody drove a peg, ran a string, and walked.

We had stakes. We had string. We had, between us, a combined education that included two degrees and a man who can read a river's whole grammar off a satellite tile. We picked a flat scrap of permitted ground well off the protected glyphs — the Local had marked it for us herself, with a kind of patient generosity, like a parent letting a kid help carry the groceries — and we made a line.

It came out a potato.

I mean that with love. It started true for maybe thirty metres, where the LENS had sighted it and we'd all been very serious and held the cord taut and stepped carefully. Then the ground does what ground does. A stone wants to come up with its neighbours. Your boot, which is enormous, which is a continent compared to the precision you're attempting, kicks a pale scar where you didn't mean one — because the lines are only ten, fifteen centimetres deep, and a boot marks the pampa as easily as a thumbnail marks clay. By a hundred metres our line had a slight, embarrassing drift, like a sentence written by someone falling asleep. It bowed. It wandered. It had what the Hydrology-reader, who is incapable of unkindness, called "character."

From the ground it looked fine.

From the ground everything looks fine. That's the thing nobody tells you. You stand on the pampa, you sight down your own crooked line, and your eye forgives every wobble because your eye is at one and a half metres and the error is happening in a dimension you can't see.

Then the LENS went up.

She flew the drone low and slow, and we crowded the little screen in the killing flat light, and there it was: our line, *LA PAPA* made manifest,

lumpy and apologetic, drifting off true like a drunk leaving a bar. And not three hundred metres beyond it, in the same frame, in the same merciless overhead glance — one of theirs. A real one. Arrow-straight for as far as the frame held it and presumably a great deal further, because some of these run kilometres without flinching, across dry washes and low rises, holding their bearing the way a laser holds a bearing, made — the consensus says — in something like a single working session, by people who are gone, whose names we will never have, whose surveying instrument was a peg and a cord and an eye and, apparently, a steadiness we could not buy with all our gear.

The LENS didn't say anything. She doesn't, much. She sees the world from above and she has trouble walking down into it — that's the deal she made somewhere over a war a long time ago, and the camera is the part of her she keeps asking us to help her put down. But she looked at the two lines in one frame, ours and theirs, the potato and the blade, and something moved in her jaw.

(The fish, surfacing: nineteen centuries of mist hardening the crust every single morning, and your boot. Your one boot. Maybe leave the surveying to the professionals, hey. The dead ones.)

We laughed at ourselves. That's allowed. That's required, actually. The official story holds — that's the part people don't expect from a show with our reputation. The lines are made by people, by hand, with nothing we couldn't buy at a hardware store, in service of things we largely understand. The 2024 work out of Yamagata, the AI survey that swept three hundred and three new figures out of the noise, didn't deepen the mystery so much as sort it. Two kinds of glyph, two kinds of audience. The little relief-type ones, nine metres, forty-odd metres off the old footpaths, four out of five of them human-themed — roadside stations, things you'd pass at walking pace, things made for the feet. And the big line-type figures, ninety metres, mostly wild animals — communal, vast, the famous ones. Not one unified secret. A landscape someone *organised*. The science caught up. It mostly won. We were the ones, this time, who got out-built by Iron Age farmers with string.

I packed the potato's stakes. Six of them. I did not pack the line, because you cannot pack a line; you can only leave it, a faint pale wandering wrongness on a plain full of true ones, where the next mist

will start, very slowly, the long work of forgetting us.

Across the pampa, the consortium was also packing. They pack better than we do. They had cases — foam-cut, numbered, climate-something — and a logistics person with a tablet who checked items the way I check items, and I felt a flicker of professional kinship I did not entirely want to feel.

They got what they came for. I won't pretend they didn't. Their drones and their scanners and their cloud of compute swept the plain and pulled more figures out of it than human eyes had found in a century, and that's real, that's good work, that catalogue is bigger because they came. The trouble was the part after the finding. The part where the data goes into a pipeline that has a patent office at the end of it. You can't patent a two-thousand-year-old monkey. But you can patent the *method* — the detection model, the workflow, the way you teach a machine to see a glyph in a satellite tile — and you can lock that, and license that, and the next people who want to look at this desert might have to come to you for the lens.

The Local had a word for it that I won't translate because translating it would flatten it. Their team had filed nothing, claimed nothing, fenced nothing. They had spent the week the way they spend every week: out on the pampa at dawn, walking, before the tourists, before the heat, before us. Keeping the count of a different ledger.

She came to see us off. The Local. Cahuachi-born, field-trained, the only person on that plain who'd never once been surprised by it. She'd out-read both crews all week without ever making a show of it — had stood at our potato with her hands in her jacket pockets and her face doing something kind and unreadable while we discovered, live, that this was harder than it looked. Had stood at the consortium's bank of screens and seen, I think, exactly how much they had and exactly what they were missing, and had said nothing there either.

The Hydrology-reader couldn't let it go. Last morning, of course he couldn't. He had his folded map, soft at the creases now, and on it the thing that had been eating him all week: a line — one of the real ones — that ran, if you let it, toward a puquio. Toward one of the spiral aqueducts that still, *still*, corkscrew down into the dead-dry ground and pull living water up out of it, the most quietly astonishing

machines on the whole plain. And not just that line. A handful of them seemed to lie along the faults, the cracks in the bedrock that channel groundwater to those very spirals. He'd traced it and traced it and never quite closed it.

"It tracks," he said. He wasn't pushing. He's not a pusher. He just couldn't stop seeing it, because seeing patterns nobody asked him to see is not a thing he can switch off; it's how he's wired, it's the whole reason he's worth bringing. "Some of them. They run with the water."

The Local nodded. She didn't wave it away. That's the thing I'll remember about her — she never once waved anything away.

"Some do," she said. "Proulx would tell you correlation. The lines are ritual, processional, about water as a *prayer*, not water as a *pipe*. You walk them to ask. Not to find."

"And you?"

She looked at him for a moment. Then she looked out at the plain, where the light was just starting to do the thing it does, turning the whole flat world from grey to gold in about ninety seconds, the lines coming up out of the ground like the desert was developing a photograph of itself.

"Nobody has closed it," she said. "That's the honest answer. The strong version — lines as a literal map of the water — that's a minority. But nobody has *closed* it." She let that sit. "You want me to tell you it's nothing. I won't tell you it's nothing. I also won't tell you it's the thing you want it to be."

(The fish, quietly, for once: she just handed you the exact shape of the hole and refused to fill it. That's the most generous thing anyone's done all chapter.)

The other one she gave us without our asking, which is how I knew she'd been deciding all week whether we'd earned it.

We were loaded. La Papa was packed, the cat-knot crated, the potato left behind to fade. The LENS had her last drone in the air for one final pass, and she was filming the Local, who had walked out a little way onto a true line — not to demonstrate, not for us, just because that's

what she does at dawn — and the long blue shadow of her stretched out down the line behind her across the gold plain, a single human figure inside a figure made for nobody to stand inside, a thing made for the eye of the sky walked by a body on the ground.

And there it was. The hole the whole week kept circling and never sewed shut. If the little relief glyphs were for travellers — sized for the footpath, themed for the human passer-by, stations you'd meet at walking pace — then fine, those are for feet. Understood. Solved, near enough. But the great ones. The ninety-metre animals. The figures that only resolve, that only *become* what they are, when you leave the ground entirely — from a hilltop if you're lucky, from the air if you're us. Who were those for? Made by feet that could never, in any single lifetime, climb high enough to see what those feet had made. Made for an eye that nobody on that plain possessed.

The science has an answer, and the answer is good, and it is not quite the *whole* of the thing, and the Local would be the last person to pretend otherwise.

She didn't pretend. She walked the line, slow, her shadow walking it with her, and she didn't explain it, and that was the explanation — that to walk the line *is* the answer, that the question "who was it for to look at" might be the wrong question asked by people who only know how to look. You don't look at it. You *go along* it. You ask for the rain. You hold the desert together with your feet. The looking is ours, the flying is ours, the wondering is ours. The walking was hers, and the dead's, and it always had been.

The LENS brought the drone down. Got it. Got the shadow, the figure, the whole impossible geometry of a body in a thing made for the sky. She held the screen out to show me and her hand was steady and her face was, for once, on the ground with the rest of us.

I shut the van door. *LA PAPA*, said the dust on it. I left that, too.

We pulled off the pampa as the gold went white and the heat came up to take the day. In the side mirror the Local was a small dark mark on a pale plain, standing on a line that ran arrow-true to a horizon we'd never measured, near a puquio that still ran water, along faults nobody had closed the book on.

The consortium had their data. We had our potato. She had the

lines, whole, the way she'd had them when we landed and the way she'd have them after every one of us was gone.

What the long ones are for, looking up. What runs along the water, and why. Nobody had closed it.

She didn't turn to watch us go. She was walking. She had somewhere to ask the rain.

Chapter 20 — The Maybe That Remains

The fire was small because there was nothing to burn. Jakobus had scavenged a crate's worth of broken stakes and a fence-post some farmer had given up on, and it burned mean and fast, the way dry things do, throwing more light than heat into a cold that came down off the pampa like a tide. We sat in the ring of it on the edge of the dark, and beyond the dark the lines lay where they had lain for fifteen hundred years, not glowing now, not anything now, just stone next to slightly different stone, waiting for a sun that hadn't been invented yet to tell them apart.

The consortium's lights were on across the plain. You could see the camp from here — a hard white smear, a generator's grumble carried thin on the still air. They'd be packing tonight too. They'd gotten what they came for. Three hundred and three new figures the AI had pulled out of the ground, and a folder of derived data, and whatever a lawyer in another time zone could make of it. Clean hands all the way down. Nobody had stolen anything. That was the part that kept catching in the LENS's teeth, I think — that you could lose a thing nobody took.

"You're brooding," the hydrology-reader said.

"I'm composing," the LENS said. "Loss looks better composed."

The fish — and yes, there is a fish, there is always a fish, the heckling part of us that won't let the chapter end pretty — said: *You flew over the most photographed dirt on Earth and you're sad about it. Get a hobby.*

The LENS had flown over it. That was the whole problem, and the gift,

and the limit, all in the one motion. From the air the pampa is legible. The straight lines run true for kilometres, dead-reckoned across dry riverbeds and over ridges as though the ground were a sheet of paper and the maker had a straightedge as long as the horizon. The trapezoids open like fans. The hummingbird, the spider, the monkey with its absurd spiralled tail — they resolve at altitude into something almost unbearably deliberate, a hand reaching up out of the dirt to wave at whatever flew. The LENS had spent a career learning to read the world from above. Up there the lines confessed everything except the one thing.

Down here, on foot, the LENS could barely find a line at all.

That was the joke we'd been living inside for three weeks. We had tried, early on, to make one. Stakes and cord — the actual method, the boring true method, the one the radiocarbon stake at the line terminus had confirmed, no aliens required, no levitation, no lost laser. Hammer a stake. Run a cord. Walk it, lifting the dark iron-oxide pebbles off the top ten centimetres and setting them aside to show the pale ground beneath. The contrast is the line. That's it. That's the whole technology. A child could do it. We had a crew of adults with a satellite phone and a drone and a fixer who'd built airstrips, and we made a line forty metres long, and from the air it looked like a worm that had been stepped on. Lumpy. Drunk. A potato.

The hydrology-reader had photographed our potato next to a relief glyph the ancients had cut maybe a hundred steps off the old footpath, one of the small ones, nine metres, a little human figure with its arms out. Theirs was crisp. The edges were true. Fifteen hundred years of being walked past, misted on, baked, and the line still held its nerve. Ours had been laid that morning by people who'd watched a YouTube video about the technique, and it wobbled like a confession.

"What kills me," the hydrology-reader said now, turning a cold coffee mug in both hands, "is that the method isn't the mystery. We *proved* the method. The method's a stick and a string. And it still came out wrong."

"You did it once," Jakobus said, from outside the firelight where he liked to sit. He never sat in it. He sat at the edge, where he could see the rest of the dark. "They did it for six hundred years. A line is not a thing you make. It is a thing you keep making." He let that go

where it wanted. He didn't fish it back.

The local was the last to come to the fire. She'd been up at Cahuachi most of the evening — there'd been a thing with the preservation committee, a thing with the tourist road, the kind of thing that doesn't end so much as get postponed. She sat down across from the LENS, took the offered cup, and looked into the fire for a while before she said anything, which was her way. She out-waited everybody. She'd out-waited us for three weeks, letting us run at the lines with all our cleverness and our kit and our hunger to *solve* the place, and never once correcting us in a hurry, because the place had been here long before our hunger and would be here after.

"You're leaving in the morning," she said.

"We are."

"And you got what you came for."

The LENS thought about that. "I got photographs."

"You got photographs," she agreed. There was no edge in it. "They got data. Everybody got something to carry away. And the lines are still here." She blew across the coffee. "That's the part people from outside have the hardest time with. Not that the lines are mysterious. That they're *not for you*. You can stand on the ground a figure was cut into and it isn't about you at all."

The fish, quieter now: *She's not wrong, you know.*

We had come, like everyone comes, half-believing in a secret. And here is the honest part, the part the chapter owes you straight: the secret has mostly been found. This is the thing the wild years got wrong and the patient years got right. Hawkins ran the alignments in '73, Aveni ran them again in '82, and the stars don't fit — only about a fifth of the lines point at anything in the sky, which is exactly the fraction you'd get by throwing lines down at random. Not a calendar. The runway thing, von Däniken's runway thing, the thing that put Nazca on a thousand bedroom posters — the ground is ten, fifteen centimetres of loose pebble over soft subsoil. A boot marks it. You could ruin a "runway" by walking your dog across it. Nothing was landing here that didn't have wings of its own.

And the new work, the 2024 work, the AI that the consortium's whole

business model is downstream of — that work *answers* things. It sorted the glyphs into kinds. The little relief figures, the nine-metre ones, sit a stone's throw from the old footpaths and they're mostly people, mostly human scenes — roadside shrines, near enough, ritual stations you'd pass and pause at on foot. The big line-figures, the ninety-metre animals, sit out where you'd gather, and they're mostly wild creatures, and they were made to be walked, to be processed along, a community moving its body through a shape. Two different machines for two different prayers. Not one grand unified riddle. A working landscape of devotion. Most of the mystery, dissolved into something better than mystery: into meaning.

"So it's solved," the LENS said, and didn't mean it, and the local knew the LENS didn't mean it, and let the LENS hang there a second before she answered.

"Most of it," she said. "Yes. The science caught up. I'm glad it did. I'm tired of the spaceships." A small smile. "My grandmother walked these. She didn't think she was on a runway."

The hydrology-reader had been quiet, which for the hydrology-reader meant working. The water had never let go. From the first day, traced from the air and confirmed on foot, there'd been a handful of lines — not most, a minority, the honest minority — that ran toward the puquios. The puquios: those corkscrew aqueducts spiralling down into the dust, ancient and *still working*, still pulling water up through a hyper-arid plain that gets twenty minutes of rain in a year. Engineering you could touch. And some of those lines tracked the geological faults that channel the groundwater to feed them. Johnson had argued the lines were a water map. Proulx and the mainstream had argued back: correlation, not function — the lines are ritual, water-*symbolic*, prayers about water, not diagrams of it.

"I keep doing the math," the hydrology-reader said. "And the math says she's right." A nod at the dark, where the consortium's mainstream-approved certainties hummed. "Most lines, no water under them. The ones that align, you'd expect some to align by chance. Proulx is probably right. The strong version's a stretch."

"But," the local said.

"But nobody's closed it." The hydrology-reader set the mug down. "That's the thing. I can show you why it's *probably* not a map. I can't

show you it *isn't*. The faults are real. The puquios are real. The lines that run to water are real. The correlation is real. It's a minority view, it's contested, and it is *not refuted*. It just sits there. Real and unproven, both at once. I keep waiting for it to resolve and it won't."

The fire popped. Somebody's stake giving up.

"And the other one," the LENS said. The LENS's one. "The figures you can only see from the sky."

This is the hole that doesn't go in your pocket. It survives every debunk because no debunk is even aiming at it. The relief glyphs make sense on the ground — they're roadside, they're sized for a walker. Fine. But the great line-figures, the spider and the monkey, the ones a kilometre across, the ones that take altitude to read as anything but a path — those were made by people who never flew. Who could not, in any literal sense, see the finished thing they had made. You walk a Nazca animal and you experience a line. You fly it and you experience an animal. The shape was for an eye that didn't exist on this plain until a Peruvian Air Force pilot, twenty-some centuries later, happened to look down.

"That one I don't try to close," the local said. "Anyone who tells you they've closed that one is selling something." She glanced, not unkindly, at the white smear across the dark. "It's not a mystery the way the spaceships were a mystery. There's no missing technology. We know who, we know how, we mostly know what for. But you walk a figure you can't see and you tell me it doesn't ask a question." She turned the mug. "You make a thing for the eye of the sky. Then you walk it with your feet. Both true. I don't need to choose."

This is where she's supposed to give you the answer, the fish whispered. Lean in. Here it comes. The secret of Nazca, ladies and gentlemen.

She didn't give us the answer. She gave us less and more than that.

"At dawn," she said, "I'll walk you one. The big one, by the path. You've flown all of them. You haven't walked one with someone who walks them." She wasn't offering to *explain*. She was offering to let us be wrong in our bodies for an hour, the way you can only be wrong in your body, the way the camera can't be wrong because it never has to stand on the ground. "You ask what they're for. To walk one is

to ask for rain. To walk one is to remember the people who walked it before you, who are under the same dust. To walk one is to hold the desert together for one more morning, because if nobody walks it the desert wins and the line goes back to being stone.” She set the cup down. “It’s not a code I’m withholding. It’s a thing you do. I can’t give it to you in a sentence because it isn’t a sentence. It’s a morning.”

The LENS, who reads the world from above, who can see every line on the pampa and cannot walk a single one straight, didn’t say anything for a long time. The fire had gotten low. Across the plain the consortium’s generator cut out — they’d shut down for the night, having extracted what could be extracted, leaving on the table the only things that mattered, because those things won’t fit in a folder.

“I always thought the camera was the gift,” the LENS said finally. “Being able to see the whole.”

“It is,” the local said. “It’s just not the only one.”

Jakobus, from the dark, said one thing, and then he handed the morning to her and to us, the way he always handed the moment off, the road and not the lead: “A made thing answers a question its makers had. Not always a question we have.” A beat. “The trick is you don’t get to choose which question.”

We sat with that until the fire was coals.

Here, then, is the door, and we are going to leave it open, because the house rule and the honest rule are the same rule. The science caught up. The stars don’t align. Nothing landed. The method is a stick and a string, and we proved it by failing at it, and the failing taught us more than the proving — that what they made wasn’t a technology but a discipline, six centuries of hands keeping a line true. Most of the mystery has dissolved into something better, into a working landscape of feet and prayers and water carried up out of the dust by spirals that still run.

But a minority of those lines still walk toward water through faults that feed the puquios, and the strongest version of what that means is a stretch nobody has refuted. And the great figures were cut, with perfect nerve, by people who could never stand far enough back to see them whole — made for an eye in the sky that wouldn’t open for

fifteen hundred years.

Correlation, the mainstream says. A prayer, not a map. Probably. Almost certainly.

We are not going to tell you it's a map. We are not going to tell you it isn't.

In the morning the LENS would go up one last time and photograph a shadow — the local's, walking, stretched a hundred metres across the gold as the sun came level, a single human body moving along a line made for the sky, asking for rain. And the photograph would be from above, where the whole thing reads, and the asking would be down on the ground, where the camera can't go.

Both true. She didn't need to choose.

Neither, it turns out, do you.

Chapter 21 — Real / Debated / Invented

This is the part of the file where we open the drawers and let you check the locks yourself.

A dossier is not a verdict. It is a map of what we are allowed to be sure of, drawn with a cold pen, and the honest ones admit where the ink runs out. So here is the pampa laid flat on paper: what is bedrock, what is still being argued over coffee in Lima and Nazca and Yamagata, and what we made up — because some of this chapter you held in your hands was true the way a photograph is true, and some of it was true the way a memory is true, and you deserve to know which was which.

The fish, who has read ahead, would like it noted that he found the dead stake very moving and will be insufferable about it.

REAL

The lines exist and you can stand on them.

They lie on the Nazca and Palpa pampas of southern Peru, and they are not engraved, not carved, not burned. They are *subtraction*. The desert floor wears a skin of pebbles gone reddish-brown from iron oxide, a patina baked on over centuries, and someone — many some-ones, c. 400 BC to AD 500, the Paracas and then the Nazca — lifted those stones aside, ten to fifteen centimetres down, to the pale sub-soil underneath. The line is the contrast. Dark removed; light re-

vealed. The whole gallery is the same gesture repeated at the scale of a continent: *move the stones, show the ground*.

This is checkable. It is also the single fact that strangles the alien-runway story in its crib, and we will get to that.

The method was stakes and cord. No lost technology. No power tools, no lasers, no anti-gravity. Wooden stakes driven at line termini have survived; one was radiocarbon-dated, which is how we know roughly *when* as well as *how*. You could do it. We tried to do it (see: the potato), and that humbling is in the file too.

Maria Reiche is real and she earned her place. From 1940 onward, the German-born mathematician walked the pampa with a broom and a measuring tape, mapping, sweeping, sleeping in a shack, fending off developers and tyres, turning a curiosity into a protected wonder. Much of what the world knows it knows because one woman refused to let the desert be paved. If you take nothing else from this chapter, take her.

The 2024 PNAS study is real and it is the best thing to happen to Nazca scholarship in a generation. Sakai and colleagues — Yamagata University, with IBM and the German Aerospace Center, DLR — ran AI over the imagery and surfaced 303 new figurative glyphs. The numbers matter, so here they are without rounding into legend:

- *Relief-type* glyphs: smaller, averaging around nine metres, clustered near ancient footpaths (within roughly forty-three metres of them), and 81.6 percent of them depict human or human-related themes.
- *Line-type* glyphs: enormous, averaging around ninety metres, and 64 percent of them are wild animals.

The conclusion is the quiet bombshell. There is no *single* Nazca mystery. There are at least two registers, doing two jobs: small roadside images you encounter on foot, like stations along a pilgrimage, and vast communal figures laid out for the group, for the procession, for the sky. The relief glyphs are for the traveller. The line glyphs are for the gathering. The lumping of all of it into one unsolved riddle was always a tourist's flattening.

The climate is the curator. The Nazca plain is among the driest

and most windless surfaces on Earth — on the order of twenty minutes of rain a *year*. Morning mist settles and hardens a crust over the cleared ground, an invisible armour that has held these subtractions in place for fifteen hundred years and more. The lines survive because nothing happens here. The desert preserved them by doing nothing, beautifully, for two thousand years.

The puquios are real engineering. Corkscrew spirals of stone descending into the ground, ancient and *still functioning*, drawing water up through the dust to fields that have no business being green. Walk down into one and the air changes; the desert is breathing through a straw it dug itself. The puquios are not a theory. They are infrastructure, working, today.

The calendar idea was tested and it failed the test. This is important, because the test is the honourable thing. Gerald Hawkins ran the alignments in 1973; Anthony Aveni ran them more thoroughly in 1982. If the lines were a great astronomical clock pointed at solstices and risings, the alignments should cluster. They don't. Only about twenty percent align with anything celestial — no better than you'd get by throwing lines at random across the sky. The "Nazca calendar" is not suppressed or covered up. It was measured, and it came up short, and good scientists said so. The fish notes that this is what losing a round honourably looks like, and that the calendar people took it on the chin like adults.

The ground is soft. Ten to fifteen centimetres deep is all the line is. A boot leaves a mark. A car leaves a scar that lasts a generation. Hold that fact; the next section needs it.

DEBATED

The water correlation is real. What it *means* is not settled.

Here is the live wire, the one the debunk never quite snipped.

David Johnson observed that some lines appear to track geological faults — faults that channel groundwater underground to feed the puquios. Lay the line map over the fault-and-water map and a subset of the lines does not scatter at random. It follows the water. This

overlap is documented. It is the checkable thing, and it sits there on the pampa not asking your permission to be tidy.

The mainstream reads it the careful way, and the careful way is strong. Donald Proulx and the weight of Nazca scholarship hold that the lines are *ritual and processional* — paths walked in ceremony, bound up with water and fertility because in a desert that gets twenty minutes of rain a year, *everything* is bound up with water. Lines point toward water-related ritual the way a cathedral points toward heaven: not as a map you navigate, but as a prayer you enact. Correlation with the faults, in this reading, is the residue of a people whose whole sacred life orbited the question of whether the water would come. Of course some lines run toward water. The lines and the water are made of the same fear.

That is not a dodge. It is the better-supported reading, and we hand it to you with respect.

But notice what it does and does not do. It explains *why* lines and water might cluster. It does not *close* the minority claim that some specific lines functioned, in some practical sense, as marks on the land tied to where the water actually runs. The strong version — “the lines are a water map” — is a minority position, contested, not endorsed here. The weak version — *some lines track the faults that feed the puquios, and nobody has fully explained every one of them away* — is just a fact lying in the sun. The case is not closed. It is merely well-argued on one side. Those are different things, and the difference is the whole game.

The visibility paradox is named, not solved.

The relief glyphs sit by the footpaths, sized for a person walking — the 2024 study made that plain. Fine. But the great line-figures, the ones the size of a stadium, the spider and the hummingbird and the monkey with its spiralled tail: their full form resolves only from altitude. From the ground you walk a path; you do not see the bird. The crew felt this in their boots and the LENS proved it from the window of a small plane.

The mainstream answer is sober and probably right: you did not *need* to see the whole figure. The *making* was the act. The *walking* was the act. The figure was offered upward, to the mountains, to the sky, to whatever held the rain — and being seen entire by a human eye

was never the point. The gods, presumably, fly.

That is a fine answer. It is also an answer that quietly concedes the figures were built to be *whole* for an eye that no human in that culture could occupy. We don't reach past that toward little grey men; the ground is too soft for anything to land on (see below), and von Däniken lost this argument fifty years ago. We just decline to pretend the strangeness isn't there. A people made enormous, precise images that they themselves could only ever experience as a path beneath their feet. That is true. What it was *for* is theirs.

INVENTED

We will be plain about our fingerprints.

The crew is composite and the chase is staged. There was no race to a named glyph at dawn against a named consortium; AI surveys of the pampa are real and ongoing, the catalogue genuinely grows, and the tensions around data, access, and preservation are real — but our particular outfit with its particular drones is a dramatic vehicle, a clean-handed adversary built to make a true argument about who gets to own a desert's secrets. The greed is plausible. The specific greedy people are ours.

The potato is invented in its details and honest in its result. The wobble of stakes-and-cord in modern hands, the lumpy line photographed from above against the flawless ancient ones — we composed that scene. But the *lesson* of it is sound: replicating a Nazca line is harder than the easy story implies, and the ancient lines really are crisp and true across kilometres. The humbling is real even where the staging is not.

The dawn walk is the deepest invention. What it *feels like* to walk a line as the desert goes gold, the shadow of a body stretching across the pampa while the LENS photographs it from above — that is rendered, imagined, built to put you on the ground. We invented the feeling so you could stand inside a true place. That is the contract of this whole series: the facts are armour-plated; the experience is offered, labelled, as a window, not a witness.

And the local archaeologist — Cahuachi-born, field-trained, out-reading both crews — is a composite who carries something we did not invent and could not. The dignity is not ours to stage. Real Peruvian archaeologists keep these lines, argue these readings, and resist the over-mapping and the tyre-tracks and the patent-hunger. When our local declines to hand over a tidy answer — when she walks the crew along a figure at dawn and gives them the *act* instead of the solution — she is doing what the people of that pampa have done for decades: holding the lines whole, and holding the meaning where it belongs.

GAZETTEER

The pampa, in brief, for the reader who wants to stand somewhere specific.

Cahuachi — the great ceremonial centre south of the Nazca River, adobe mounds and plazas, the brooding heart the lines seem to lean toward. Not a city. A place people came to, and left.

The puquios of Nazca and surrounds — the corkscrew aqueducts, some still feeding fields. Cantalloc, the most visited, where you can walk the spiral down toward the water table and feel the temperature drop.

The line-figures — the hummingbird, the spider, the monkey, the condor, the “astronaut” (a relief glyph on a hillside, named by a wink, not a doctrine). Stadium-sized, sky-offered, foot-made.

The relief glyphs — smaller, roadside, human-themed, the 2024 cohort among them. The ones you’d have met on the path. The ones that were always for you, the walker.

The footpaths — older than tarmac, the threads the relief glyphs hang on, the evidence that this was a landscape you *moved through*, not just looked at.

FURTHER READING

Start with Anthony Aveni, *Between the Lines* — the calendar-tester turned humane interpreter, the steadiest hand on the whole subject. Donald Proulx for the ritual-and-water mainstream. The 2024 PNAS paper by Sakai and colleagues for the AI cohort and the two-register reading; it is technical and worth the climb. Maria Reiche's own writings for the founding devotion. And David Johnson's water-and-fault work, read as the minority position it is — because the honest reader checks the side that didn't win, too.

Von Däniken you may skip, or read as folklore — a document of what the 1960s wanted the desert to be. The fish says read it last, in good light, with someone to laugh with.

The dossier closes here, and it closes the way the pampa does — open.

We can tell you, with the cold pen, how the lines were made and roughly when and by whom, and that the sky was never a runway and the stars never a clock. The science caught up; most of the wild theories went down honestly, in the daylight, by measurement. That is the official story and it largely holds, and we gave it its full due because it earned it.

But the water still runs under some of those lines toward the spirals that still draw it up, and nobody has explained every one of them away. And the great figures are still whole only from an altitude their makers could not reach, offered upward into a windless sky that has not rained on the answer in two thousand years.

We are not going to tell you what those two things mean. The people who keep the pampa have not told us, and it was never ours to be told. They walk the lines instead — to ask for rain, to remember the dead, to hold the desert together one more season — and they let the meaning live in the walking rather than the solving.

So we hand it back the way it was handed to us: armoured against the easy lies, and wide open at the one place that matters. The lines are real. The water is real. The walking is real.

The why is theirs to keep, and yours to wonder at.

That is the humility the desert teaches, and it is the last word.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor